GET FOUND

The No-Fluff Guide to Ranking Higher and Becoming Your Customers' First Choice

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Cover and text design by Jazmin Welch

Proofread by Lucy Kenward

Paperback ISBN: 978-1-0688264-0-5

Ebook ISBN: 978-1-0688264-1-2

Also available in audiobook.

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Acknowledgments

First and foremost, to my wife, Ali—thank you for always keeping me honest. You read two pages of my first draft and said, "You can do better." Then you sat with me for months while I rewrote it. I appreciate your endless patience, support, and drive to do better. Love ya, poo.

To the HeyTony team—your support, feedback, and behind-the-scenes help made all the difference. This book wouldn't be what it is without you.

And to everyone who's followed along with my journey—whether through my videos, emails, or posts—your encouragement and support gave me the confidence to write this book.

We're just getting started.

Introduction

I'M SO EXCITED THAT YOU'RE HERE because I've seen firsthand how the concepts in this book can change everything. Over 30,000 people have taken my courses, and many of them have used what you're about to learn to grow their business, increase profits, and get back to doing work they actually enjoy.

Whether you stumbled across this book out of curiosity or you're actively searching for a way to get more website visitors, more leads, and more customers, this is where it all begins. Search Engine Optimization (SEO) isn't just some technical marketing trick; it's one of the most powerful tools you can use to build an online presence that works for you 24/7. And the best part? It's something you can learn, apply, and see real results from without spending a fortune.

I wrote this book for anyone looking to master SEO, whether you're a complete beginner or someone with experience who needs a refresher or a spark of inspiration. My goal is to break down complex concepts into simple, actionable steps so you can confidently optimize your website and grow your online presence.

If you're wondering whether this book is right for you, let me make it simple: SEO is a powerful marketing strategy that helps your website show up higher on search engines like Google and Bing. If your goal is to increase your visibility and attract more visitors, then this book is exactly what you need.

By the time you finish this book, you'll have the confidence and knowledge to apply these SEO techniques to your website and see real improvements. These aren't just theories; I've used these strategies to grow my own

business and help my clients succeed. And I've seen countless business owners who follow me on social media achieve the same results.

Take Ahmed, a doctor in Dubai who was struggling to bring patients into his clinic. His business was a year old, and he knew he needed a way to attract more people. He had heard of SEO but didn't fully understand how it worked. Hiring an expert wasn't an option; his budget was tight. So, he had only one choice: learn how to do it himself.

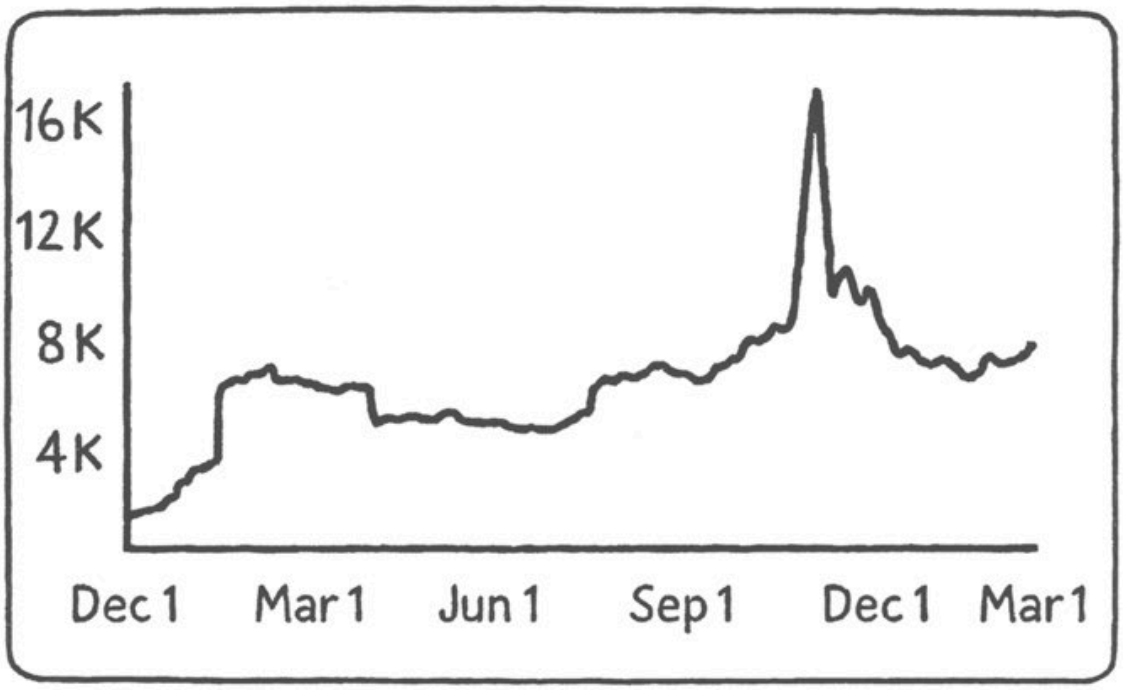
With nothing but free online resources, he set out on his SEO journey. But like most people, he was overwhelmed. Blog posts were too long, YouTube videos were too vague, and every SEO "expert" seemed to have a different opinion. Then something unexpected happened: He came across a video on Instagram. It was short, clear, and immediately actionable—exactly what he needed in that moment. No fluff. No jargon. Just a simple breakdown of what to do and why it mattered. SEO finally started to make sense to him.

That video? It was one of mine.

From that moment on, he went through my entire backlog of free social media content, making notes, and got to work. Within a few short months, the results started rolling in. And not just a handful of visitors—his website was now attracting over 8,000 visitors per month.

Ahmed shared his story with me during a Zoom call I was hosting to help entrepreneurs better understand SEO. At one point I asked if he had ever paid for any of my resources. He smiled and said, "Nope. Not a dime."

And I loved that. Because more than anything, I loved his results. I loved his results so much I had to share a screenshot with you.



Here's a screenshot of his estimated website visitors over the last 16 months. In November 2023, his website was getting exactly zero visitors. By January 2024, that number had skyrocketed to over 8,000 visitors per month. While his visitors have fluctuated over the past year, he's consistently maintaining around 8,000 monthly visitors, ranking for powerful keywords like "doctor near me," "general practitioner Dubai," and "medical care in Dubai." This is the power of SEO in action.

Ahmed's story isn't unique. Over the past few years, I've watched thousands of business owners take control of their SEO, put in the work, and completely transform their businesses. They didn't wait for someone else to do it for them. They learned, they applied, and they dominated their niches. And now, it's your turn.

If you're reading this book about SEO, I'm guessing you fall into one of two categories: Either you're an entrepreneur looking to grow your business or you're someone working for a company and you're eager to sharpen your skills, land a promotion, or make yourself an indispensable asset.

Either way, good for you! Taking the initiative to learn SEO is one of the smartest moves you can make, and I'm excited to help you along the way.

If you're an entrepreneur, I feel you. I really do. Not only do you need to be top tier in your niche, you also need to become a marketer. This involves working additional hours after your work day to ensure that people will buy from you tomorrow. And on top of that, there is no certainty that what you're working on will actually bring in new customers or clients.

Thankfully you picked up this book, and by the end you'll have a clear roadmap that has been used by thousands of people all over the world.

If you're working for a company and looking to brush up your skills, I've got some good news for you. Not only will this book help you learn more about ranking on search engines, but it will also help you understand how to create quality content, regardless of the platform, which is the basis of all marketing.

No matter which category you fall into, there's one thing you need to understand: Marketing takes time and patience. If you're expecting instant results, you're setting yourself up for disappointment. SEO, like any effective marketing strategy, requires consistency and commitment. But if you're willing to put in the work, the rewards are more than worth it.

After a decade in the SEO world, I've had countless conversations with business owners who wanted to invest in SEO but needed results fast. They were on the brink, hoping for a last-ditch effort, a quick fix, a silver bullet to save their business. And honestly? That's not what SEO is. SEO isn't an overnight solution; it's a long-term strategy that, when done right, delivers sustainable growth that no ad spend can compete with.

I have a lot of rules in my agency when it comes to taking on clients, but the number one rule is that we do not take on clients who are in this type of situation. We can't help them and we're not in the business of taking money from those we cannot help. Every client we work with has to commit to working with us for a minimum of 12 months. That is how long it can take to see results when it comes to ranking. I wish it didn't take so long to rank, but search engines do this for a reason, which we'll explore in more detail later in the book.

I don't say this to discourage you from doing SEO, far from it. In fact, the impact SEO can have on a business is truly life-changing. And not just for the business owner, but for everyone the business touches. It's not just about increasing revenue; it's about creating jobs, fueling local economies, and making a real difference in people's lives. When a business thrives, it lifts up an entire community, and that's the power of SEO.

People often overlook the fact that marketing, especially SEO, is the foundation of any successful business. Without it, there's no steady flow of customers, no predictable growth, and no solid ground to stand on. Unless your product is so exceptional that it sells itself without any effort (I promise you it won't), you need a strategy that keeps your business visible and thriving.

A pattern that I've noticed throughout the years that never really made sense to me is that when times are tight, marketing is the first thing that gets cut. And when times are good? Marketing is *still* the first thing that gets cut!

This became glaringly obvious when Covid hit the world in 2020.

When it hit, a dozen clients emailed me to cancel their SEO services, services that were crushing it for them! Most were healthcare providers, dentists, doctors, therapists. They couldn't see patients, and therefore couldn't make money, so marketing was the first expense to go.

I get it. You're thinking, "If they're not making money, how can they pay for marketing?" But here's what everyone missed: Their competitors were thinking the exact same thing.

While everyone was panicking and pausing their SEO services, I saw an opportunity. Instead of encouraging my clients to take their foot off the gas, I boldly suggested they accelerate. Like the classic story of the tortoise and the hare, this was the perfect time to blow past their competitors and dominate search results.

It took some convincing (and a few flexible payment plans), but the clients who stayed the course with SEO saw their revenue double within a few months. By the end of the year, one client was so overwhelmed with new business that they had to pause our services. They were turning customers away! When they eventually resumed, it was on a scaled-back basis because they were already coasting on the momentum we had built.

So remember: When you're thinking about cutting marketing, *don't.*

I promise you, if hiring an agency isn't in your budget, you can still learn and implement SEO yourself. In fact, it's something you, your parents, and even your grandparents can grasp. The key is breaking it down into simple, actionable steps.

Unfortunately, many marketers want you to believe SEO is rocket science. It's not. The secrecy and gatekeeping by so-called "experts" is exactly why I decided to write this book: to show you that SEO isn't just for professionals, it's for anyone willing to learn.

After a decade of working in SEO and thousands of conversations with business owners, I keep hearing the same basic questions:

"What's a title tag?"
"Why do we need blog posts?"
"What's alt text?"
"What's a backlink?"
"Why are you so damn good looking?"

Okay, I threw that last one in for fun, because SEO should be fun, not some boring technical nightmare!

If you don't know the answers, it's not your fault. It's the failure of digital marketers who can't (or won't) explain SEO in simple terms. The irony? A huge part of good SEO is making content so clear and simple that a 12-year-old could understand it.

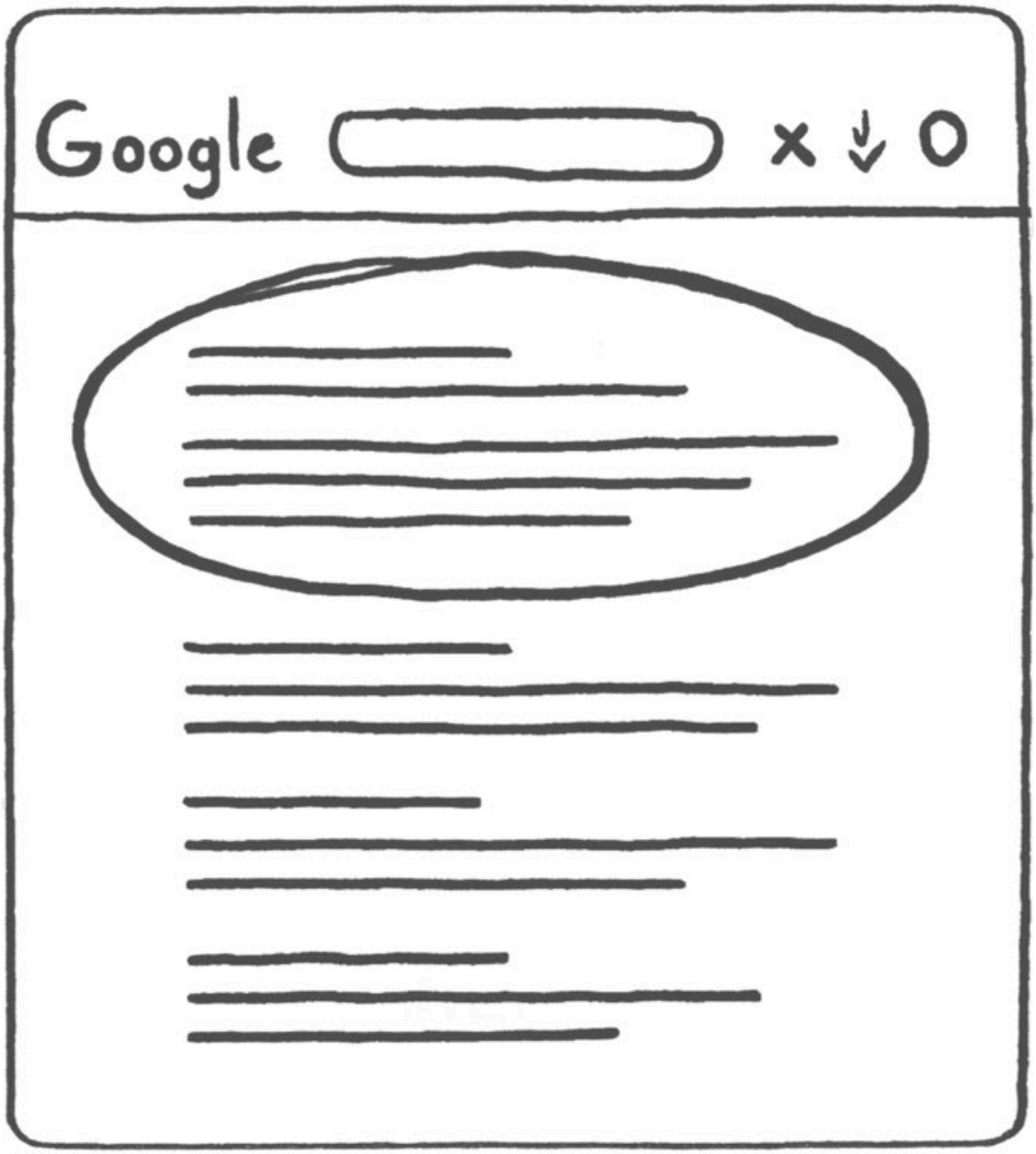
This book isn't written like a textbook or VCR manual (remember those?). Think of it as a conversation between friends... via text. Simple. Easy. Fun. To the point.

So let's actually get to the point: You're reading this because you want your website to rank higher on search engines like Google. To make that happen, we need to understand the key elements that go into SEO.

Let's start at the very beginning.

What Is SEO?

Search Engine Optimization is the process of optimizing your website to appear (aka rank) higher in search engine results, making it more visible to potential visitors.



If you're new to SEO, that definition might seem a bit abstract, so let's take a step back to the late '90s, when SEO was born.

Before the internet, people used something called the Yellow Pages to find local businesses. It was a massive printed phone book delivered to homes and businesses once a year. Inside, it listed companies by category, like “Plumbers” or “Pizza Restaurants,” along with their phone numbers and addresses. If you needed a service, you’d flip through the Yellow Pages and call the business that stood out. It was basically Google… in book form.

Fun fact: Ever noticed businesses with “AAA” at the beginning of their names? That’s because the Yellow Pages listed companies alphabetically, and being first in the directory meant more calls. Even then, businesses were finding ways to “game” the system to get noticed.So when Google opened to the public in 1998, what do you think the first thing smart businesses did? They scrambled to figure out how this new digital directory worked, and more importantly, how to get their website to the top of the list. But unlike the Yellow Pages, where adding AAA to your name was enough, Google had a completely new, uncharted system to understand and leverage.

And that’s exactly what SEO is, learning how search engines rank websites and using that knowledge to position your business ahead of the competition.

SEO is about making your website and content better so when someone searches for what you offer, your site shows up higher in the results.

Why Should You Care About SEO?

If you’re still unsure whether SEO is worth your time, here are a few compelling reasons why investing in SEO can be one of the smartest moves for growing your business:

- **Google can be your wingman.** Google is trying to be the world’s best matchmaker, connecting people with exactly what they’re looking for. When you position yourself as the best option, Google does the heavy lifting, introducing you to a steady stream

of potential customers who are already looking for what you offer.

- **People are ready to buy.** People searching on Google aren't just browsing, they're on a mission. They're actively looking for a solution and are ready to take action. In marketing terms, this is called "high purchase intent." They're like hungry tourists with a hankering for Italian food. They know what they want and are just looking for the best place to get it.
- **It's perfect for penny pinchers.** Not every business has deep pockets for advertising, especially small businesses. But with SEO, a massive budget isn't a requirement to get noticed. With smart strategies and persistence, you can level the playing field and compete with bigger companies that spend a fortune on marketing. (We help our clients do this all the time!)
- **Rankings = Built-in trust.** With SEO, you're not shouting, "BUY THIS!", you're subtly saying, "Hey, I have exactly what you're looking for." People hate being sold to, but they love to buy, especially from businesses they trust. And when you appear at the top of search results, that's exactly what you build: trust and credibility.

Now that we're aligned on just how powerful SEO can be for your business, it's time to break down the three core types of website SEO.

The 3 Types of Website SEO

At its core, SEO is about getting your website to rank higher on search engines like Google and Bing. But SEO isn't limited to just websites, many other platforms have their own search functions. Take Amazon, for example. There are specific strategies to rank your products higher on Amazon, but that doesn't necessarily mean those products will rank well on Google. The same applies to platforms like Pinterest, YouTube, and even TikTok.

In this book, we're focusing on website SEO, and when it comes to that, there are three main types you need to know:

1. **On-Page SEO (aka on-site SEO):** These are all elements that you have full control over: the words, images, videos, links, and tags on your website. Think of it like a house. You may not be able to build one yourself from the ground up, but you can change the paint color, rearrange the furniture, swap out the door handles, and make it your own. The same goes for optimizing your website.
2. **Off-Page SEO:** These are the elements you can't directly control, like getting other websites to link to yours, earning customer reviews, or having people share your content on social media. You can influence them, but ultimately, they're in the hands of others.
3. **Technical SEO:** These are the behind-the-scenes elements you can control. Think of it like tuning up a car, making it run smoother, more efficiently, and ready for the road. In SEO terms, that means optimizing your site's speed, ensuring Google can crawl (find) all your pages, making it mobile-friendly, and handling all the technical details that keep it performing at its best.

Here's the bottom line: SEO isn't just a buzzword, it's a game-changer. It's your chance to grow your business without spending a dime on ads. Whether you're a total beginner, running a small local shop, or aiming for global domination, SEO can be the secret weapon that sets you apart.

> **P.S.** Need extra help? To access a video series packed with visual references and real-world examples, visit https://getfoundbook.com/seo/.

PART I

ON-PAGE SEO

PROLOGUE

The Power of On-Page SEO

IN MY SECOND YEAR AT ST. CLAIR COLLEGE, studying advertising and marketing, I was your typical broke college student dreaming of making it big in the industry. But patience wasn't my strong suit. I didn't want to wait until graduation to start making money, I wanted to put my skills to work right away. Back then I saw opportunity in almost everything.

It was an early April morning. I was on my way to college and saw a dumpster sitting in an empty lot. You know the kind, those big bins people rent during home renovations to toss in old cabinets, drywall, and debris before a truck hauls it away a few days later.

Without thinking, I slammed on the brakes and pulled over. I had an idea. No, the dumpster wasn't overflowing with gold bars or stacks of cash, but to me, it was something even better. I saw an opportunity.

I jotted down the bin rental company's name from the side of the dumpster and went on my way. I was going to turn that garbage into cash.

I searched online extensively but found nothing. No website, no listings, no trace of the company anywhere. So, I called the number I had written down from the side of the bin.

A man answered. As I stumbled through my first-ever cold call, I managed to get out the words: "I noticed you don't have a website. I can help with that." Nothing fancy. No SEO talk, no mention of Google or making more money, just a simple observation and an offer to help. I could tell he was hesitant. He said he'd have to check with his wife, but they weren't really looking for a website right now.

I hung up, defeated. My dream of turning my newfound knowledge into cold, hard cash was dead.

Or so I thought.

A few weeks later, while wrapping up my semester, I got a call from an unknown number. It was the bin rental guy! His wife had told him they did need a website, and that they should hire me. Turns out she knew my mom from childhood. In fact, she knew my entire family. It was both a blessing and a curse. On one hand, I had built-in trust; on the other, there was no room for mistakes.

We scheduled a meeting at their house to discuss what they needed. As I pulled into their driveway, nerves hit me. I had never done anything like this before. But I was in my early 20s and cocky. I hadn't prepared a thing for that meeting, but hey, I had already closed the deal, right?

After some small talk, I asked the big question: "So what do you want on your website?"

"We'd like pictures of our bins and trucks. Oh, and diagrams showing the dimensions of each bin. And the types of things people can and can't put in them."

Great! "Do you have pictures and diagrams you can send me?"

"No."

"Okay, no problem! Do you have descriptions of what people can't put in the bins?"

"No."

I had already quoted them a price without knowing the scope of the project. Classic rookie mistake.

The only thing they really knew was that they wanted to show up for "Rubbish Removal" when someone searched on Google. Great. They were hiring me for a website and now I had to do SEO too!?

Luckily, I had taken two classes relating to SEO and loved it. As I was leaving, I confidently told them I'd have their website done in a week. (Note: NEVER tell a client you can have ANYTHING done in a week. But when you're young, hungry, and have literally no other clients or commitments, you can make those kinds of promises!) The only task I gave them was to take some photos of their truck and bin and email them to me.

A few days later, I got the photos. They were out of focus, grainy, and poorly angled. I had some work to do. Now, I had to build an entire website

from scratch, write all the text, transform their low-quality images into something usable, and optimize everything for search engines. At the time, the only thing I really knew was on-page SEO, the exact topic we're covering in this first section of the book. So, I stuck to what I knew and got to work.

One week later, their website was live. They were ecstatic. I got paid. And just like that, I was officially a marketer.

I didn't expect what happened next. I drove by that lot almost every day and started noticing more and more bins just sitting in the lot. My first thought? *Oh no! They were going out of business. No one was renting their bins anymore.* I tried calling them to check in, but couldn't get through. The phone was always busy. *The phone was disconnected. It must be. There's no way they're always on the phone when I call.* Finally I got through.

"Matt! How are you?"

"Uhh, I've seen a ton of bins in the lot and haven't been able to get through to you! I thought the phone line might be disconnected. Is everything okay?"

It turns out the website *was* working. That basic on-page SEO I had done had shot them to the top of the search results. Their business had exploded. They went from 11 bins for rent to over 100. That's over a 1,000% growth rate—but who's counting? I watched this couple go from renting a small apartment to owning a home big enough to host family gatherings with spare bedrooms for their grandkids. And to top it all off I built their entire website for just $500, which meant that after countless hours of work, I ended up making far less than minimum wage.

For them, that $500 was life-changing. And for me? It was proof that I could turn this skill into a real business. I had just made money out of thin air, and I knew this was only the beginning.

That is the power of SEO and ranking higher on Google.

CHAPTER 1

Introduction to On-Page SEO

WELCOME TO THE EXCITING WORLD OF ON-PAGE SEO! This section is the longest in the book, and for good reason. On-page SEO consists of a ton of individual elements, and mastering them can have the biggest impact on your search rankings.

We'll break down each element in detail, with every key component getting its own mini-chapter. By the time you're done, you'll have a clear roadmap to optimizing your site for maximum visibility.

A quick recap: On-page SEO is made up of elements on your website that you can control. Meaning these are elements that you can edit yourself; like words, images, and links.

Before we dive in, let's talk about why on-page SEO matters. Without content on your website, search engines have no way of understanding what your site is about, so how can they connect you with the right searchers? Think of it this way: If you're an accountant, your website will likely have pages about taxes, payroll, and bookkeeping. That content tells search engines, "Hey, this site is about accounting." Without it, there's nothing for Google to work with, making it nearly impossible for your site to show up in relevant searches.

Without content (and on-page SEO) it's almost impossible to rank. This is why on-page SEO is the most important part of SEO.

All of these elements feed into algorithms, the secret formulas search engines and social media platforms use to decide what content gets seen and what gets buried. These algorithms are constantly evolving, but the fundamentals remain the same. And that's exactly what we're covering in this book, the core building blocks that will help you rank.

How Algorithms Actually Work

Whether you realized it or not, that's why you're here, right? You want the shortcuts, the secrets, the edge that helps you outrank your competition, steal their website visitors, and dominate search results. So, let's talk about how algorithms really work. And not just Google's, but Instagram's, TikTok's, YouTube's, all of them.

Every platform (search engines, social media sites, etc.) has one main goal: to keep users engaged so they don't leave for a competitor. That's the big secret! If you can help a platform achieve that, it will reward you with visitors, views, and engagement: the whole package.

While social media platforms want to keep people scrolling endlessly, search engines exist to send people away, to the best possible answer for their question. Take Google, for example. Its entire mission is to connect users with the most relevant, high-quality answers. When it does that well, people keep coming back, trusting Google every time they need information. So, if you consistently provide the best content in your industry, you'll automatically rank #1, right?

Well… not exactly. While great content is the foundation of SEO, there's a lot more that goes into ranking at the top. And that's exactly what we're about to dive into.

CHAPTER 2

Content

BEFORE WE GET INTO CONTENT STRATEGY, let's recap what content actually is. It's everything on your website, from the words and images to the videos and links that shape the user experience. These elements should be present on every page of your website. When you intentionally incorporate words, images, videos, and links, you're not just filling space, you're creating high-quality content that search engines and users will love.

High-quality content is well written, easy to understand, and effortless to skim, making it simple for users to find the information they need. It provides the most complete, in-depth coverage of a specific topic while incorporating personal experience and expertise. Most importantly, high-quality content doesn't just inform, it solves a problem.

In late 2022, Google introduced new guidelines aimed at improving user experience. Known as E-E-A-T (Experience, Expertise, Authoritativeness, and Trustworthiness), these principles outline what Google expects from website owners to ensure high-quality, trustworthy content.

Google is becoming more selective about what it considers "helpful content," and for good reason. Their entire mission is to keep users coming back instead of turning to other search engines. By prioritizing high-quality, genuinely useful content in search results, they ensure a better experience for their users and maintain their dominance in the search game.

Yeah, I know what you're thinking: "There's still plenty of junk in search results!" But trust me, they're working on it!

So what is "helpful content?" Think of it like being the go-to person on a specific topic. Let's say you're writing about "The best grass for dogs." Your website should cover everything:

- Pros and cons of different grass types
- Which grass types are safe for dogs to eat
- How well each type of grass handles dog urine and waste
- Grass types that recover quickly from digging and wear
- Dog breeds that might have issues with certain grasses
- Best drought-resistant grasses for dog owners
- How to prevent yellow spots from dog urine on grass

While you could cover all these points in a single piece of content, it would likely be too long and overwhelming, defeating the purpose of being helpful. Instead, a better approach is to mention related topics briefly and link to other content that dives deeper into those topics, making it easier for users to find exactly what they need. This is a concept we'll go more in depth on later in the book; these practices are called topical mapping and internal linking. This is where E-E-A-T comes in.

Google wants your personal experience in your content. It makes it unique.

Think about it: Who would you trust more?

- Someone who just rewrites existing articles about dog-friendly grass OR
- Someone who's spent 20 years working with dogs and different types of grass

Think of it like this book: Anyone can write about SEO, but it's my personal stories, case studies, and real-world experience that make it unique and genuinely helpful. These elements not only make the content more engaging but also build trust, showing that I've actually lived what I'm teaching.

High-quality helpful content keeps users on your page longer, signaling to search engines that your information is valuable. Your content should do one of two things: answer a question or solve a problem. Don't just fill space. Provide information people can actually use. Longer content that really digs into a topic typically ranks higher. (More on word count shortly.)

Fun fact: In his book *They Ask, You Answer*, Marcus Sheridan explains how he used this exact strategy to build a 9-figure business.

In 2008, during the economic downturn, small businesses were suffering, laying employees off, and shutting down; things were no different for Marcus. His company, River Pools and Spas, based in Richmond, Virginia, was struggling. No one was buying pools.

With a very limited (non-existent) marketing budget, he asked himself, "What can I do right now, that costs no money, to help my business survive?" The answer was blogging. In the evenings, after his wife and kids went to bed, Marcus sat at his kitchen table answering questions his customers had asked him. Questions like:

"How much does a fiberglass pool cost?"
"Fiberglass vs. concrete pools—which is better?"
"What are the problems with fiberglass pools?"

He did this diligently for 18 months, pumping out 2–3 blog posts per week, and in 2009 he started to see inquiries come in. He had taken a leap of faith and trusted the process, and it was starting to pay off. Inquiries would often include comments like "I read every article on your site."

And by 2010 Marcus's blog posts were dominating the search results for almost every major pool-related question. By being overly helpful to his potential customers, Marcus took his business from the brink of bankruptcy to being one of the top fiberglass pool installers in the country.

> I recently had the privilege of interviewing Marcus. Visit https://getfoundbook.com/marcus to watch!

To truly understand the power of blogging, we need to rewind all the way back to the 1990s. Yes, that far back. Blogs, originally known as "web logs," have been around for decades. In those early days, they were more like digital diaries, spaces where people shared personal thoughts, opinions, and life updates with little structure and even less fact-checking.

Fast forward to today, and blogs have evolved into one of the most important tools in digital marketing. They're no longer casual musings; they're strategic, purpose-driven content pieces. Today's blogs are well researched, fact-checked, and carefully written with a clear goal: to provide valuable information to people actively searching for answers.

And the results speak for themselves. For most websites, blog posts are the primary driver of visitors. They're the front door through which potential customers discover your brand, learn about your expertise, and take the first steps toward becoming paying clients.

Think of every page on your website, blogs included, as a door to your business. The more doors you have, the more opportunities people have to find you.

Recently, I was speaking with a potential client who asked, "Is blogging still worth it?"

I told them about Amy.

Amy runs a beautiful, blooming flower shop. Her business was doing well, but online, her local competitors were crushing her business on Google. She had already spent thousands with another so-called SEO "agency" over several months and had nothing to show for it. No visitors, no leads, no results.

Then she hired us.

Our strategy? Focus on creating genuinely helpful blog posts to bring in targeted visitors.

Here's what happened:

Before working with us: 1,000 visitors per month
Month 1: 1,100 visitors (a small bump)
Month 2: 1,300 visitors (still modest)

Amy was understandably skeptical. After all, she'd already been burned by another SEO "expert." But then everything changed.

Month 4: 5,000 visitors per month
Month 8: Over 9,000 visitors per month

Amy was over the moon. Her revenue doubled, and we achieved it primarily through one thing: blog posts. That's right: consistent, helpful, keyword-targeted blogging. Blogging didn't just work for Amy. It transformed her business. The simple act of sharing your expertise online can dramatically boost your website visitors and rankings. As for Amy, it's been 3 years and her business is still growing year over year.

Blogging has another not-so-obvious benefit: topical authority. Topical authority is when Google (or any search engine) sees you as a trusted expert on a specific subject. If you're consistently writing about plumbing, it becomes crystal clear to search engines that you're a plumber.

Here's the thing: People are getting tired of self-proclaimed "experts." Have you been on Instagram lately? You've got twenty-somethings selling courses about "how they got rich." The world needs fewer of those and more real experts sharing actual experience and knowledge. That's exactly what search engines reward: genuine expertise.

Blogging doesn't just drive traffic, it also boosts the performance of the pages that really matter, like your product and service pages. These are the pages that make you money, and blogging can help them rank higher by building overall topical authority.

But that's just the beginning. Blogging also opens the door to powerful SEO strategies we'll explore later in the book, like internal linking, earning backlinks, and executing content marketing campaigns that bring long-term results.

The Truth About Word Count

One of the first questions I get asked is, "How long does my blog post need to be?"

While longer content often performs better, there's no magic number that guarantees a top spot in the search results. I've seen pages with just 400 words outrank pages that are double or triple that length.

My general rule? Aim to have slightly more content than the page currently ranking #1. There's no need to go overboard and tack on an extra

thousand words, just focus on being a little more helpful and complete than your competition.

Take this section as an example. I could write several more pages on the topic, but the goal is to get to the point and keep it helpful. Or, as Kevin from *The Office* would say, "Why waste time say lot word when few word do trick?"

Making Your Content Easy to Understand

Someone once told me: It's dumb not to dumb it down. And since then I've made that my motto.

The purpose of having a website and creating content is simple: to get people to buy what you're selling. But the more complex your content is, the fewer people will actually understand or stick around long enough to care. The real power lies in making complex ideas simple. If you can showcase your expertise using clear, everyday language, you'll reach a much wider audience.

If people can't understand your content, what's the point in publishing it? Your writing should be clear enough for anyone to get it. Take one of our clients, for example, a team of plastic surgeons. They understand that if their website only used technical terms like "subglandular placement" or "capsular contracture," they'd risk alienating a large portion of potential patients. Most people aren't searching for those terms, they're searching for terms a regular person would likely know. By simplifying their language and focusing on what real people are actually searching for, they're able to attract and connect with a much larger audience.

When it comes to readability, the go-to metric is the Flesch Reading Ease score, developed by Rudolf Flesch in the 1940s. It's a mathematical formula used to predict the difficulty of adult reading material. In short, it measures sentence length and word complexity.

Which of the following statements is easier to understand and read?

> "She exhibited a jubilant demeanor."

"She looked really happy."

It's like the difference between a 5-page contract full of legal jargon and a simple sentence that says, "Here's the work we'll do, and here's what it'll cost." Both say the same thing, but one just makes it easier to understand.

Most modern readability tools use the Flesch Reading Ease or the Flesch-Kincaid Grade Level, which is similar to the Flesch Reading Ease score but it outputs a U.S. school grade level (for example, Grade 8).

Installing a free plugin like Yoast on your website will automatically analyze your content and give you a readability score. It'll also flag if your writing is too complex or difficult to understand, so you can make improvements before hitting publish. Yoast has been my go-to plugin for over a decade, and readability is just one of the many things this plugin does.

The goal? Write so clearly that even a 12-year-old could understand it.

Remember, it's dumb not to dumb it down.

Can You Use AI to Write Quality Content?

Writing high-quality content can be time consuming and, at times, frustrating. Until recently, your only option was to sit down and start typing from scratch. But now, thanks to AI tools like ChatGPT, you can create content much faster.

But here's the big question: Will that content actually be helpful, and will it rank? As any marketer loves to say… it depends. It depends on how you're using AI to create content.

If you're asking ChatGPT to "write a blog post about the benefits of a high-protein diet" and then copy-pasting the result straight onto your website, don't expect great rankings (or to really help your audience).

But if you're using AI as a starting point, to brainstorm, structure, expand on your original ideas, or clarify your message, you're far more likely to end up with content that's useful, unique, and capable of ranking well on Google.

Here's what Google actually says about AI-written content:

"Google's ranking systems aim to reward original, high-quality content that demonstrates qualities of what we call E-E-A-T: expertise, experience, authoritativeness, and trustworthiness."[1]

"Not all use of automation, including AI generation, is spam. Automation has long been used to generate helpful content, such as sports scores, weather forecasts, and transcripts. AI has the ability to power new levels of expression and creativity, and to serve as a critical tool to help people create great content for the web.

This is in line with how we've always thought about empowering people with new technologies. We'll continue taking this responsible approach, while also maintaining a high bar for information quality and the overall helpfulness of content on Search."[2]

AI-generated content came in fast, and seemingly out of nowhere, forcing search engines to adapt just as quickly. Tools like ChatGPT can produce content that's so polished it's nearly impossible to tell if it was written by a machine or a human expert. That's exactly why Google doubled down on promoting high-quality content that demonstrates the key principles of E-E-A-T.

At my agency, HeyTony, we've been using AI since the very beginning. We started by testing it on our own website, just to see if Google would penalize us for using AI-generated content. When we realized it was not only safe but also a powerful way to produce high-quality content quickly, we began integrating it into our client work. Quick note: We weren't just repeating information that already existed online—search engines don't like that. Instead, we took our clients' real-world stories and insights and wove them into the content, creating something original, valuable, and genuinely helpful.

The results? A huge boost in efficiency. We saved time, reduced costs, and were able to take on more clients without expanding our team, all while keeping profitability at sustainable levels. In the past few years alone, our clients have seen millions of website visitors, many of them engaging with content created, at least in part, with AI.

> Click here to get access to a tutorial showing you how to use AI to write content.

CHAPTER 3

Keywords

BY NOW, YOU'VE GOT A SOLID UNDERSTANDING of why content matters for SEO, and not just any content, but genuinely helpful content.

I wish it were as simple as just writing something useful and calling it a day. But the truth is, there are several other elements that need to come together to make content truly SEO-friendly and it all starts with keywords.

Keywords are the words and phrases people type into search engines to find what they're looking for. Helpful content is naturally full of keywords, so let's talk about what that means for you. Think about the topics you'll cover.

Understanding and using the right keywords in your content is crucial because it helps search engines match what people are searching for with the most relevant content (hopefully yours!).

Before we get into the types of keywords, there's one important concept you need to know about first: search volume.

Search volume tells you how many times a specific keyword is searched for, usually shown as a monthly average. It's a crucial part of choosing the right keywords because it helps you focus on the terms people are actually typing into Google.

When it comes to keywords, they can be categorized by length, user intent, or attributes. Having a grasp on these categories will allow you to choose the right keywords to use in your content depending on your goal.

Let's start with the "length" category.

Keyword Categories: Length

Keyword length can be broken down into two subcategories: short-tail keywords and long-tail keywords.

Short-tail keywords

Short-tail keywords are shorter, more generic keywords that have higher search volumes but WAY more competition. They're typically 1–2 words long.

Think of keywords like "dog" or "running shoes." See how broad these terms are? What specifically are you looking for when you search for "dog"? Dog toys? Dog food? A specific breed of dog? And when you search for a broad term like "running shoes," are you looking for Nike running shoes, Adidas, or something completely different?

Since so many people search for these broad keywords, there's tons of competition, which makes short-tail keywords *really* hard to rank for. If you are just starting out with SEO, I highly recommend *not* focusing on short-tail keywords to drive traffic to your website.

But don't worry! That doesn't mean you can't show up in search results when someone searches for these words. This is where long-tail keywords come in.

Long-tail keywords

Long-tail keywords are longer, more specific phrases that people use when they're searching for something in particular. These users are often further along in the buying process, using voice search, or looking for detailed information on a specific topic.

Long-tail keywords typically contain 3 or more words, and while they may have lower search volume, they often come with higher intent, and

higher conversion potential. (And if you're not sure what intent or conversion potential mean, don't worry. We'll be covering those in just a bit.)

An example of a long-tail keyword is: "How to change the valve cover gasket on a 2000 Chrysler Neon"

I actually had to make that exact search the first time I lived on my own and was completely broke. My car needed a valve cover gasket replacement, and the mechanic quoted me $500 for the job, which might as well have been $5,000 at the time. So I turned to Google.

Right away, I found a detailed tutorial. It had step-by-step instructions, clear photos, and even close-up video angles. I ordered the part they recommended on Amazon for about $12, popped the hood, set my laptop on a bench next to the car, and got to work.

A few hours (and a lot of second-guessing) later, I had replaced the valve cover gasket myself. I was fully expecting the car to blow up when I turned the key, but instead, it purred like a dream. Total success.

That's why you want to use long-tail keywords.

Far fewer people search for long-tail keywords, which means there's less competition and a better chance for your content to rank. Think about it: Someone searching for "bread" is probably just browsing, but someone searching for "gluten-free sourdough garlic bread" knows exactly what they want and is far more likely to make a purchase.

Here's the cool part: Targeting long-tail keywords doesn't just help you rank for those specific phrases, it also helps you rank for broader, short-tail keywords too.

Take "gluten-free sourdough garlic bread" as an example. Within that one phrase, you're also targeting multiple short-tail keywords like "bread," "garlic bread," and "sourdough." It's a win-win.

Keyword Categories: User Intent

Now that we know about long-tail and short-tail keywords, we need to talk about user intent. Not all keywords serve the same purpose. To get the best results you're going to want to use a mix of the 4 types of user intent key-

words. To create content that ranks and converts, you need to understand the intent behind each search.

User intent is all about figuring out why someone is searching, not just what keyword they're typing. Are they looking for information? Trying to compare options? Ready to make a purchase?

When you align your content with the intent behind a keyword, you're no longer just showing up in search results, you're showing up at the right moment, with the right message, for the right person.

Informational keywords

Informational keywords are exactly what they sound like: people searching for information. These people aren't ready to pull out their wallets just yet. They're curious, they're learning, and they're asking questions to better understand a topic. And honestly? That's a great thing for you. Why? Because if your content is the one that gives them the answer they're looking for, you instantly become a trusted source in their eyes.

Remember Marcus and the strategy that helped turn his struggling pool business into a 9-figure empire? It all started with answering the questions his customers were already asking.

Informational keywords like "how to file taxes as a freelancer" or "what is a root canal" are often the very beginning of someone's buying journey. They're not ready to make a purchase yet, but they're clearly interested in a topic that can lead to one. This is where blog content becomes your secret weapon. These keywords help you show up early, build trust, and establish authority, so when that person is ready to buy, you're already top of mind.

Navigational keywords

Navigational keywords are used when someone already knows who or what they're looking for, they just need help getting there. These are the

people searching for things like "QuickBooks login," "Spotify pricing," or "HeyTony SEO." They're not browsing; they're navigating.

These keywords are typically used when someone's trying to find a specific page on a website, or just looking for a quicker way to get there. Instead of typing in the full URL, they'll search something like "Facebook" or "Amazon" and click the first result. It's faster, easier, and honestly, most of us do it without even thinking.

Navigational keywords might not bring in massive traffic, but they often bring in your most ready-to-convert visitors. These people are already looking for you, and your job is just to open the door.

Commercial keywords

Commercial keywords are where things start heating up. These are used by people who are seriously considering making a purchase, but they're still weighing their options. They're comparing, researching, and looking for the best solution before they commit.

Think of searches like "best CRM for small businesses," "Nike vs. Adidas running shoes," or "top-rated SEO tools." These folks aren't just curious, they're close to making a decision. They just need a little more information, a little more reassurance, and maybe a helpful blog post or two to tip them over the edge.

For you, commercial keywords are a huge opportunity. This is where you get to show up, build trust, and guide potential customers toward your product or service. Well-written comparison posts, buyer's guides, and even blog posts answering "which is better?" questions can be incredibly effective here.

And just like with informational keywords, your goal isn't just to rank, it's to be helpful, honest, and clear. Because when people feel like you've helped them make a smart decision, they're more likely to trust you and buy from you.

Transactional keywords

Transactional keywords are where the magic happens. These are the keywords people search when they're ready to buy. No more researching (informational), no more comparing (commercial), they've made up their minds and now they're looking for the fastest path to take action.

Think of searches like "buy noise-canceling headphones," "book dentist appointment near me," or "hire plumber." These aren't casual browsers, they're hot leads, ready to pull the trigger. If your website shows up at this stage, and you've done everything right up to this point, you're in prime position to make the sale.

This is why your product and service pages are so important. This is why clear calls to action, great page structure, and fast-loading websites make a difference (more about all of these in upcoming chapters). When someone is this close to buying, every little detail matters.

The goal here isn't to educate or convince, it's to close. So when you're optimizing for transactional keywords, think clarity, confidence, and ease of use. Make it obvious what you're offering, how much it costs, and how they can get it. At this stage, people don't want to be sold to, they want a solution. Your job is to make sure they don't have to look anywhere else.

Keyword Categories: Attributes

So far, we've talked about keywords by length (short-tail vs. long-tail) and by intent (informational, navigational, commercial, and transactional). But there's another layer you need to understand: keyword attributes. These aren't about how people are searching or why they're searching. Attributes are about the context. Are they location-based? Are they tied to a brand? Are they evergreen?

This section is all about helping you recognize the different flavors of keywords that can strengthen your SEO strategy. Because not all keywords

carry the same weight, and knowing how to spot the right ones will save you time, money, and a ton of frustration.

Let's break down the keyword types that add depth and strategy to your content plan, so you can attract the right people, at the right time, with the right content.

Branded keywords

Branded keywords are exactly what they sound like, searches that include a specific brand name, product, or company. Think "Nike running shoes," " iPhone," or even "HeyTony SEO." When someone types in a branded keyword, they already know who they're looking for, they just want to get to you faster. These can be a type of "navigational keyword" (page page <OV>).

It's actually pretty hard for branded keywords not to show up, unless your business name is supergeneric or overlaps with other well-established companies or websites. If that's the case, it might be worth considering a more unique name to help you stand out. Trust me, it'll make your life (and your SEO) a whole lot easier.

Search engines love when people search for your brand by name. It's a strong signal that you're a real, legitimate business, and Google is all about showing legitimate businesses to its users. The more your brand grows, the more branded searches you'll get, which makes showing up for them even more important in the long run. It's one of the clearest signs that your marketing is working.

Evergreen keywords

These are my favorite types of keywords. These are keywords that stay relevant year after year, consistently pulling in traffic no matter what's trending or what season it is. Think of keywords like "how to change a tire," "best productivity tips," or "how to write a business plan."

As a business owner or marketer, evergreen keywords are pure gold. Why? Because you can create a piece of content once, and, if done right, it can drive traffic for years. Of course, that only works if you're keeping an eye on your SEO strategy, monitoring your rankings, and making sure the competition isn't creeping up to steal your coveted #1 spot.

Here's an example. We published a blog post on the HeyTony website back in 2023 titled Facebook Reels Not Showing? Here's How To Fix It., and it's still going strong. That one post has brought in over 82,000 visitors, and it's still climbing. One post. Years of traffic. That's the power of evergreen content.

This is the kind of content that builds long-term momentum. It compounds. You're not chasing trends, you're building assets. And when you sprinkle in a few internal links, optimize for related long-tail keywords, and keep the content updated now and then? Google loves that. So does your audience.

If you're serious about building sustainable traffic without constantly reinventing the wheel, evergreen keywords need to be part of your strategy.

Time-sensitive & trending keywords

These are my least favorite types of keywords. They're a flash in the pan, explosive, attention-grabbing, but short-lived. Evergreen keywords, on the other hand, are the slow burn that keep delivering results long after you've hit publish.

Back in 2015, I met with the owner of **Heavy.com**, a news and pop culture site that thrives on trending and time-sensitive keywords like "Michael Jackson death" or "Super Bowl halftime performer 2024." Their strategy was all about speed, getting content out within minutes of breaking news.

They had a large team of writers on standby, constantly refreshing Twitter, watching live events, and reacting instantly to whatever was happening in the world. It worked, and they pulled in huge amounts of traffic from these spikes. But the traffic didn't last. A few days or weeks later, those pages would fade into digital obscurity.

Can you imagine that kind of pressure? Always chasing headlines, writing and publishing on the fly, just to stay relevant? It's effective in the short term, but exhausting. And definitely not the kind of SEO strategy I recommend for most businesses. Give me a slow, steady stream of evergreen traffic any day.

Geotargeted keywords

If you're a local business, geotargeted keywords are going to be your best friend. These are phrases like "electrician Windsor," "pizza near me," or "window cleaning Dallas." They include a specific location, which makes them highly relevant to people searching for your product or service in your area.

The best part? These keywords are usually much easier to rank for because you're not competing against the entire internet, you're only competing locally. That gives you a serious advantage.

Sure, the search volume might be lower compared to broader terms, but don't let that fool you. These searches are often commercial or transactional, meaning the person searching is actively looking to buy or book something. And if your website shows up when they're ready to take action? That's a win. Every single time.

Keyword Variations

Keyword variations are one of the key ingredients in the "secret sauce" of SEO. Think of them as alternative ways someone might search for the same topic. They also help search engines better understand your content and increase your chances of showing up for a wider range of related searches.

The best part? When you're writing naturally, you'll often use keyword variations without even thinking about it. For example, if your main keyword is "gluten-free garlic bread," you might naturally include variations like:

- gluten and dairy free garlic bread
- gluten free cheesy garlic bread
- gluten free garlic cheese bread
- gluten free pull apart garlic bread
- homemade gluten free garlic bread
- how to make gluten free garlic bread

Using variations not only makes your content more readable, but also helps Google see that your page is rich in relevant information. By using these variations you're also increasing the chances of your page ranking for those keywords. That's a win-win.

> **Pro tip:** Some of these related keywords could be entire topics on their own, which you can elaborate in detail on separate pages or posts. More on that later!

Keyword Density

Keyword density refers to how often you use your focus keyword, the one you're trying to rank for, compared to the total word count on your page.

There's no magic number or perfect percentage, but here's a general rule: Don't overdo it. If you repeat your keyword too many times just for the sake of SEO, it starts to feel unnatural not just to your readers, but to search engines too. That's called keyword stuffing, and Google hates it.

Your goal is to write content that flows naturally while still making it clear what the page is about. If you're using keyword variations and writing with your audience in mind, keyword density usually takes care of itself.

To get a better idea of what your keyword density should be, try this quick trick:

Go to Google and search for the keyword you're targeting. Open up the top three results. Check how many words each page has (you can use a free online word-count tool or a browser extension). Next, hit **CMD+F** (or

CTRL+F on Windows) and type in your keyword. This will instantly show you how many times that page uses the exact keyword.

You'll need to do a bit of simple math here. For example, if the #1 result has 1,000 words and uses the keyword 10 times, their keyword density is 1% (10 ÷ 1,000).

Your goal? Aim for a slightly higher keyword density, maybe use the keyword one or two extra times. Just enough to give you a small edge, without feeling forced or unnatural.

In the early days of SEO when search engines were still figuring things out, people used to hide keywords on their page by making the text the same color as the background. Humans couldn't see it, but search engines could. This does NOT work anymore... so don't even think about it!

Just focus on using your keywords (and their variations) naturally. At the end of the day, your content should always flow smoothly, feel authentic, and be genuinely helpful to your readers. Because great SEO isn't about keyword stuffing, it's about creating content people actually want to read.

Where to Use Keywords on Your Page

At this point, you're probably thinking, "Hey Matt, that's great, but where do we actually put these keywords?"

The short answer is: in your content. But hang tight, because you need to understand the elements of on-page SEO to know why I recommend placing keywords in specific spots.

Ideally, you'll want to include your target keyword in your title tag, meta description, H1 tag, at least one H2 tag, and naturally throughout the body of your page. If you're new to SEO, you might not know what all that means yet, but don't worry, that's exactly what we're diving into in the upcoming chapters.

Here's something shocking: The number one reason people fail to rank is that they're not even using their keyword on their page at all! Every single day I get asked, "Hey Matt, why am I not ranking for this keyword?", only to find out that keyword isn't even mentioned once in their content.

Imagine visiting a shoe store's website and the owner hasn't even included the word "shoe" anywhere. Sounds ridiculous, right? But trust me, I see this happen all the time.

But hey, you're reading this book... so you're not going to make that mistake, right?

CHAPTER 4

Title Tags

THINK OF A TITLE TAG AS THE HEADLINE of your web page. It's the first thing people see when your site shows up in Google search results. (It's the clickable blue text that clearly describes what your page is all about.) The title tag also appears when you share a link on social media, giving users a clear idea of what to expect before they click.

Here's what it looks like in the real world:



Why Are Title Tags Important?

Imagine your web page as a book sitting on a crowded shelf. Your title tag is the spine label; it signals clearly to everyone passing by exactly what's inside. This tiny piece of text is vital for both visitors and search engines, giving a quick but compelling glimpse of what awaits if they choose your page over others.

Here's why title tags are so important:

- **They provide a snapshot of your content.** A good title tag tells users exactly what to expect before they click, encouraging more relevant visits and fewer quick exits.
- **They act as your headline on social media.** When your page gets shared on platforms like Facebook, LinkedIn, or Twitter, your title tag is front-and-center, shaping users' first impressions and influencing whether they click.
- **They appear in browser tabs.** Ever opened 20 tabs at once? (I'm definitely guilty of that!) Your title tags help users keep track of your content, acting as helpful reminders about what each tab contains.

Crafting clear, enticing title tags helps you make your page stand out from the competition, attracting the right audience and improving your visibility in search engines.

Let me tell you a quick story about why title tags matter so much. Back in 2014, I was done with the advertising industry. Between jobs and struggling to make ends meet, I had just a few small freelance clients, too few to pay the bills. To fill the gap, I started driving trucks on movie sets and for commercials. The job had lots of downtime, and I'd use that downtime (and the studio's Wi-Fi) to hustle on my freelance gigs.

One freelance client was an online publication paying me just $125 per week. Clearly, something needed to change.

A few months in, a group of freelancers and I pitched the owners an ambitious idea: an online lifestyle magazine designed to inspire people to ditch the 9-to-5 routine. Our pitch was convincing enough that they invested, and suddenly, I was a shareholder!

Fast forward: By August, we had a website, regular articles, and even a small team. That first month, we hit 30,000 visitors. Not bad! But by December, the investors were nervous. Traffic wasn't growing fast enough, and we were running out of money.

Then something incredible happened: One of our articles went viral. Traffic surged from 30,000 to over FOUR MILLION visitors in a single month. We immediately analyzed everything about that article. What made it explode? The answer: the title tag.

The title tag was what caught people's attention on social media, making them click, read, and share. It was clear, compelling, and exactly matched what the audience wanted.

Up to that point, most of our titles were factual rather than sensationalized (aka slightly "click bait"). Instead of saying "NASA is looking for participants for their Bed Rest Studies," it would be more like "NASA will pay you $18,000 to stay in bed for 70 straight days." That was the first article that we had go viral on social media. That's when I realized how powerful a well-crafted title tag could be. It wasn't just a small detail; it was a critical factor in our success.

Quick note: Title tags for social media can be a bit more clickbaity than SEO title tags, which are typically more factual. If you use a WordPress plugin like Yoast, you can actually have two title tags: one for search and a different one that appears on social media.

Best Practices

Character count

Let's be honest, no one's clicking a title that's about as appealing as last week's leftover salad. Your title tag needs to immediately grab attention, clearly showing the value of your page in just a glance.

Aim for around 60 characters (that's roughly 8–15 words, depending on how big those words are). Why 60? Because Google typically cuts off anything longer than that, and your carefully crafted message might get lost. Remember, when it comes to title tags, bigger isn't always better—clarity and conciseness win every time.

Keyword placement

Always try to place your main keyword (the term you're trying to rank for) as close to the start of your title tag as possible. Why does this matter so much? Because people scanning search results have incredibly short attention spans and tons of options at their fingertips. They need to instantly recognize that your page has exactly what they're looking for, or they'll move on.

A strategically placed keyword immediately signals relevance, helping users (and search engines) understand precisely why they should click your link.

Uniqueness

Every title tag on your website should be unique, and for good reason. Each page on your site should focus on one specific topic, and your title tag is your first (and most important) chance to tell both search engines *and* users what that page is all about.

Using the same title tag on multiple pages is a big no-no. Not only does it confuse your audience, but it also confuses Google. When search engines see duplicate title tags, they might assume the content is the same, or worse, not know which page to rank. That can lead to both pages underperforming.

Your title tag is prime real estate in the search results. It's your headline, your hook, and your chance to stand out. Make each one count by keeping it relevant, specific, and clearly tied to the content on that page.

How Does the Title Tag Help You Rank?

That's the big question, isn't it? You're here to rank, to get more traffic, more visibility, and ultimately, more success.

When you include your focus keyword in the title tag, you're clearly signaling to both users and Google exactly what your page is about. Pair this with a few other essential on-page elements (which we'll dive into soon), and you create a clear roadmap that helps Google understand and confidently recommend your content.

But that's not all. A compelling, keyword-rich title tag attracts more clicks. And here's the magic: *The more people click your link (instead of your competitors'), the stronger the signal you send to Google that your content is valuable*. Google notices this user behavior and rewards you by boosting your rankings even higher.

Simply put: The right title tag doesn't just get attention, it drives traffic, improves rankings, and sets your content apart from everyone else's.

What's Next?

We've just scratched the surface, my friend. Next up, we'll dive into the world of meta descriptions and URLs, because in SEO, every element on your web page is a piece of the puzzle, and we're here to put it all together.

Your title tag is what screams, "Choose me instead of the other person!"

Speaking of standing out, let me share one more quick story. Growing up, my dad would always say, "Don't be afraid of work, make work afraid of you," to motivate us during yard work. Part of me rolled my eyes, but another part took this as a challenge. I carried this mindset into college,

specifically into an Intro to SEO class. The final project was simple: build and optimize a 10-page website. The professor explained that more pages mean ranking for more keywords and, ultimately, more traffic. So, instead of creating the required 10 pages, I built a website with nearly 500 pages, every single one manually coded. (No shortcuts, no ChatGPT, just late nights and determination.)

To submit the project, we had to print out the code for every optimized page. I ended up printing an entire ream of paper, so much that no binder could hold it. I punched holes through the pages and tied them together with twine. Remember what my dad said about making the work afraid of you?

I got a perfect score on that assignment. Even better, it led directly to a summer internship at my professor's SEO company. Why did he choose me? Because I gave him an unforgettable reason.

That giant stack of paper tied with twine was basically my real-life title tag, a bold statement saying, "This is the best option, choose this one!" And that's how my career in SEO began.

CHAPTER 5

Meta Descriptions

THE META DESCRIPTION IS THE SHORT SNIPPET of text that appears directly below the title tag in search results. Its job is to give users (and search engines) a quick preview of what they'll find if they decide to click your link.

Think of the meta description as the title tag's partner in crime: They always show up together and help users decide whether your page is worth their time.

Here's an example of what it looks like in the real world:



Why Are Meta Descriptions Important?

So, your title tag caught someone's attention, now it's up to your meta description to seal the deal. Think of it as your second (and final) chance to convince someone that your link is the best one on the page.

Here's why meta descriptions matter so much:

1. **They give a more detailed snapshot of your content.** A well-crafted meta description clearly sets expectations for the reader, explaining exactly what they'll find after clicking. Similar to your title tag, a strong meta description leads to higher click-through rates, which in turn helps your page rank higher in search results. More clicks, fewer quick exits— that's what Google loves.
2. **Your meta description doesn't just live on Google.** It can show up on social media platforms like Facebook, LinkedIn, or Twitter when someone shares your link. This gives social media users a clear preview of your content, increasing the likelihood that they'll actually click through and visit your site.

Bottom line: Invest a little extra time in your meta descriptions. They're often the deciding factor in getting the click.

Best Practices

Character count

Here's the good news: Meta descriptions give you more breathing room than title tags. You've got between 80 characters and about 156 characters to charm both search engines and searchers alike. That's your chance to convince someone to take the leap and click through to your content.

Craft click-worthy meta descriptions

Writing a compelling meta description isn't as hard as you might think. Just clearly tell people exactly what they can expect on your page. For example, if your page is about "The Best Candle Wax for Mosquitoes," your meta description might say something like: *"Mosquitoes hate this candle wax. Here are the waxes that work best and why these candles are a must-have for outdoor nights."*

Similar to title tags, it helps to include your primary keyword near the beginning of your meta description. However, don't stress too much about using the exact keyword every single time. Google doesn't directly factor meta description keywords into rankings.

In fact, Google sometimes ignores your carefully crafted meta description altogether, opting instead to create its own based on what it finds on your page. Google's algorithm can do this when it thinks there's other content on your page that's more relevant to the user's search query.

Make them unique

Every page on your website should focus on one main topic, and your meta description should reflect that. It needs to be unique because it's your chance to tell both users and search engines exactly what that specific page is about.

If you reuse the same meta description across multiple pages, you risk confusing your visitors and sending mixed signals to Google. In fact, search engines may ignore one of your pages altogether, thinking it's a duplicate. Unique meta descriptions help your content stand out and ensure each page gets the attention it deserves.

What's Next?

Up next, we'll be diving into URLs (the links to your pages) and then one of my favorite topics, heading tags. It's an area a lot of people get wrong simply because they don't fully understand how powerful heading tags are or how to use them properly.

Just remember this: SEO works best when all the elements work together. It's not about nailing just one piece, it's about how all the pieces connect. When done right, they create something far greater than the sum of their parts.

CHAPTER 6

URLs (aka Links)

URLS, ALSO KNOWN AS LINKS, SLUGS, OR PERMALINKS, are how people, and search engines, find specific pages on the internet. A URL is essentially the web address to a particular page on your site.

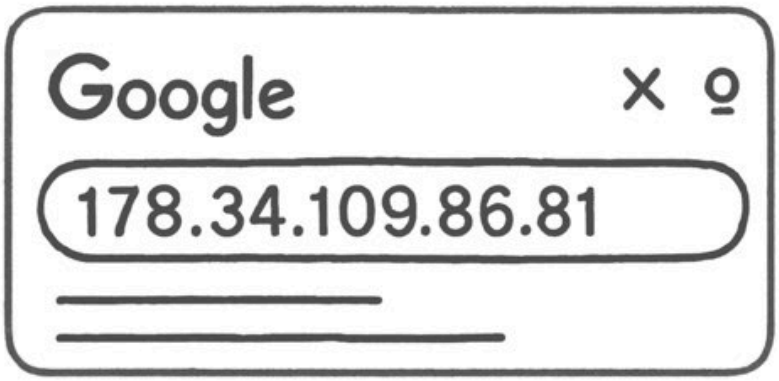
Think of a URL like a street address. Just like every house needs a unique address so people can find it, every page on your website needs a unique URL so users (and Google) know exactly where to go.

Fun fact: URL stands for Uniform Resource Locator (bet you didn't know that!). Its job is simple: to create a clear, understandable path to your website's content. And when done right, your URLs don't just help people find you, they help you rank better too.

The URL–User Experience

Let me paint you a picture of what life was like when the internet first began. Back then, the only way to access a website was by typing in a string of numbers called an IP address.

Imagine having to remember something like 178.34.109.86.81 every time you wanted to visit a website. Or worse, 17834109864151234897134 just to get to your home page. Yeah… not exactly user-friendly.



Thankfully, URLs came along to make the internet actually usable for humans.



Now imagine telling someone to visit your home page by giving them that number. It's a lot easier to just say "go to **heytony.ca**," right?

Best Practices

Character count

The maximum length of a URL in most browsers is currently 2,048 characters. But just because you can make it that long, doesn't mean you should!

To illustrate my point, that last paragraph was 144 characters... Imagine a URL that long! No, thanks.

Shorter URLs often lead to better performance because they're:

- Easier for users to understand and remember
- More search engine friendly
- Less likely to break when shared
- Just plain nicer to look at

Incorporating keywords in URLs

Just like with title tags and meta descriptions, keywords play a crucial role in URLs too. Every page's URL should include the relevant keyword, except for your home page, which usually takes the form of a simple domain name (like **website.com**). For example, if you have a page about chocolate chip cookies, your URL could be something like:

yourdomain.com/chocolate-chip-cookies/

- This tells both users and search engines exactly what your page is about.

However, and this is important, *don't go overboard with keywords*. Here's an example of what NOT to do:

yourdomain.com/chocolate-chip-cookies-cookies-with-chocolate-chips-the-best-chocolate-chip-cookies

- This is a classic example of keyword stuffing, cramming a bunch of keywords into your URL in hopes of tricking Google into ranking your page higher.

Spoiler alert: Keyword stuffing doesn't work. In fact, it can actually hurt your rankings. Google's way too smart for that now, and it's focused on clarity and user experience, not keyword spam.

Real-World Examples: The Good & the Not-So-Good

Let's compare two examples.

1. **Not-So-Good URL: example.com/hamilton-website-designers-web-design-hamilton/**
   - This is keyword stuffing in action. It's excessive and hard to read.
2. **Good URL: example.com/website-design**
   - This hits the sweet spot: It's short, descriptive, and includes the necessary keyword.

URL Subdirectories

In addition to keeping your URLs short and to the point, you should also keep them organized. Clean, structured URLs help both search engines and visitors quickly understand what a page is about, and that's exactly where subdirectories come in.

Think of subdirectories like folders in your website's filing system. They add structure and clarity to your URLs, showing how different pages relate to each other. When done right, subdirectories make your site easier to navigate, easier to understand, and easier to rank. Clean structure = stronger SEO.

Take this example: example.com/product/protein-milk/

- In this case, "product" is the subdirectory. It tells you, and Google, that this page is part of the product section of the website.

Now compare that to: example.com/blog/health-benefits-of-protein-milk/

- Here, “blog” is the subdirectory, clearly showing this page is part of the blog section.

Just by glancing at the URLs, you can instantly understand the purpose of each page: One is for buying something and the other is for learning something. This kind of structure improves user experience and helps search engines better categorize your site, which can improve your chances of ranking higher in relevant search results. Clean, organized URLs = a better website for everyone.

Here are some examples of popular subdirectories:

/products/
/services/
/store/
/shop/
/collections/
/blog/
/articles/
/resources/
/guides/
/news/
/about/
/team/
/careers/
/contact/
/press/
/login/
/signup/
/account/
/dashboard/
/profile/

While these are some of the most common subdirectories you’ll see across websites, there’s no strict rule for what yours need to be. You’re not

locked into using "/blog/" or "/products/" if something else makes more sense for your business.

The only real guideline I'll give you is this: Use subdirectories to clearly describe the section of your website they belong to. That's it. Keep it clean, clear, and intuitive.

And whatever you do, don't use subdirectories as a way to cram in extra keywords. That's just keyword stuffing dressed in a different outfit, and as we've covered, keyword stuffing helps no one (especially not your rankings).

CHAPTER 7

Heading Tags

HEADING TAGS ARE ONE OF THE MOST VALUABLE, and yet most underused and misused, elements in SEO. They play a critical role in organizing your content for both readers and search engines. Without proper headings, your page becomes harder to read, harder to skim, and harder to understand.

Heading tags (H1, H2, H3, etc.) act like signposts, guiding users through your content and helping Google understand what each section is about. They break up your content into digestible sections, improve the overall user experience, and make it easier for people to quickly find the exact info they're looking for.

In short: They're not just about structure, they're about clarity, relevance, and helping both humans and algorithms make sense of your content. Use them right, and they can make a huge difference in how your content performs.

The Different Heading Tags Explained

There are 6 different heading tags. They range from H1 to H6 and act as the building blocks of your content's structure. They prioritize and organize information on your web page, making it digestible and easy to navigate.

Here's the breakdown:

H1 tag: your headline

Your H1 tag is the main headline, the primary topic of the page. Every page on your website should have one, *and only one*, H1 tag. It often mirrors your title tag, but it's meant for users on the page, not just those scrolling through search results.

Your H1 should be unique to each page and clearly tell both Google and your visitors what the page is about. It's usually the biggest, boldest text on the page and the first thing people see when they land there. Done right, it sets the tone for everything that follows and helps users immediately understand they're in the right place. If you have more than one H1 tag, it may confuse search engines as to what your page is actually about.

Best practices

- Only use ONE H1 tag per page.
- Try to keep them under 60 characters.
- Use your keyword toward the beginning.

H2 tags: your subtopics

Heading 2 (H2) tags break your main topic into clear, digestible subtopics. They're the backbone of your content structure. While your H1 introduces what the page is about, your H2s organize the supporting details.

They help users quickly scan and skim your content to find the exact section they're interested in, which massively improves readability and user experience. From an SEO perspective, H2s reinforce and support the H1 by showing search engines how your content is organized and what it covers in more detail. In short: They make your content easier to navigate for everyone, humans and search engines alike.

While there's no strict rule for how many H2 tags you should use, a good guideline is to include at least 2 per page. Each H2 should introduce a key section of your content and ideally include a variation or subtopic related to the keyword in your H1 tag.

Think of them as supporting pillars that hold up your main topic. Not only do they help structure your page for better readability, but they also give search engines more context about what your content covers, which can help you rank for related keywords and phrases.

Best Practices

- You can and should use multiple H2 tags on every page.
- No strict character limit, but keep them concise.
- Use the keywords you're trying to rank for somewhere in your H2 tags; *they don't necessarily need to be at the beginning*.

H3 tags: supporting details

H3 tags support your H2s. They're like sub-subtopics that break down your content even further. If H2 tags are the main sections of your page, H3s live underneath them, helping you dive deeper into specific points or details within that section.

You'll typically use H3 tags when your content is more in-depth and needs a higher level of organization. They help keep things clean, readable, and easy to navigate, especially in longer blog posts or detailed guides.

There are no strict rules around how many H3s you should use or how long they should be, but as with all headings, they should be clear and concise. Unlike H1s and H2s, H3 tags don't need to include your main keyword or a variation, they're more about structure than SEO. And if your content doesn't go that deep? No need to force it. Use them only when it makes sense for the reader.

Best practices

- You don't necessarily need to use H3 tags.
- No character limit, but keep them concise!
- You don't necessarily need to include keywords you're trying to rank for.
- Your H3 tags support what your H2 tags are talking about.

H4 to H6 tags: deep dives

These tags are less common, but they can still be useful for breaking down complex subtopics even further, especially in long-form or highly detailed content. That said, they're not as essential as your H1 through H3 tags when it comes to SEO impact.

> **pro tip:** If you find yourself needing to go that deep into subtopics, it might be a sign that your content is getting too dense for one page. In that case, consider creating a separate piece of content that dives deeper into that specific area. Not only does it help with clarity, but it also gives you another opportunity to rank for a related topic.

Heading Tag Hierarchy

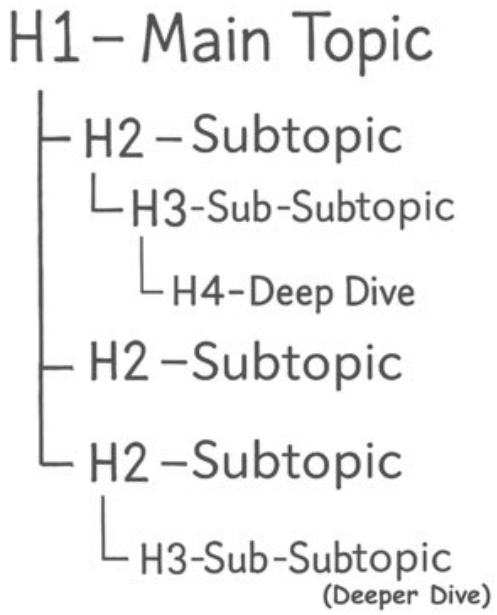
Here's the golden rule when it comes to heading tags: Always use them in sequential order. This keeps your content organized, easy to read, and easy for search engines to understand.

Your H1 should always be the first and only main heading on the page; it sets the stage. From there, you move to H2 tags to introduce major sections, then to H3 tags to break those sections down further, and so on.

But here's where a lot of people mess up: jumping straight from an H1 to an H3. When you skip levels like that, you're skipping important context. Search engines rely on this hierarchy to understand how your content flows.

Think of it like a table of contents: Each level should logically build on the one before it.

That said, you can move backwards. For example, if you're in the middle of a section using H3 tags and start a brand-new topic, it's perfectly fine to go back to an H2. The key is to use heading tags logically to reflect the structure of your content, not just for SEO, but for the reader's experience too.



The SEO & User Experience Impact

Effectively using heading tags does more than just organize your content, it guides your readers through the journey of your page. For someone landing on your site for the first time or skimming for a specific answer, clear and well-structured headings make it easy to find what they're looking for without digging.

From an SEO standpoint, heading tags also help search engines understand the hierarchy and relevance of your content. When your headings align with commonly searched questions or phrases, they can boost your chances of landing in rich snippets (aka rich results) or AI-generated overviews in search results. And that kind of visibility? It can be a game-changer, putting your page front and center, even above the traditional #1 spot.

CHAPTER 8

Anchor Text

ANCHOR TEXT IS THE CLICKABLE TEXT ON A WEBSITE. It's usually blue and underlined, signaling to users that it can be clicked. But it's more than just a visual cue. Anchor text is used to give users and search engines context about the page it's linking to.

When used properly, anchor text helps guide readers to related content and helps Google understand how different pages are connected. It's used for both internal links (linking to other pages on your own site) and external links (linking to other websites). We'll get into internal and external links in the next two chapters.

The Importance of Descriptive Anchor Text

When you're adding a link to your content, the anchor text you choose, the clickable part, should always be descriptive and relevant to the page you're linking to. This might sound small, but it serves two really important purposes:

1. It helps users. Clear anchor text tells people exactly what they'll find when they click the link.
2. It helps search engines. It gives Google more context about what the linked page is about, which can help both pages rank better.

Here's a common mistake to avoid: using vague phrases like "click here" or "learn more." Those could link to anything, and they don't give users or search engines any useful information.

Instead, be specific. If you're linking to a page about how to choose the best running shoes, your anchor text should say something like "how to choose the right running shoes," not "read more." The clearer your anchor text, the more helpful it is.

Best Practices

Keep them short

There's no hard-and-fast rule, but a good guideline is to keep your anchor text between 1 and 5 words. You should be able to describe the page you're linking to within that range. Short, clear, and to the point is the goal.

Be specific, not vague

The more specific your anchor text, the more helpful it is, for both users and search engines. If your anchor text says "chocolate cake recipe," it better link to a page with an actual chocolate cake recipe.

On the flip side, if you link to that same page with something like "click here," no one (including Google) knows what to expect. It's vague, unhelpful, and a missed opportunity for context.

Don't link full paragraphs or sentences

This one might seem obvious, but it happens more often than you'd think: Don't link an entire sentence or paragraph. It looks messy and provides zero clarity. Anchor text should give *context*, and a whole chunk of text

doesn’t do that. Just link the relevant words that describe where the user is going.

CHAPTER 9

Internal Links

I'M GENUINELY EXCITED ABOUT THIS CHAPTER. Internal linking is one of the most overlooked, underutilized, and ridiculously simple SEO tactics out there. And because it's so simple, people often assume it's not that important. Big mistake.

Internal linking is when you link from one page on your website to another page on your site. That's it. But that one move does a lot of heavy lifting. It helps guide both users and search engines through your site, connecting related content, keeping people engaged longer, and strengthening your site's overall SEO structure. It's easy to implement, and when done right, it can make a huge difference.

The Different Internal Links Explained

While text-based internal links are the most common (and most effective), there are actually a few different ways to link within your website.

1. Text links (anchor text)

When I talk about the power of internal linking, *this* is what I'm talking about: text links, also known as anchor text.

They help users and search engines discover other pages on your website *and* give context about what those pages are about. And here's where it

gets powerful: If you use a relevant keyword as your anchor text (ideally one the linked page is targeting), you're helping Google understand and rank that page better.

It's simple, strategic, and very effective when done right.

2. Image links

While not as powerful as text-based links, image links can still play a role in your internal linking strategy, *when used thoughtfully*. I wouldn't rely on them as a core tactic, but they can be effective in the right context, like showcasing a product that clicks through to its detail page.

Want to give them a bit more SEO power? Make sure your image has descriptive alt text. That helps search engines understand what the image, and the link, is about. (Don't worry, we'll dive into alt text in a few chapters!)

3. Buttons

Buttons are technically just styled links, and while they function like internal links, they're not usually a core part of your internal linking strategy. They're more about driving action and conversions.

You'll often see buttons with phrases like "Book a Call," "Schedule an Appointment," or "Get a Free Quote." These are great for user experience, but not so great for internal linking. Why? Because that kind of text is *vague*. It doesn't tell search engines anything specific about the page it links to; almost any website could use those same phrases.

That said, buttons are still super valuable. Just think of them as calls-to-action, not keyword-optimized links. Use buttons to guide users toward the next step in their journey, and support those buttons with clear text links nearby when it makes sense for SEO.

4. Breadcrumbs (navigation paths)

Breadcrumbs are those little navigation trails you often see at the top of a page, just under the main menu, which show users exactly where they are on your site and how they got there. Breadcrumbs are kind of like a GPS for your website.

Let's say you're shopping for a dog collar online. You might see something like: **Products > Dog > Collars > Small Collars**

Breadcrumbs help users easily navigate back to previous sections without starting from scratch. From an SEO perspective, they also create a logical internal link structure that signals hierarchy and relevance to search engines. So while breadcrumbs are primarily built for user experience, they also quietly boost your site architecture and internal linking strategy behind the scenes.

Where You Can Use Internal Links

Navigational links

Navigational links are the ones that appear in your main menu and footer, showing up on every page of your website. These links send a strong signal to Google (and your visitors) about which pages are the most important.

Your main navigation menu should feature your highest-priority pages, like your services, products, contact page, or blog. These are the pages that drive the most action, so they deserve top placement.

Your footer, on the other hand, is where you can link to secondary, but still important, pages. Things like frequently asked questions (FAQs), policies, support pages, or location-specific content live here. It's your chance to keep key pages accessible without crowding the top of your site.

In-content (contextual) links

These are the links that live *inside your actual content*, the ones that show up as blue (or whatever color matches your brand). They link one piece of content to another on your site using anchor text.

For example, if you're writing a blog post and you mention "website design," you can link that phrase to your website design service page. That gives both Google and your readers a clear signal about what to expect if they click.

Best Practices

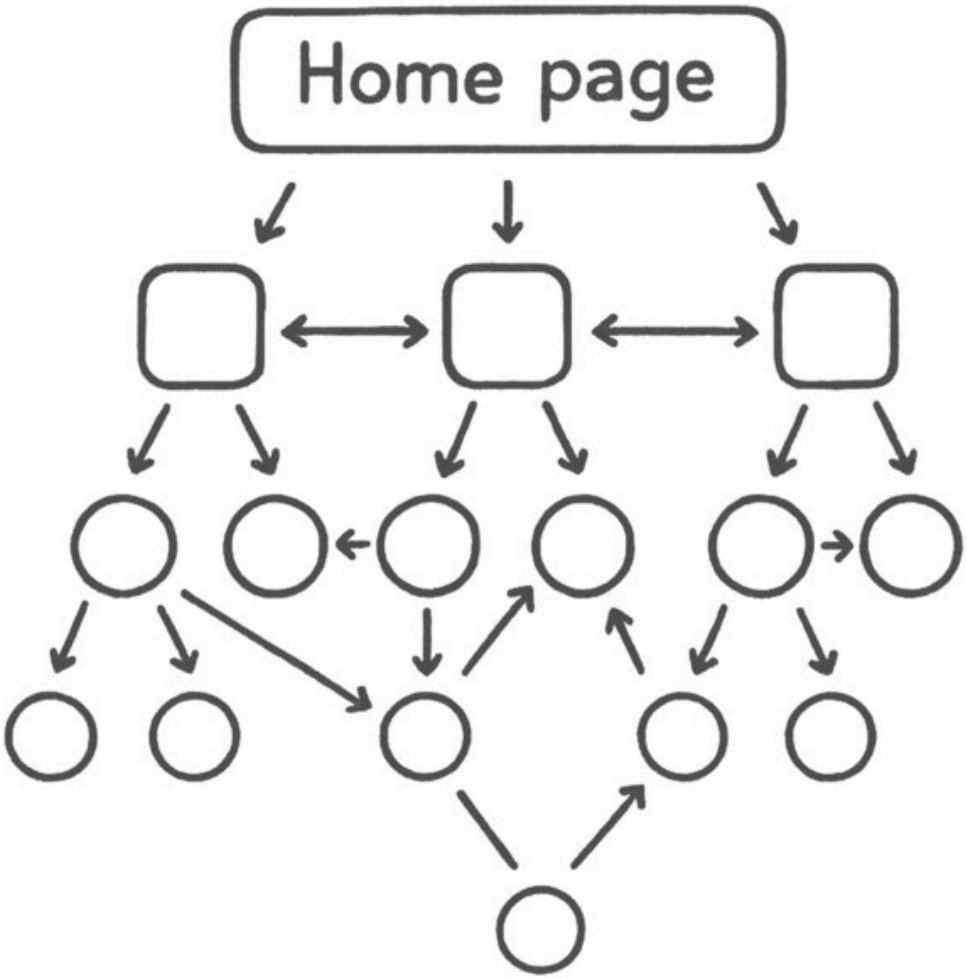
Use descriptive anchor text

Using non-descriptive anchor texts like "click here" or "learn more," doesn't provide any context about where the link leads. Make sure your anchor text describes the page you're linking to.

How many internal links per page

Try to include 3 to 5 internal links on every page (in content), using descriptive keywords as your anchor text. These links help with user navigation, improve SEO, and keep people on your site longer. At least one of those links should go to your product or service pages.

Think of your website as a spiderweb. With each internal link, you're adding another strand, making it easier for search engines to crawl, index, and understand your site's content.



The Power of Internal Links

I'll be honest, I didn't prioritize my own SEO strategy right away. Like a lot of agency owners, I used to believe clients just "came to you" if you were good at what you did. For a long time, my site was a one-page placeholder… which, let's be real, is absolutely terrible for SEO.

But when it came time to rebuild my website, I approached it with a clear plan. SEO would be baked in from the start. I wasn't just creating a nicer-looking site, I was creating an SEO machine. I mapped out a full structure: a proper home page, service pages, a contact page, and a content hub built around regular blog posts.

I hired a web designer to bring the vision to life, while I focused on the content. I wrote and optimized each service page with intention, using

every on-page SEO tactic I knew. Then I hit publish.

And… nothing.

No traffic. No rankings. No movement.

But I wasn't panicking. SEO takes time, and I had already committed to the long game. In the meantime, my team and I kept pushing forward, publishing blog posts several times per week, each one written with strategy in mind.

Fast forward about a year. I decided to check in on the service pages. To my surprise, we were ranking #1 for almost all of our top keywords. At first, I thought it had to be a mistake. I double-checked the data. I even opened the page revision history to see if anyone had made quiet changes behind the scenes. Nope. The last edit was mine. A year ago. So what happened?

Well, it turns out the blog content was doing its job. Not only was it driving traffic, but it was also silently powering up our service pages. Every post followed the same simple rule I had laid out from day one: Internally link to at least one service page using keyword-rich anchor text. That's it. Nothing fancy. No hacks. Just consistent execution of one basic, overlooked tactic.

And that was the moment it clicked: Internal linking isn't just helpful, it's a game-changer. It became a top priority for our client strategy, and the results have been undeniable. What started as a structured, intentional plan to improve our own SEO has turned into one of the simplest, most effective tools in our entire playbook.

CHAPTER 10

External Links

EXTERNAL LINKS ARE LINKS THAT LEAD from *your* website to *another* website. Think of them as references that support your information, data, or claims by linking to authoritative external sources.

Using external links effectively can significantly boost your website's credibility. By linking to reliable sources, you show both users and search engines that your content is well researched and based on facts, not just opinions.

Every single page on your website should link to *at least* one external source.

Where You Can Use External Links

External links are great for SEO when used properly. They show search engines that you've done your research and that your content is connected to credible, relevant sources. When using external links, keep in mind that you want to use them:

- Inside your content only, never in your navigation menu or footer.
- At least once on every page, especially when referencing facts, stats, or tools.

Example: Let's say you're writing a blog post about e-commerce trends in Canada. You mention that online shopping in Canada is growing quickly.

To back that up, you include a link to a recent study or official report that supports your statement. This not only adds credibility to your content but also shows readers (and Google) that your information is trustworthy.

Best Practices

Only link to reputable, relevant sources

Make sure the site is trustworthy, up-to-date, and closely related to the topic you're covering.

Don't link to competitors or duplicate content

Never link to another page covering the exact same topic as you; it can send traffic away and weaken your own content's authority. (More on this topic in a few chapters.)

Avoid using your target keyword as anchor text

This is a common mistake. If you're trying to rank for "National Flower of Canada," don't link to a Wikipedia article using that exact phrase. You're literally helping them rank for the keyword you want to win. Instead, use neutral anchor text like "source" or "according to Wikipedia."

CHAPTER 11

Bullets & Lists

WHAT ARE THEY? Simple, bullet points and numbered lists. That's it!

These little formatting tools are incredibly powerful when it comes to organizing your content. They break down information into bite-sized, easy-to-digest chunks, making your content quicker to read and easier to understand. When people can scan your page and instantly find what they're looking for, they're way more likely to stick around.

Here's the truth about long blocks of text: They're intimidating. A giant wall of words can turn readers off before they even start. But bullets and lists? They create visual breathing room, helping users absorb key points without feeling overwhelmed.

Bullet Points Example

Here's an example of bullet points you could use in a blog post titled Easy Ways to Save Money on Groceries.

Here are a few simple ways to cut down your grocery bill without sacrificing quality:

- Plan your meals for the week before heading to the store.
- Make a shopping list, and stick to it.
- Avoid shopping when you're hungry (you'll buy more than you need).
- Buy in bulk for items you use regularly.

- Compare prices per unit to get the best deal.
- Use loyalty cards or store apps for extra discounts.
- Opt for store-brand products when possible; they're often just as good.

See how easy that list was to scan and understand? Bullet points highlight the key takeaways, making the content more digestible at a glance. You can also use them as navigational elements by internally linking each point to a relevant section further down the page. You'll often see this in a table of contents located at the top of a blog post. This gives readers the option to jump straight to the information they're most interested in, improving both usability and engagement.

List Example

Similar to bullet points, you can use lists to make content easier to follow and digest. Let's look at an example that could be used in the same piece of content mentioned above: Easy Ways to Save Money on Groceries.

Follow these steps to plan a budget-friendly grocery trip:

1. **Set a weekly food budget.** Know exactly how much you're willing to spend before you even start planning.
2. **Check your fridge and pantry.** Take inventory of what you already have to avoid buying duplicates.
3. **Plan meals around what's on sale.** Base your meals on weekly store flyers or discounts.
4. **Write a detailed grocery list.** Organize it by category (produce, dairy, etc.) to shop faster and avoid impulse buys.
5. **Stick to your list at the store.** This is the key to avoiding unnecessary extras that sneak into your cart.

People love numbered lists because they present information in a clear, step-by-step order that's easy to follow. They guide the reader through a

process from start to finish and help make sure no steps are missed along the way.

You'll see lists like this all over the internet, especially on sites known for "listicles." Think titles like "10 Must-Try Excursions in Barbados" or "5 Easy Weeknight Dinners You Can Make in Under 30 Minutes." They're simple, scannable, and incredibly effective at keeping readers engaged.

Best Practices

When to use bullets & lists

While bullet points and numbered lists can be extremely helpful, not every page or piece of content needs them. There's no hard rule—you'll need to use your best judgment.

If you notice a big chunk of text with several paragraphs and nothing breaking it up, that's a good sign it might be time to add a list. Bullets and lists give your readers a mental break and make your content more scannable, especially when you're covering multiple ideas, tips, or steps.

When in doubt, ask yourself: Would this section be easier to understand if I pulled out the key points? If the answer is yes, a list is probably the way to go.

From an SEO standpoint, the clarity and structure provided by bullets and lists can positively impact your site's readability score. This, in turn, can influence your search rankings. Search engines love content that's user-friendly and easy to understand.

CHAPTER 12

Images

NOW LET'S SHIFT OUR FOCUS to another key element of SEO *and* user experience: using images and graphics on your website.

Images do more than just make your site look nice, they play a meaningful role in:

- Increasing the time visitors spend on your page
- Boosting conversion rates
- Building trust and credibility
- Making your content easier to read and engage with

(Notice the bullet points? That's a real-world example of how useful they are.)

Images, just like bullet points, help break up walls of text. A page that's packed with text can feel overwhelming. Adding relevant images, graphics, or charts gives your readers a visual break, keeps them interested, and makes the content feel more approachable.

Custom Images & Graphics

Go back just 10 years, and creating custom images or graphics would've cost you an arm and a leg. It simply wasn't sustainable for anyone regularly publishing free blog content. But today? It's never been easier or more affordable.

Thanks to tools like Canva, you can create high-quality, on-brand graphics in minutes. You don't need to be a designer, and you don't need a premium subscription to get started. That said, upgrading does unlock a ton of extra templates and time-saving features if you're producing content regularly. And even better, you can use AI like ChatGPT to create images and graphics for you.

While stock photos still have their place, custom visuals—like branded graphics, screenshots, or photos you've taken yourself— make a much bigger impact. They add personality, build trust, and make your content feel more original, credible, and cohesive. Bottom line: Custom visuals show your audience (and Google) that you know your stuff.

> **Warning:** You can avoid any copyright infringement by using royalty-free, custom, or paid-for stock images.

Choosing the Right Image Format

Most of us are familiar with image file formats like **.jpg** and **.png**; they've been around forever and are still the most widely used formats today. But in recent years, newer and more efficient formats have entered the scene. These are known as "next-gen image formats."

One of the most popular is **.webp**. It offers the same visual quality as **.jpg** or **.png** files, but at a *much smaller file size*. This means your pages load faster, which is a big win for both user experience *and* SEO.

While tools like Canva don't currently support exporting to **.webp**, it's still easy to convert your images. Just google "convert **.jpg** to **.webp**" and you'll find several free tools that do it in seconds. If you're using Photoshop, you can export directly to **.webp** from your computer.

One quick heads-up: As of the time of writing, Squarespace is the only major website builder that doesn't support **.webp**. So if that's your platform, you'll want to stick with compressed **.jpg** or **.png** files instead. You can compress your images by changing the quality in Canva, using a paid tool like Photoshop, or just searching online for "Compress **.jpg**."

Types of Images

To get the most out of a piece of content, you'll likely use a mix of different image types, each serving a specific purpose depending on the topic and intent of your post.

Whether you're writing a how-to guide, a product breakdown, or a personal story, combining various visuals can help keep your content engaging, informative, and easier to follow. The key is to be intentional and choose images that support the message, not just fill space.

Here are some of the most popular types of images.

Photographs

Photographs are a great way to show that you're a real person behind a real business. Nothing builds trust like images of you, your team, your office, or your happy customers. Photos don't always need to be professionally taken; your phone camera can do the job just fine. Just make sure you brush up on a few basics for taking quality photos.

While using stock images is easy and convenient, there's a good chance you and your competitors will choose the *exact same images* which doesn't do much for your credibility.

Ever searched for a new dentist and noticed every dentist's site had the same smiling woman in a white coat? Exactly. That's why I always recommend using your own photos whenever possible. They're unique to you, your business, and your brand, and that authenticity makes a big difference.

Graphics & illustrations

These are my go-to visuals, especially as a digital marketer who doesn't have a physical product to photograph or a fancy office to show off.

Graphics and illustrations are perfect for adding depth and clarity to your content when traditional photos just don't cut it.

They're also incredibly versatile. You can use them to highlight key points, explain concepts visually, or even replace bullet points and numbered lists when you want to make your content more engaging and easier to understand.

A perfect example? Infographics.

Infographics are powerful because they give people a visual summary of your content in a way that's easy to digest and remember. Infographics are also highly shareable, especially on platforms like Pinterest, and can help drive additional traffic and even earn backlinks. (More on backlinks later!)

Infographics also make great educational tools. Think about the last time you were at the doctor's office. You probably saw a poster of the human body explaining different systems or conditions. That's an infographic in action, helping people *see* and better understand something complex.



So whether you're explaining a concept, simplifying data, or just trying to make your page more visually appealing, graphics and illustrations are a smart way to do it.

Screenshots

Screenshots are another simple but highly effective type of image. These can be taken from your computer, phone, or tablet, and they're perfect for how-to guides or any content where you need to visually show someone exactly what to do or what something looks like.

They're especially useful for walking users through step-by-step processes, highlighting specific features, or even showing proof of results, like your follower count, a social media profile, or a snapshot of analytics. Screenshots help make your content more credible, clear, and actionable.

Charts & graphs

People love graphs and charts. Just like infographics, they offer a quick, visual way to understand data without having to read through a wall of numbers or paragraphs.

Graphs and charts are perfect for summarizing key data points, illustrating trends, or backing up a claim with evidence, especially when referencing a study, report, or your own analytics. They make complex information more digestible and add an extra layer of professionalism to your content.

Image Placements

Featured images

Nearly every website builder gives you the option to add a featured image, and you should definitely use it. This image usually appears at the top of the page, either just below or layered behind your H1 tag. It's also the image that shows up when someone shares your page on social media.



A featured image is your first visual impression, it tells part of the story before the reader even starts scrolling. For example, if you land on a blog post about Gluten-Free Sourdough Garlic Bread, you'd expect to see a mouth-watering photo of that bread right at the top. That image doesn't just add visual appeal, it draws the reader in and sets the tone for what's to come.

In-content images

These are the images you see sprinkled throughout blog posts and web pages, not just at the top, but woven into the content itself. In-content images help support and enhance what you're saying. They can clarify a point, visually explain a concept, or simply give the reader a much-needed break from large blocks of text.



Think of these images as visual signposts that help move the reader through your content. Whether it's a chart, a diagram, a screenshot, or a relevant photo, each image should serve a purpose. It's not about adding images just to make the page look pretty, it's about making the information more engaging and easier to understand.

Used correctly, in-content images improve comprehension, keep people scrolling longer, and create a better overall experience on your site.

Best Practices

How often should you use images?

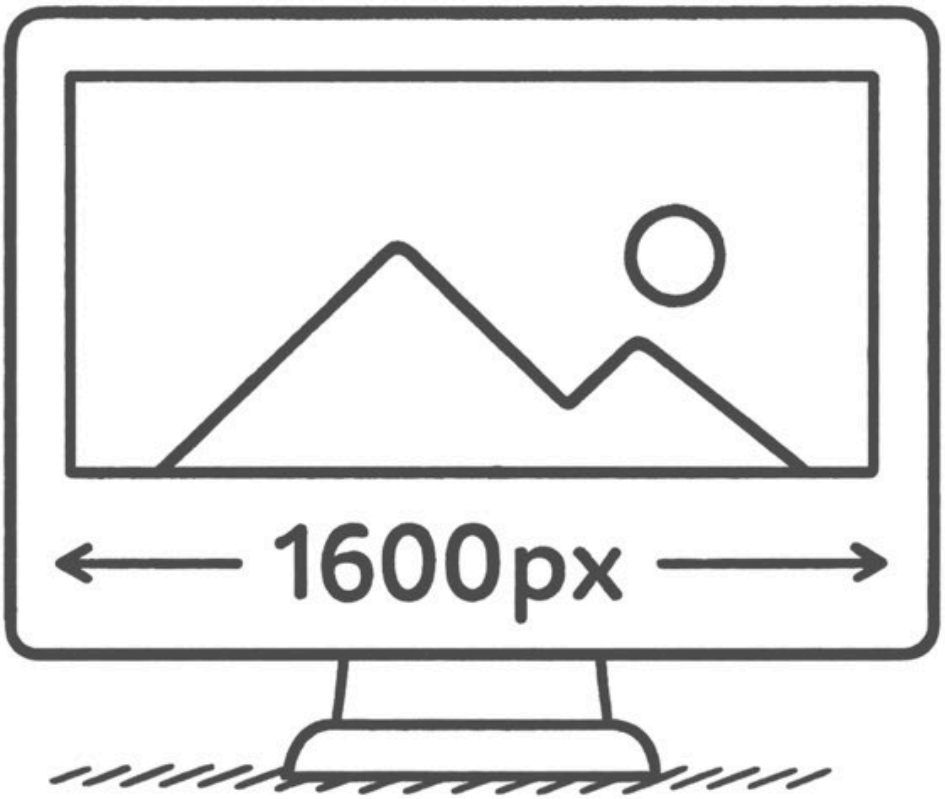
Aim to include one image for every 200 words of content. Don't treat this as a strict rule, but avoid publishing pages that are all text and no visuals. Images help break things up, make your content more engaging, and keep readers scrolling.

What image format should you use?

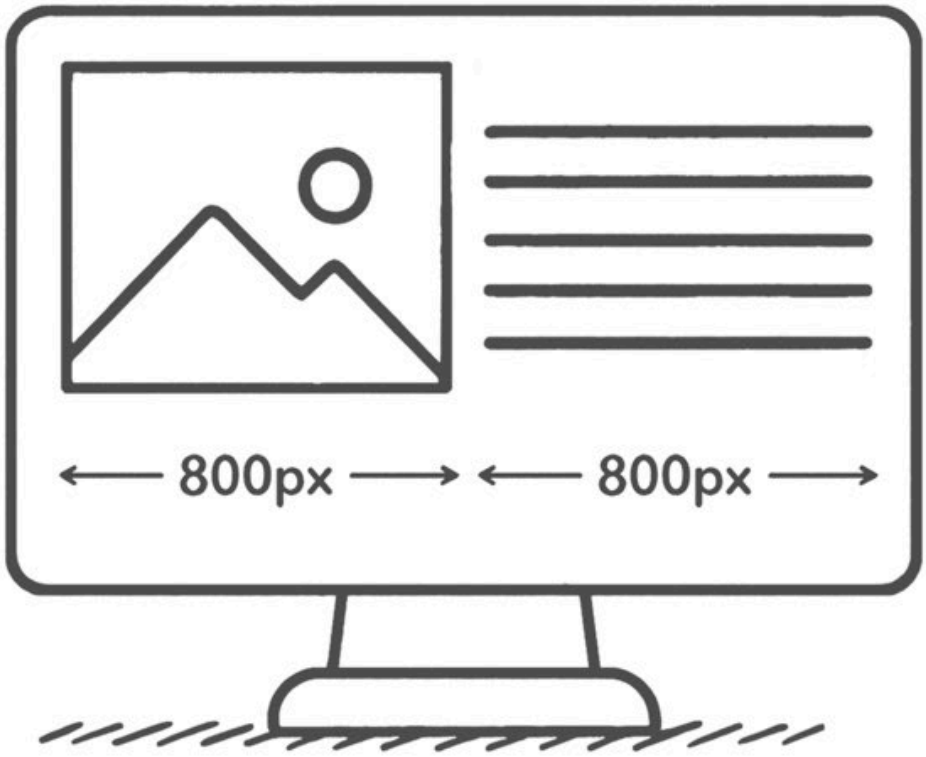
- Use **.webp** whenever possible. It gives you great quality at a fraction of the file size.
- If **.webp** isn't an option, **.jpg** is your next best bet.
- Avoid **.png**s unless absolutely necessary. They're higher quality, but the large file sizes can slow down your site. (And most users won't notice the visual difference anyway.)

Image sizing (in pixels, px)

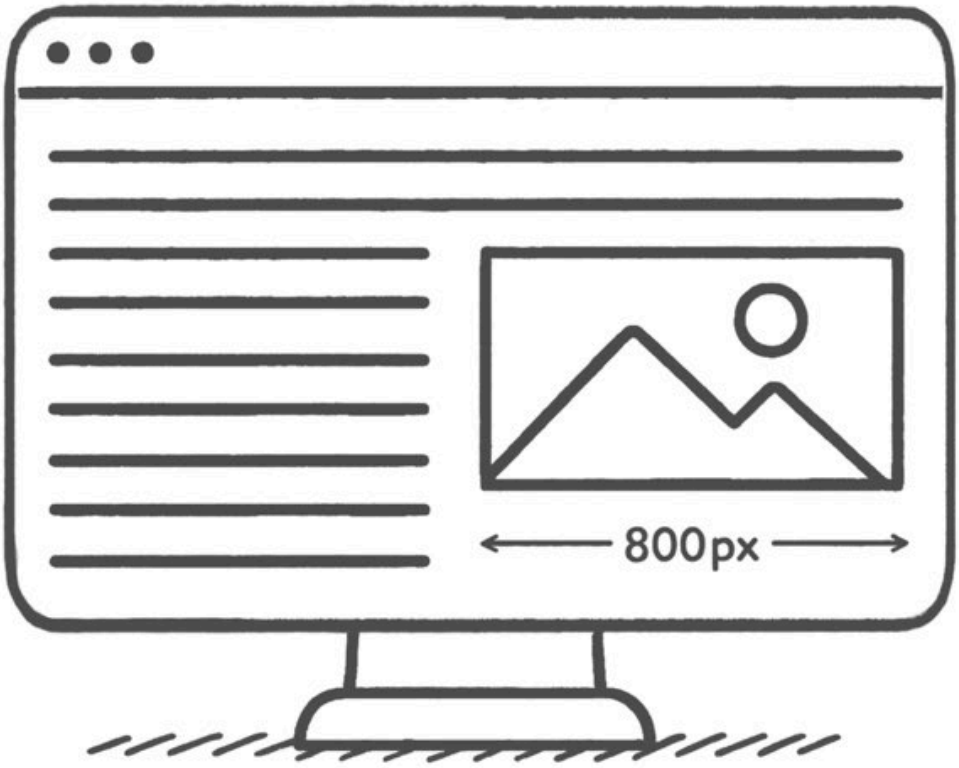
These are general guidelines that work well for most modern websites.



Full-width images (banners, hero sections):1600px wide max



Half-width images (side-by-side with text):800px wide max



In-content blog images (within paragraphs):800px wide max

File size (in kilobytes, KB)

Try to keep your images under 250KB each.

With **.webp**, you can often get file sizes under 100KB, even for large images.

Smaller file sizes = faster loading times = better user experience and SEO.

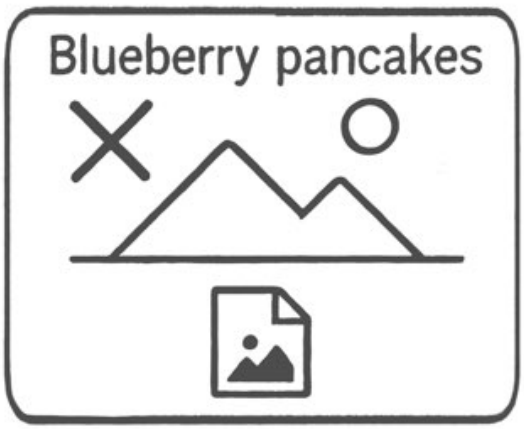
CHAPTER 13

Image Alt Text

ALT TEXT (ALTERNATIVE TEXT) PLAYS AN IMPORTANT ROLE in both accessibility and SEO. It's essentially hidden text attached to an image that serves two key purposes:

- It describes the image to search engines.
- It provides context to users relying on screen readers, especially those with visual impairments.

You've probably only *noticed* alt text when an image fails to load because what shows up is the alt text describing the image that should've been there. Otherwise, it's invisible to the average user.



Because alt text isn't visible 99% of the time, some people try to use that field as a place to sneak in extra keywords. Don't do that. It's called keyword stuffing, and as I've mentioned before, Google's smarter than that. Search engines have seen this trick a thousand times, and they'll ignore and maybe even penalize you for it.

Instead, treat alt text like a quick, helpful explanation of what the image actually shows. If you can include a relevant keyword naturally, great—but

make clarity the priority. Done right, alt text adds value for your users and gives search engines more context to understand your content.

And in case you were wondering, alt text is how your images show up in Google Image Search. If your image has clear, relevant alt text, it has a much better chance of appearing in image results. It's a small detail that can drive a lot of extra traffic over time.

Crafting Effective Alt Text

The best practice is to be as descriptive and accurate as possible. Your alt text should:

- Clearly identify the medium (photo, illustration, graphic).
- Describe what's in the image.
- Include relevant details that might help with the search.

Imagine an image of blueberry pancakes.

- **Bad alt text:** "pancakes," too vague and ineffective
- **Better alt text:** "stack of blueberry pancakes in a kitchen," provides more detail and context
- **Best alt text:** "illustration of a stack of blueberry pancakes in a kitchen," specifies the medium and gives complete context



> **Pro tip:** Add your focus keyword as alt text in 1–2 images when possible.

CHAPTER 14

Videos

THIS IS THE FINAL CHAPTER OF PART I, which means you're almost through the entire on-page SEO section. And look at that, it's not nearly as complicated as it first seemed, is it?

I saved video for last because, unlike other on-page elements, it's not *required*, but when done well, it can be incredibly powerful. Like images, heading tags, and bullet points, video helps break up text and add extra context to your content. But video has one major advantage none of those other elements do: It keeps people on your website longer.

And when people stick around? Google notices. Longer time spent on page is a strong signal that your content is resonating with visitors, which can help you move up in the search rankings.

That said, creating original video takes time and effort, so here's the good news: You can absolutely embed videos from other creators if they help explain your point or walk users through a step-by-step process. We're here to help the user first and foremost, so if a YouTube tutorial adds value, include it.

Just keep in mind: Embedding someone else's video means you're helping *that* video rank higher, not your own content. That's why, whenever possible, it's better to include your own video. It reinforces your brand, builds trust, and positions *you* as the expert.

And let's be honest, you might've picked up this book because you saw a video of me first, right?

Embedding vs. Uploading

I've mentioned embedding your videos already, but let's talk about why that's the method I recommend, and what to avoid.

Embedding a video means taking a small piece of code from YouTube (or another video hosting platform) and adding it to your website. This allows the video to *appear* on your site, but it's actually being streamed from the hosting platform. That's a good thing: It saves your website from having to handle the video load itself, which keeps your site fast and smooth.

Now, there *is* another option: uploading the video directly to your website. And I'll say this clearly, *don't do it*.

When you upload videos directly to your site, you're using your own server's resources. That means more bandwidth usage, longer load times, and a sluggish user experience, especially on mobile. And when your website slows down? Google notices. That can hurt your SEO, pushing you further down in the rankings and making it harder for people to find your content in the first place.



So, keep it simple (and smart): Use platforms like YouTube, Vimeo, or Loom to host your videos and embed them into your site. You'll get all the benefits without sacrificing speed or performance.

Get more views with video

Google indexes one video per page. That means even if it's an embedded YouTube video, Google can pull that video into search results, giving that

page an extra chance to show up, especially if it aligns with what people are searching for.

Whether it's your home page, a blog post, or a landing page, video can be a game-changer. Use it intentionally, and it can elevate everything else you've built on the page.

Recording Your Own Video

I get it, recording your own videos can feel intimidating. But here's the truth: You don't need a fancy camera, expensive lighting, or a full-blown studio to create something helpful or engaging. All you really need is the phone in your pocket.

Seriously, that's what I've built my business on: videos filmed on my phone. And you don't even need to pay for editing software anymore. Most social platforms have built-in editors, and tools like Canva make it super easy to create simple, polished videos without any technical know-how.

Remember the story I shared earlier about fixing the valve cover gasket on my 2000 Chrysler Neon? The video that helped me? It wasn't high quality at all. The guy had his phone on a tripod and talked me through each step. That was it. But I could see and hear everything clearly, and that made the video incredibly useful.

That's the key. Clear visuals and clear audio. That's all your viewer really needs.

And if you work in the digital space, there's another great option: screen recording. I've used tools like **Loom.com** to record everything from tutorials to full training programs. It shows your screen, and you appear in a little circle at the bottom, talking through each step. It's not "high production," but it's high value, and that's what matters most.

Whether you're filming with your phone or sharing your screen, just start. Your video doesn't need to be perfect, it just needs to be helpful.

Using Video to Write Blog Posts Fast

If writing isn't your thing—like, actually sitting down and typing out blog posts—you're going to love this: You don't have to do much of it. This strategy uses video as the starting point, and with the help of AI, you can turn it into a helpful blog post (and more) in no time.

Remember how Marcus used to spend his days answering customer questions about pools, then go home and write blog posts based on those conversations? Well now, thanks to AI, that same process is faster, easier, and honestly, better.

There are two simple ways to start.

Option 1 (my favorite):

If you're already on virtual calls with your team or clients, record those conversations (with their permission). Let them know it's for internal use, training, process improvement, or content creation, not for public sharing.

Option 2:

Fire up a Zoom call or your phone's camera and hit record. Just talk through answers to the questions your customers ask you all the time.

The goal is simple: Answer real questions on video. By doing this, you're naturally sharing your expertise, experience, and unique perspective on the topic, all of which makes your content truly original and valuable. And that's exactly what search engines are looking for.

Once you've got the recording, you can use the transcription as your starting point. There are a ton of free tools that you can use to get your transcription. My favorite way to get a transcription is to upload the video to YouTube—they auto transcribe every video. Then you can upload that transcript to an AI tool like ChatGPT to help you shape it into a structured, well-

written blog post in a fraction of the time it would take to write from scratch.

This is one of the easiest, most effective ways to create content that's authentic, useful, and SEO-friendly, without ever facing a blank page.

With that in mind, make sure you're actually applying the principles from this book. Don't just copy and paste whatever AI like ChatGPT gives you. Sure, the content might sound polished, but you're the expert, and it's up to you to double-check, fact-check, and personalize the information so it reflects your voice and experience.

Once your draft is ready, enhance it by adding heading tags, images, and video to create a stronger user experience. And here's a bonus tip: If you started with a video, you can even use AI to refine your script, then upload that video to the blog post. It's a full-circle content strategy.

Looking ahead, that same transcript can also fuel social media content. AI can help you turn it into hooks, captions, short-form video scripts, and more. One video = endless content potential.

> To get a tutorial showing you how to go from transcript to blog post,visit https://getfoundbook.com/transcript.

PART II

OFF-PAGE SEO

PROLOGUE

The Power of Off-Page SEO

IN 2014, SOME FRIENDS AND I launched an online publication, basically a blog, but with higher ambitions. Our mission? To "broaden the horizons of potential lifestyle choices." Translation: We featured people living in vans, building off-grid Earthships, traveling as digital nomads, and chasing unconventional paths. We were nobodies in the publishing world. No media contacts. No connections. Just stories we believed in and the drive to get them seen.

One day, while my business partner and I were brainstorming dream collaborations, we came across a massive Canadian media conglomerate. They owned radio stations nationwide, each hungry for cool, alternative content. But they were a total long shot for us. We didn't know a soul there.

Fast forward a few months. The phone rings. It's a local number. On the other end? That exact company. They'd heard about our publication. Not only that, they wanted to meet… at their national headquarters. To pitch us our own idea.

They rolled out the red carpet. We met with division heads, discussed integration strategies, and left with contracts in hand. Oh, and they wanted to sell our ad space across Canada.

Shortly after that, *Vice* reached out. But this time, they didn't just want to feature us. They wanted to sell our ad inventory to their clients, which included Apple, GM, Google, and Anheuser-Busch. This was big money. Then came StumbleUpon and Google+. Both wanted to feature our content and boost our visibility on their platforms. But here's the thing: We didn't reach out to a single one of these companies. They found us.

And the snowball didn't stop there. Other blogs and websites started sharing and linking to our content. Within months, we had thousands of

sites linking to us, daily traffic from other businesses, and a tidal wave of credibility. Search engines noticed and our rankings soared. And that, my friend, is the power of off-page SEO.

It's not just about who's visiting your site, it's about who's talking about you, linking to you, and recommending you to others.

Let's dive into how to build that same kind of off-page momentum for your own business.

CHAPTER 15

Introduction to Off-Page SEO

THIS IS THE PART OF SEO that tends to confuse people the most, off-page SEO. These are the elements I get asked about constantly, and for good reason. They feel mysterious, harder to control, and often misunderstood. But don't worry, we're about to clear that up.

While this section may be shorter than Part I (on-page SEO), that doesn't mean it's any less important. In fact, some off-page elements carry even more weight when it comes to building authority and increasing your visibility in search results.

We're going to break down each component of off-page SEO, one by one. Each piece gets its own mini-chapter so you can clearly understand how it works and how to take action. By the time you're done, you'll have a no-fluff roadmap for boosting your rankings beyond your own website.

On-page SEO covers everything *on* your website that you can control, things like content, images, internal links, and keywords.

Off-page SEO, on the other hand, is all about what happens outside of your website that influences how well it ranks. These are things like backlinks, brand mentions, social signals, and your overall online reputation. You don't "own" these elements or control them directly, but they send strong signals to Google about your credibility and authority.

So why does off-page SEO matter? Because without it, great content can still go unseen. You could have the best, most optimized pages on the internet, but if no one's linking to them, talking about them, or engaging with them, Google assumes your content isn't worth much. That's where off-page SEO comes in. It's how you build trust with search engines and climb the ranks.

Just like with on-page SEO, all of these off-page elements feed into search engine algorithms—those ever-evolving formulas that determine what content gets shown and what gets buried. While the algorithm itself may be a mystery, the fundamentals we'll cover here are proven, repeatable, and essential to long-term success.

Why Great Content Alone Isn't Enough

Here's the thing most people misunderstand about SEO: *The best content doesn't always rank at the top*. Why? Because search engines don't just look at what's on your page, they also look at what's happening outside of it.

When Google first launched, its original algorithm was called PageRank. The challenge? There were already millions of web pages online and that number was growing rapidly into the billions. Google needed a way to determine which ones were shown first.

Their solution was smart: Instead of only analyzing the words on a page, they also looked at how many other sites were talking about that page or company. In other words, popularity and credibility mattered. If other websites were linking to a page, Google saw that as a vote of confidence. This became the foundation of off-page SEO, and it's still a huge part of how search engines determine which content truly deserves to rank at the top.

Today, Google's algorithm is far more advanced than it was back in 1998, but PageRank is still a core part of how rankings are determined. While a ton of other signals now factor into search results, the concept of evaluating a site's trust and authority based on who's linking to it is still at the heart of how search engines decide which pages deserve to be at the top.

Every element in Part II is focused on one thing: building trust and reputation for your website in the eyes of both users and search engines.

CHAPTER 16

Link Building (Backlinks)

GETTING OTHER WEBSITES TO LINK TO YOURS is one of the most powerful ways to show search engines that your content is credible, trustworthy, and worth ranking.

Think of backlinks like someone citing your work to support their own. It's just like school. Remember when your teachers made you cite your sources? They weren't trying to be annoying, they just wanted to make sure you weren't pulling facts out of thin air.

Search engines work the same way. When another site links to yours, it's like saying, "Hey, this content backs up what I'm saying." That link tells Google your content is the source, and that makes it way more likely to show up higher in the results.

This might sound a little intimidating, and you might be thinking *Why would anyone want to link to me? There are millions of people online who are more experienced or more credible than me. How good does my content have to be for someone else to reference it?*

Here's the good news: You don't need to be a scientist, a researcher, or have a PhD for your content to be worth linking to. You just need to share what you *actually know*, and do it in a helpful, clear, and trustworthy way.

Let's say you've been working as an arborist (aka a tree expert) for the last 20 years. You've seen it all. You know exactly what's wrong with a tree just by looking at the leaves or the bark. Even better, you live in a region where a certain type of tree gets a very specific kind of disease, and you've dealt with it countless times.

Now, even though there are millions of arborists in the world, you might be one of only a few people in your area with that exact hands-on experi-

ence. If you write blog content that helps homeowners diagnose what's wrong with their trees, that information becomes valuable.

Let's take it one step further. A local landscaping company is writing a blog post about common plant problems in your city. Rather than pretend to be an expert on tree diseases, they might link to your article for a more in-depth explanation. Why? Because you've already done the hard work. You've written something useful, based on real experience, and now *your* site becomes the trusted source.

Your Authority Score

There are two types of authority (or credibility) scores when it comes to off-page SEO: domain authority and page authority.

Domain authority

Domain authority is a measure of how trustworthy and credible your entire website is, based on the total number and quality of backlinks pointing to all your pages. Think of it as your site's overall "trust score" in the eyes of search engines.

It's measured on a scale from 0 to 100, with higher numbers indicating stronger authority. Sites like Facebook, Wikipedia, LinkedIn, and Medium rank near the top, but don't let that discourage you. Most businesses fall somewhere between 0 and 30.

At first glance, that might seem low… but remember you're not competing with Facebook. You're competing with other businesses in *your* niche. Your goal isn't to be the biggest website on the internet; it's to outrank your direct competitors.

A quick note: Domain authority isn't a term coined by Google. It was originally developed by an SEO software company called Moz as a way to estimate a website's ranking strength. However, recent Google data leaks

have confirmed that Google does use its own version of domain authority, even if it doesn't call it that publicly.

So while the score itself is a third-party metric, the concept behind it is very real, and very relevant.

Page authority

While domain authority measures the credibility of your entire website, page authority zooms in on just one single page. It's a score that reflects how reputable that individual page is, based on how many backlinks it has, and more importantly, how high-quality those backlinks are.

You don't necessarily need a higher domain authority than your competitors to outrank them. If your page authority is higher, because that specific page has earned strong backlinks and signals of trust, you can break through and outrank bigger sites, even if their overall domain carries more weight.

Not All Backlinks Are Created Equal

Let me paint a picture for you. We're back in high school, prom season is around the corner, and it's time to vote for prom king and queen. Now, just like in SEO where not all backlinks carry the same weight, not all endorsements for prom royalty hold the same influence.

The popular kids (high-authority sites)

These are the most well-known, respected kids in school, the ones everyone listens to. If one of them endorses someone for prom king or queen, everyone pays attention.

That's the SEO equivalent of getting a backlink from a site like *The New York Times*, *Forbes*, or a top-tier industry blog. These links are pure gold.

They carry serious weight and can boost your authority big time.

The average students (mid-level authority sites)

These are the kids who are liked and respected, but not exactly running the school. Their votes still count and help sway opinions, just not as powerfully.

This is like getting backlinks from reputable blogs, local media outlets, or niche sites. They may not be household names, but they're solid, trustworthy sources that help build your site's reputation.

The new kid (low-authority or spammy sites)

Then there's the new kid, or worse, the kid with a bit of a *reputation*. They haven't earned trust yet (or have already lost it), so their endorsement doesn't help much. It might even backfire.

That's the equivalent of a backlink from a low-quality, spammy, or irrelevant site. Best case? It's ignored. Worst case? It could actually hurt your rankings.

Bottom line: quality over quantity when it comes to backlinks. A few powerful endorsements can do way more than a hundred weak ones. Aim for links that actually boost your credibility, not ones that just check a box.

What Is a High-Quality Website?

A high-quality website is one that search engines trust. These are the sites that consistently rank well, attract organic traffic, and are seen as reliable sources of information.

It's easy to point to household names like *Forbes* or *The New York Times* and say, "Yeah, obviously those are high-quality websites." And they are, but they represent the *top tier* of authority.

The good news? You don't need links from websites like that to improve your rankings.

There are millions of websites with domain authority scores in the 30–60 range that are still considered high quality. These sites might not be famous, but they can have tens of thousands of backlinks and attract millions of monthly visitors. And search engines trust them.

So what actually makes a website high quality when it comes to authority?

- It gets consistent organic traffic from search engines and other sources.
- It has a strong backlink profile, with links from other trustworthy websites.

Would a backlink from *The New York Times* be amazing? Absolutely. But let's be honest, that's probably not happening tomorrow. Unless you've got a contact on the inside… or you're willing to drop thousands on a PR firm.

The reality is that you're far more likely to earn backlinks from trustworthy, topic-relevant websites that most people have never heard of. And that's not just okay, it's how SEO works.

In fact, the majority of the internet is made up of these kinds of sites. They may not be household names, but they're still credible, trusted in their industries, and more than capable of boosting your site's authority. Take my site, HeyTony.ca, as an example. You won't find it on the front page of CNN, but it ranks, it gets traffic, and it helps thousands of people. That's the kind of site you should be aiming to get links from, and the kind of site *you're* building too.

Backlink Relevancy

Google has gotten *really* good at understanding what websites are about, and it uses that context to evaluate backlinks. For example, if you run a house painting business, a backlink from a hot sauce company wouldn't

make a ton of sense. There's no logical connection between the two industries. But a link from a drywaller, general contractor, or real estate site? That's much more relevant. It reinforces what your site is about and helps Google better understand the niche you're in.

So… should *all* your backlinks come from sites in your niche? Ideally, most of them should be.

Niche-relevant backlinks help Google categorize your website and strengthen your authority within a specific topic. The more of those you get, the more it signals to search engines: "This site is an expert in [insert niche here]." That said, you'll probably end up with a natural mix of both niche and general links, and that's totally normal.

Take *The New York Times*, for example. They cover everything, news, business, health, lifestyle, tech, you name it. They're not specifically relevant to any one niche, but a backlink from them? That's a massive credibility boost because of the overall trust and authority they carry.

Aim for niche-relevant backlinks as your foundation, but don't turn down high-authority links just because they're broader. Both help you build trust, just in slightly different ways.

Backlinks vs. Referring Domains

One of the most common misconceptions in SEO is that more backlinks = better rankings. But that's not exactly true.

Let's say you get 1,000 backlinks from a single website. That might sound impressive, but it doesn't carry nearly as much weight as it seems. In fact, it can actually hurt your credibility if it looks like you're trying to game the system, especially if those links come across as spammy or unnatural.

The reality is you can get multiple backlinks from the same site, and that makes backlink counts a tricky metric to rely on. That's why I focus on a different stat: referring domains.

Referring domains measure how many unique websites are linking to your site, regardless of how many times each of them links to you. This is a

much stronger signal to search engines that multiple, independent sources trust your content, and that's what builds authority.

In my experience, referring domains matter more than backlink totals. A thousand links from one site don't hold nearly the same weight as a hundred links from a hundred different, trustworthy sites.

So when you're tracking your progress, focus on the diversity of your backlinks, not just the volume. Quality and variety always win.

Backlinks to Avoid

Not all backlinks are good backlinks. In fact, there are certain types, and entire strategies, you'll want to avoid altogether. These are the kinds of links commonly used by spammers trying to game the system, and they fall under what's called "black hat" SEO. (And yes, this is the *first time* I've mentioned "black hat" in this book, for a reason.)

Black hat SEO techniques may work in the short term and you might even see a quick spike in rankings. But the moment Google rolls out a core algorithm update (and they *will*), those are the people you'll see flooding forums and comment sections saying things like, *"My traffic disappeared overnight!"* or *"SEO doesn't work!"*

I've been doing SEO for over a decade, and not *once* have my websites, or my clients' sites, lost rankings due to an algorithm update. Why? Because I don't use shortcuts. I stick to strategies that are built to last. The same strategies we talk about in this book.

Here are the types of backlinks to avoid.

Private Blog Networks (PBNs)

PBNs are networks of websites that are owned or controlled by the same person or company, and their sole purpose is to create backlinks. You'll often see these advertised as cheap, fast ways to build links, and sure, you *can* buy backlinks from these networks.

But here's the catch: You're not the only one buying their links. Thousands of other websites are doing the same thing, which makes your backlink profile look just like everyone else's. Google's algorithms are incredibly advanced and have gotten very good at detecting these patterns.

Google actively penalizes websites that rely on PBNs. Even if you see a short-term boost in your ranking, it's only a matter of time before you're hit by an algorithm update or even a manual action, meaning your site could be removed from search results entirely.

Link farms

Link farms are kind of like PBNs' chaotic cousin. Instead of being one person's controlled network, link farms are collections of low-quality websites that exist purely to exchange or sell backlinks.

These often include websites with spun content, irrelevant topics, or articles stuffed with random links. The people behind them somehow have access to a large number of sites (don't ask how, they just do), and will "place" your link across a bunch of them, usually without much rhyme or reason.

While a few of these sites might look "okay" on the surface, most are low-quality and spammy, and linking from them offers zero long-term value, and in many cases, can harm your rankings.

Reciprocal linking

This is when two websites agree to link to each other. It was one of the earliest attempts to game the algorithm, way back in the late '90s and early 2000s. The strategy was simple: *"Hey, we'll link to you if you link to us."* And for a while, it actually worked. But search engines quickly caught on.

Here's the problem: When two sites link to each other just for the sake of rankings, it muddies the waters. Who's the true source of information? Which site should Google consider more relevant or authoritative? It's like

two people referencing each other in a research paper without any original data; it creates a loop with no clear value.

That said, not all reciprocal links are bad. If you genuinely partner with another brand or business—maybe you collaborate on content, share audiences, or support each other's work—it makes total sense for you to link to each other. In those cases, a few reciprocal links are completely natural and won't hurt your rankings.

The key is *intent*. If the link exists to help users and makes contextual sense, you're good. If it's just there to boost rankings, it could raise a red flag to search engines.

To sum things up: If it feels shady, it probably is. Stick to ethical, earned backlinks from real, relevant websites. Google's whole mission is to reward great content, not manipulation. And as someone who's been in this space for over a decade, I can tell you from experience: The slow, legit route always wins in the long run.

Dofollow vs. Nofollow Backlinks

When a website links to another site, it can add a little tag in the code that tells search engines how to treat that link. That tag determines whether it's a Dofollow or Nofollow backlink.

Dofollow backlinks

The default backlink in most website builders and content management systems is Dofollow. Unless you change it manually, any link you add is probably Dofollow. In the code, it looks something like this: **rel="dofollow"**, though in most cases you don't even need to write it; it's assumed.

A Dofollow link passes authority (also known as "link juice") from one site to another. These are the types of links you want when building your backlink profile, as they help increase your rankings and credibility in Google's eyes.

Nofollow backlinks

A Nofollow link, on the other hand, includes the tag **rel="nofollow"**. This tells search engines, *"Hey, don't pass any authority to the site I'm linking to."* Why would someone use this?

- To protect their own site's authority
- When linking to sponsored content or user-generated content
- If they don't fully trust the destination site but still want to include the link

Here's the thing: Nofollow links aren't totally useless. Even though they technically don't pass authority, they still help create a natural-looking backlink profile, and they can drive referral traffic. Plus, Google has said that it may choose to ignore the Nofollow tag in some cases, especially if the link is coming from a trusted source.

So what does this mean for you?

Focus on earning Dofollow links, but don't stress if you're picking up some Nofollows along the way. A healthy backlink profile includes a mix of both. That balance is what search engines expect to see.

I Got 400,000 Backlinks from One Website...

In 2022 while working on my own SEO for HeyTony, I accidentally proved my theory about backlinks vs. referring domains. Here's what happened. I had asked a client if I could add a little credit in their website footer, something like "Website built by HeyTony." They agreed, no problem. Since I built the site, I assumed it had maybe 20 or 30 pages max. What I didn't realize was that their site included a forum, and every single post and reply had its own URL.

A month went by and I was checking our backlinks on Semrush, and to my surprise we had almost 400,000 backlinks... seemingly overnight. But

the odd thing was that our referring domains didn't go up by much. Maybe 10 or 20.

I felt the blood leave my face, and my stomach drop. Did I just mess up all the SEO I had been doing? Was Google going to ban my website? Did a competitor buy a bunch of trash links in an attempt to tank my rankings and take over the top spots on Google? What was going on here? (By the way, this shady practice of buying bad backlinks to your competitors does NOT work anymore!)

I checked the backlinks (and referring domains), which is super easy to do using a tool like Semrush or Ahrefs, and it looked like they were all coming from one site. *My client's site.* Not a big deal, I thought. I could just remove the link from my client's site and things would go back to normal. But then I got curious. I wondered if that many backlinks would have ANY impact on my website—good or bad. So I left them.

I had to test this backlink strategy. What if this was a winning strategy for my clients? We could look like heroes. I had severe doubts that it would do any good, but I wondered how bad it could be? Sometimes we inherit clients with bad backlink profiles, meaning they have a ton of backlinks from a handful of websites.

So as any good marketer would do I had to test the theory. *I would NEVER test a theory or hunch this massive on a client site. Our goal is to get them results, not destroy their websites.*

A couple of months passed, and I noticed something concerning. My spam score shot up to 61%. That's *very* high. For reference, spam scores typically range from 1% (great) to anything above 30% (not great). And mine was suddenly deep in the danger zone. At that point, I pulled the plug and removed the footer link. Then I waited.

Every day, I checked my Semrush dashboard to see when those backlinks would drop off. It took almost a year. But here's the unbelievable part… *My rankings never dropped*. Not once. They only went UP. Even after the bad backlinks were all gone, we were still climbing the ranks and getting more traffic!

What I Learned About Backlinks

Search engines like Google and Bing don't seem to put much weight on multiple backlinks from the same website. Sure, they might count the first 5 to 10, but anything beyond that? Those links are likely ignored, or at the very least, heavily discounted.

Now, I'll be clear: this is just my educated guess. Google doesn't reveal the inner workings of its algorithm (and I don't have a backdoor to their algorithm), but based on my experience, and the 400,000 backlinks experiment I accidentally ran, I think this is how they handle it. Here's why.

For years, shady "marketers" were buying massive amounts of spammy backlinks and pointing them at their *competitors'* websites in an attempt to knock down those competitors in the rankings. That tactic is called negative SEO, and yeah, it's as sleazy as it sounds. (Quick PSA: Don't do that. It's a dick move, and it doesn't work anymore.)

So to prevent people from gaming the system like that, Google likely limits how much "link juice" it will pass from a single domain, which makes sense.

And if you're skeptical about whether I really got 400,000 backlinks from one site, feel free to check it for yourself. If you have access to Semrush or Ahrefs, plug in HeyTony.ca and scroll back to late 2022. You'll see it there, the mountain of backlinks that started this whole theory.

How to Remove Bad Backlinks

Here's the question I know you're already thinking: *What if I have bad backlinks pointing to my site, and I don't have access to the site or know who owns it? How do I get rid of them?*

Here's what you can do.

1. Reach out to the site owner

Your first move should always be to contact the website owner and ask them to remove the link. If you can find a contact page or an email address, send a polite message asking for removal.

> **Fair warning:** They might invoice you to do it. It sucks, but it happens.

2. Use Google's Disavow Links tool (with caution)

Google does have the Disavow Links tool, which basically lets you say, "Hey Google, please ignore these backlinks; they're spammy and I didn't ask for them." But here's my recommendation: Don't use it. Seriously, just don't.

Unless you *absolutely know what you're doing*, the Disavow Links tool can do way more harm than good. We've seen cases where a client (or their old agency) went overboard with disavowing links and completely tanked their traffic and rankings. You never know how much a backlink is actually helping your website's authority.

Google's own advice

Google recommends using the Disavow Links tool only if both of these conditions are true:

- You have a large number of spammy, artificial, or low-quality links pointing to your site, AND
- Those links have caused (or are likely to cause) a manual action against your site (you'll see this notification in Google Search Console).[1]

In almost every other situation, you're better off ignoring low-quality links or trying to get them removed manually by contacting the site owner.

Google is *very* good at recognizing spam these days, and they'll usually ignore bad links on their own.

So stick with Option 1, monitor your backlink profile, and don't panic if you see a few sketchy links. It's part of being on the internet.

How Many Backlinks Do I Need?

I hate this answer as much as you do, but... it depends. And honestly, it's not just about the total number of backlinks, it's about the number of referring domains (remember, that means how many *unique* websites are linking to you).

You could have 100 backlinks from one site, and that's going to be *way* less valuable than one backlink from 100 different sites. Why? Because search engines care more about diversity and trust than sheer volume.

Some websites, especially niche ones, can rank with just 10 to 20 referring domains. But if you're in a competitive space, you might need hundreds or even thousands.

Let me give you a real-world example. At the time of writing this book, HeyTony.ca has 548 referring domains. Our main local competitors? They've got thousands. But guess who gets more traffic? *(Spoiler alert: It's not them.)* It's not just about quantity; it's about quality, relevance, and how well your site is optimized overall.

Want a smart way to figure out how many links you might need?

- Look at the top-ranking sites for the keywords you want to rank for.
- Use a tool like Semrush or Ahrefs to check how many referring domains they have.
- Then start reaching out to those same websites and see if you can get a link too.
- Or, if you want to get a little sneaky, ask them to replace your competitor's link with yours. (Be careful about it. This might upset your competitors if they find out!)

The goal isn't to play dirty, it's to earn better links by offering something more valuable, helpful, or up-to-date. That's how you win long term.

How to Get Backlinks Organically with Helpful Content

Brian Dean of **Backlinko.com** built over 5,000 backlinks to his website, for free and without spending any time doing outreach. His secret? Reverse outreach.

Remember back in Chapter 10 when we talked about external links? (If you don't, here's a quick refresher: When you cite a source in your content and link out to another website, that's called an external link from your perspective. For the site receiving the link, it's called a backlink. Same link, different name, depending on which side you're on.) Instead of asking others to link to you, you get them to ask you.

If I said, "90% of Canadians prefer 8-ounce mugs over 12-ounce mugs," I'd need to link to a study backing that up, *unless I'm totally making that up… which I am in this case*. But if that study *did* exist and I linked to it, I'd be giving that website a backlink. That's exactly what Brian capitalized on.

Brian created content that journalists, bloggers, and other writers would naturally want to link to when writing their own articles. One great example: his blog post on TikTok user statistics in 2022.

He knew major publications would be looking for reliable, up-to-date data, and if his post became the *source*, they'd link to it. And they did. We're talking links from Bloomberg, **Inc.com**, *Business Insider*, and a bunch of other massively popular publications. Normally, getting backlinks from sites like that is next to impossible. But Brian didn't have to beg for them, he just made himself the source.

How can you use this strategy?

It's simple (but not easy). You need to create genuinely helpful, original content that others will want to reference. The catch is that you have to do it consistently. Every week. Not every post will get traffic or earn backlinks, but if you don't publish, you'll never know which one could.

Here's proof it works. My team (shoutout to Denroi) wrote a blog post about next-gen image formats, and we didn't do any outreach for it. No emails, no begging for links, just solid, well-explained content. And guess what? It picked up natural backlinks from relevant websites, and it helped us rank #1 on Google for that topic.

All we did was publish genuinely helpful content. That's the game. That's how you earn links that last.

Can You Rank by ONLY Getting Backlinks?

I had a client recently who was eager to rank higher on Google, but paid ads were completely off the table. Not because their business was shady or doing anything illegal, but because they're in a heavily restricted industry that isn't allowed to advertise on major platforms like Google Ads, Meta, or TikTok. Tough spot, right?

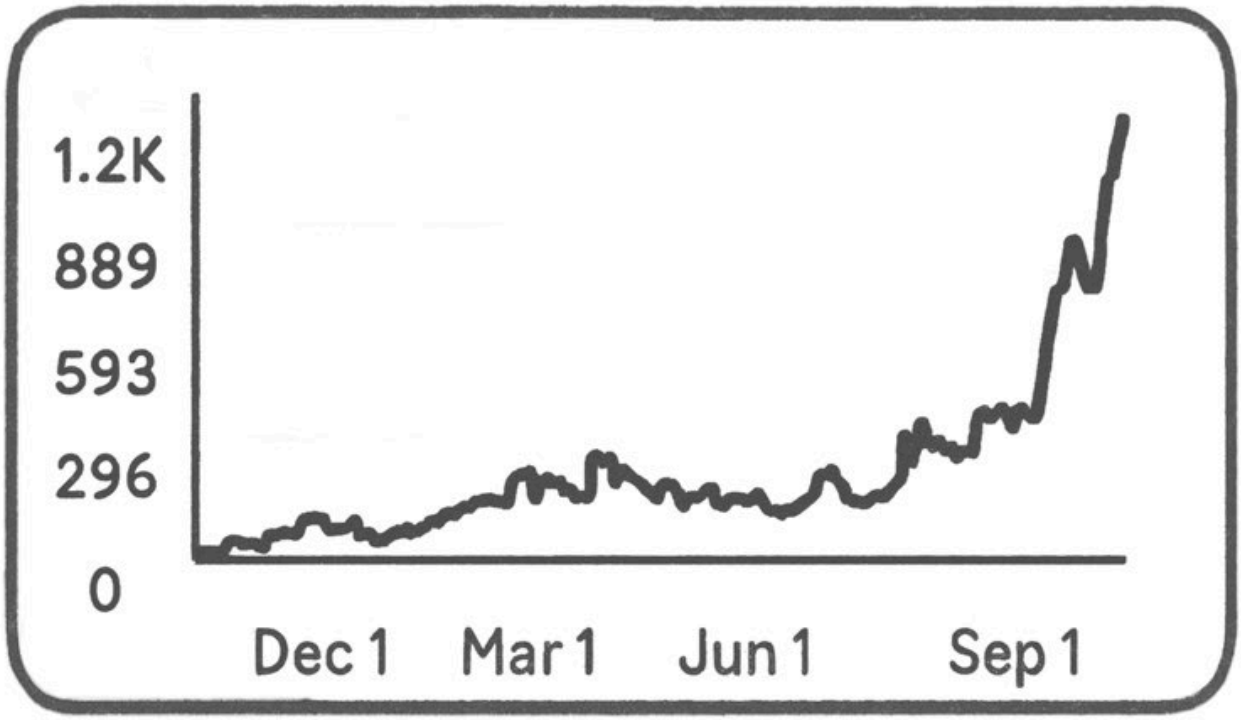
To work around this, they had launched a few microsites, basically one-page websites that were adjacent to their main business and sat in a gray area where ads were allowed. (For the record, I don't recommend this strategy… but hey, you do you, boo.)

They came to us asking if there was any way to drive organic traffic to these one-page sites. Since the microsites converted really well with paid traffic, the client figured ranking them organically could be a huge win. But here's the problem: They were one-page websites. No blog. No content strategy. Nothing to optimize other than… well, that one page. The only real option left? Backlinks.

I told the client straight up, using backlinks probably *wouldn't* work. But considering the limitations, it was the only play we had. So in August we got to work building high-quality backlinks to those one-page sites. And

then… something surprising happened. A few months later, they started ranking. And not just ranking, they were getting organic traffic.

This chart shows their traffic increase from the backlink-only strategy.



I do not recommend this as a strategy. If you want the best, most sustainable SEO results, you need helpful content *and* high-quality backlinks working together.

But in rare cases like this, where content isn't an option? Backlinks might just be enough to move the needle.

Can You Rank Without Getting Backlinks?

Sometimes, clients force your hand, usually because of budget constraints. And that's exactly what happened with Michael's company.

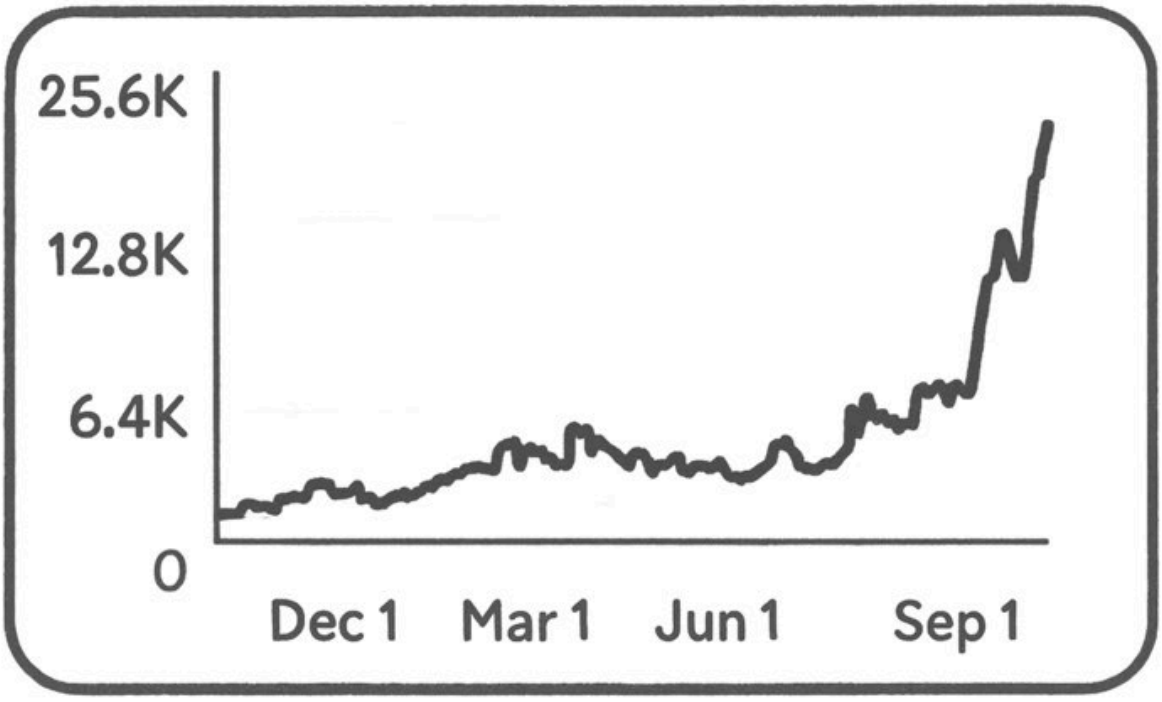
Michael had been working with another SEO agency for over six months and hadn't seen any results. Not even a *small* shift. Just the same vague promises you hear from so many SEO "experts": "The results are coming. SEO takes time." Which is true… but you should still see *some* momentum after six months. So, he reached out to me.

He'd been following me on social media for a while, knew I was legit, and decided to hire my team to take over. (See? Content marketing works. More on that in the next chapter.)

For the first few months, we followed our full SEO process, on-page + off-page, content + backlinks. And things were starting to move. But around month four, his budget tightened, and he asked me to cut backlinks from the strategy.

I told him this wasn't ideal: Sites that rank well almost always have a healthy number of high-quality backlinks. But he insisted, so we paused the off-page work and focused solely on on-page SEO.

And then something unexpected happened. His traffic grew. And he started ranking for more keywords, month after month.



I'm *not* saying backlinks don't matter. They absolutely do. But this was a great reminder that solid on-page SEO can still move the needle, especially in less competitive niches or when the technical foundation of a site is strong.

Would I build a long-term SEO strategy without backlinks? Nope. But if you're just getting started, don't underestimate what great on-page SEO can do.

My Favorite Backlink Strategy

One common backlink strategy involves reaching out to other websites and asking them to link to your content because, surprise!, you think it's amazing. This is often referred to as guest posting or link insertion, and in theory, it can work. But here's the catch: It's incredibly time-consuming and, unless done really well, often leads to being ignored or marked as spam.

Here's a typical email I get almost daily from people employing this strategy. (Note, don't do this.)

Subject: I LOVED your recent blog post

Hi Bob,

I hope you're having a great day!

I'm a huge fan of yourwebsite.com and I really loved your blog post [blog post title]. It was thorough and a great read!

I recently wrote a blog post called [blog post title] that I think your readers would absolutely love. I was wondering if you'd be willing to link to it from your blog post!

Seriously, keep up the great work!

Best, Jim

Now, I'm going to be honest. The first time (or even the first few times) you get one of these backlink request emails, you might feel a little flattered. *"Wow, someone read my content and wants to link to it? That's kinda cool!"* Don't fall for it.

These people are sending hundreds, if not thousands, of these emails every single day. They're using automation tools to scrape websites, find contact info, and fire off templated messages. And no, they didn't read your blog post. They probably don't even know what your site is about.

So what does this have to do with my favorite backlink strategy?

Instead of getting annoyed or ignoring these emails, let's make them work for us.

If someone's reaching out asking you for a backlink, that means they're already trying to build links, and are likely open to a fair exchange. So here's how I respond:

Hi Jim!

I would love to link to your website, but momma didn't raise no fool.

I'll add your link to that blog post; however, I need something in return.

Can you get me a link from a 3rd party website with a decent domain authority? One that isn't linking to or from the website you want a link from?

If you can accommodate this request, I'd be happy to add your link!

Please send me the link to the article linking to mine when it's published and at that point I'll add your link to my site.

Cheers, Matt

This is my favorite backlink strategy for 2 reasons: 1. It's free. And 2. It takes no effort on my part.

Those people flooding your inbox asking for a backlink? They're usually not trying to get a link for *their own* website. They're doing it for a client. And because they're sending out thousands of these emails a day, chances are they manage several sites, and one of them might be a perfect fit for you to get a backlink.

So when you reply and say you're open to a link exchange, they'll go out and find a backlink for you just to get their client one in return. All because you responded.

They're doing the legwork. You just reap the reward.

Okay, but here's the truth: This is still my second favorite strategy. My #1 favorite will always be: Create content so good that people link to it organically.

That's the ultimate backlink win. It's *truly* free, sustainable, and requires no outreach, no negotiating, no spreadsheets, just helpful content that earns links naturally.

CHAPTER 17

Content Marketing

ONE OF MY FAVORITE PIECES OF ADVICE when it comes to marketing is this: "Give away for free what other people charge for." That's the heart of content marketing. Not only does it help you reach more people, but it also builds trust, authority, and thought leadership for your business. When you consistently show up and *actually help people*, they remember you, and they come back.

Now, technically, blogging is content marketing, but it also falls under on-page SEO since it lives on your site. So why am I talking about content marketing here, in the off-page SEO section? Because blogging is just one piece of the puzzle. And while it's incredibly powerful for building awareness, authority, and backlinks, there are other forms of content that can work *off your site*, and play a major role in building backlinks, brand mentions, and overall visibility.

Content marketing fuels off-page SEO too. And we're going to dig into how to use that to your advantage.

The key is to share knowledge and insights without overtly promoting your brand. I know that sounds counterintuitive. After all, what's the point if we're not actively promoting our business?

The first thing most businesses do is slap their logo on everything they create. That mindset comes from old-school advertising—billboards, TV commercials, brochures—where you had to include your logo so people knew who you were.

But today, people are bombarded with so many ads that they've learned to tune them out. The only way to break through is with content marketing that actually provides value.

Social Media

While social media has a relatively small impact on your search rankings, it's still a ranking factor worth paying attention to. Once you publish a blog post, make sure to share it on platforms that support link sharing, like Facebook, Twitter, Reddit, and Pinterest.

Links that get high engagement and shares send a signal to search engines that your content is valuable and worth showing to more people.

Technically, these are backlinks, but they don't carry the same weight as a link from another website. Why? Because anyone can share a link on social media; it doesn't necessarily mean the platform is endorsing your content.

However, when you share your links on social media and people actually click through, you're showing search engines that you're not a one-trick pony; you're a legit business attracting visitors from multiple channels. That kind of diversity helps build trust and authority in the eyes of search engines.

And not only that, but you're reaching more potential customers with your content.

What about platforms like Instagram and TikTok, the ones that are more visual and don't allow clickable links in captions? Surprisingly, they can still help your SEO, just in a different way.

When you share videos or images on these platforms, you're building trust, awareness, and familiarity with your brand. Even if you're not posting ads or dropping direct links, your profile handle likely includes your business name, or your display name is your business name. And when people enjoy your content, they go looking for more.

They visit your profile. They click the link in your bio. That could take them to your website, a contact page, or a lead magnet (more on that soon). And when they click? That's traffic to your website, which, as you now know, is a ranking factor.

But it gets even better.

If you consistently show up with valuable content, people will start googling your business name. This is called a branded search, and it's a strong signal to search engines that your business is legit.

I get thousands of people searching "HeyTony" on Google every month, just because I post on social media. They like my content, they trust what I say, and many of them want to hire my agency to help with their SEO.

Pretty cool, right?

How social media saved my business

I know this is a book about SEO, but I'd be doing you a disservice if I didn't share a bit about my journey into content marketing, because it changed everything for me.

At the start of 2023, my business was at an all-time low. I had just parted ways with my biggest client, and there were no new leads in sight. Up until then, I was running a referral-only business. That meant I had no control over when the next client would come in. I was just hoping someone, somewhere, would send work my way.

The lull in my business wasn't for lack of trying. I ran ads. I hired experts to help me fill my calendar. I took courses. I even ran placements in newsletters. But I wasn't doing the two most obvious things: SEO and organic social media.

Yes, you read that right. *The guy writing the book on SEO wasn't doing SEO for his own business.* And I still kick myself for that. But hey, what's that saying? *The shoemaker's kids go barefoot.* That was me.

Then one day in 2022, a friend casually mentioned that the agency he worked for got all their leads from SEO. That comment stuck with me. Thanks, Dave.

Around the same time, I realized I wasn't doing any content marketing either. No blogs. No videos. No social posts. Nothing.

That January, I hit a wall and made a decision. I had to start putting myself out there.

I was burning through business books, hoping one of them had the secret. Then I read *Jab, Jab, Jab, Right Hook* by GaryVee (Gary Vaynerchuk) and it hit me like a truck: There's never been a better time to be an entrepreneur. Social media is free. So why wasn't I using it?

Right after that, I read *The ONE Thing* by Gary Keller and Jay Papasan. It asked one simple question: "What's one thing you can do every day that will make everything else easier or unnecessary?"

My answer? Create one short-form video a day. No more waiting on referrals. No more praying for leads. Just consistent, helpful content.

I was skeptical. I'd read a lot of books that made big promises. But I figured I'd give it a real shot, one full year. If it worked, great. If not, at least I could say I tried.

So on January 11th, 2023, I started posting a video every single day to Instagram and TikTok, teaching entrepreneurs how to do their own SEO. And at first? Nothing happened. Three months in, I had maybe 250 followers. My videos weren't hitting. I wasn't making money. It felt pointless. But I remembered what one client had told me: Give away 99.99% of your knowledge, and people will handsomely pay you for that last 0.01%. So I kept going.

In April, I pushed myself harder. One video a day wasn't enough. I started posting three videos per day, even though I was barely coming up with ideas for one.

Three months passed. I had over 300 videos up… and only 1,500 followers. I felt defeated. I was close to quitting. My brother asked if I was making any money from this, and when I told him no, he said I should stop wasting my time. But I had made a promise to myself: one year. I was halfway there. I could finish. I had to finish.

A week later, I posted a video that went viral, over a million views. The week after that? Another viral hit. I went from 1,500 followers to 15,000 in two weeks. And I was hooked. The dings, the DMs, the buzz: I was finally reaching people.

By the end of 2023, I had over 100,000 followers, a full client roster, and more inbound leads than I could handle. And here's the wild part: I never

once said I was for hire or shared my business name. I just gave away helpful content. I showed up. I shared what I knew. That's content marketing.

Podcasts

Yes, podcasts… As my social media started to grow, so did the podcast invites. People wanted to interview me. And honestly? My first thought was: *"Who the hell wants to hear from me?"* I was just a marketing nerd making videos from my home office, trying to help people understand SEO. But I figured, why not? So I said yes. To everyone.

Your first podcast? Let's do it.

You train dog trainers? Sure, I can talk SEO for them!

At one point, I landed a spot on a massive podcast, one I later found out gets hundreds of thousands of downloads. And of course… I completely lost my train of thought mid-episode. They kept that segment in. Classic.

But then something interesting started happening. In every podcast's show notes, they'd include links to my website, social profiles, and free downloads. Wait... my website? The same one I'm trying to rank higher on Google?

I hadn't realized it at first, but every time a podcast episode goes live, it's published on the podcaster's site, and distributed to platforms like Apple Podcasts, Google Podcasts, Spotify, etc. Which means high-quality backlinks. From reputable sources. All pointing to me. And I wasn't paying a cent. I was just showing up and sharing what I knew.

Moral of the story? Say yes to podcasts. As many as you can. Or better yet, start your own. And hey, if you happen to have a podcast about digital marketing or small business, email me. I'd love to be a guest.

Just like posting visual content on social media, being a podcast guest helps you build trust, grow awareness, and position yourself as a thought leader.

And there's an added bonus: it can also lead to more branded searches. The more people hear your name and your message, the more likely they

are to google you, check out your content, and eventually… become a customer.

Email

Email marketing is one of the most efficient and effective forms of content marketing out there. Once someone's on your list, you can reach them for free, anytime, with messaging that's targeted and relevant. Even better? You can send them content they didn't even know they needed.

Let's say you run a handyman service. Every spring, you email your subscribers a spring maintenance checklist, something genuinely helpful they can do themselves. And that checklist? It's actually a blog post you wrote years ago that's still relevant today.

Now you're driving traffic to your website, building trust, and casually reminding your audience that you're still around when they need help.

That spike in traffic tells search engines that you're a legit business attracting visitors from multiple sources. And if people bookmark or share your checklist? Even better. Those are extra signals that help boost your credibility, and your rankings.

Here's the thing about content marketing—it's not about making quick sales. It's about building relationships. When you consistently provide valuable resources, you become the go-to expert in people's minds. Then, when they actually need services like yours, guess who they think of first?

CHAPTER 18

Off-Page Local SEO

THIS CHAPTER IS FOR BUSINESSES that serve a specific local area— think window cleaners, electricians, therapists, chiropractors, barbers, coffee shops, restaurants, and the like. If your goal isn't to expand nationally or internationally, and you've got plenty of customers right in your own backyard, you're in the right place.

If that *doesn't* sound like you, feel free to skip ahead. But if it *does*, I've got great news: Ranking locally is way easier than trying to rank on a national or global level.

Your customers are searching for local solutions using phrases like "near me" or including their city or neighborhood in the search. That means you're *not* competing against every other business across the country that offers the same service. In fact, you might not even be competing with the business across town.

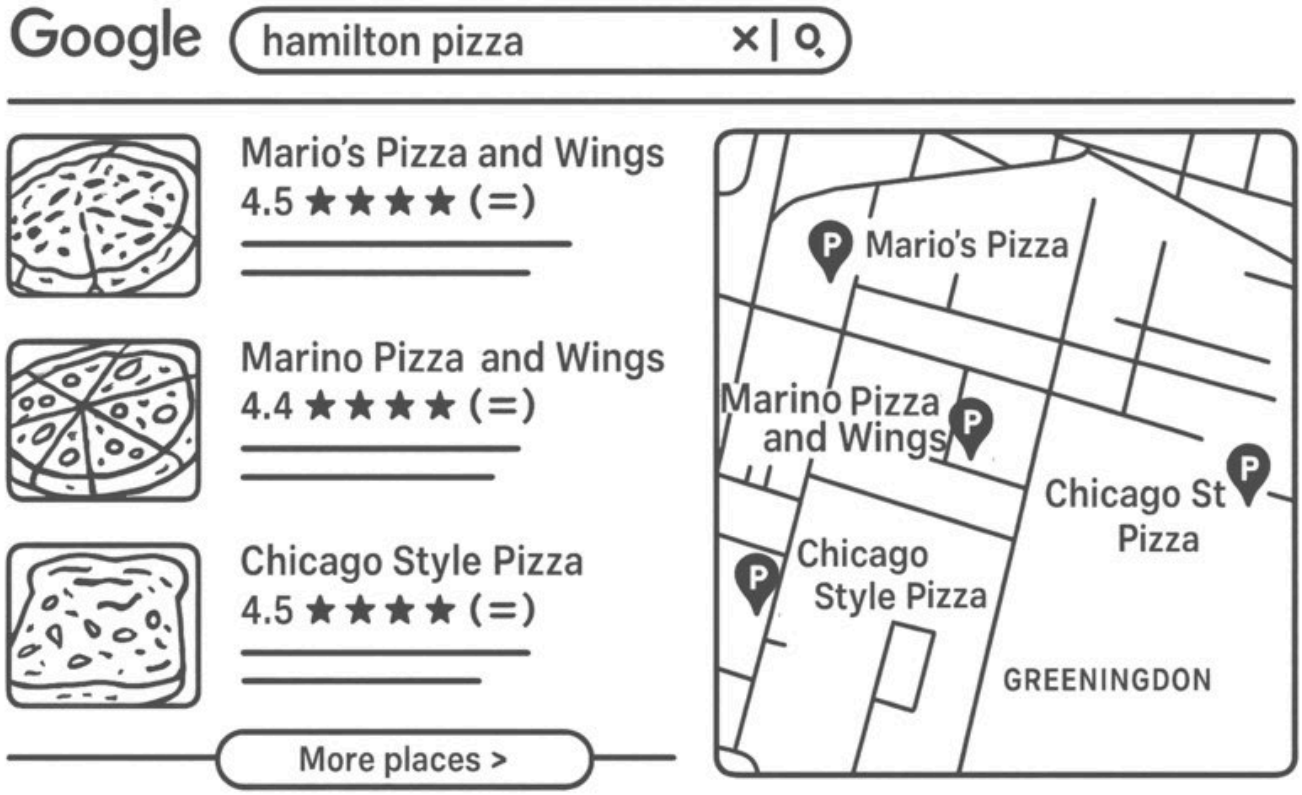
Let's say you're a dentist in North York (a neighborhood in Toronto). Your future patients aren't going to drive all the way to Liberty Village, an hour away, when you're just a few blocks from home.

That's the beauty of local SEO. It narrows the competition *and* connects you with people ready to take action, right in your neighborhood.

How to Rank Locally

There are two places your business can show up in local search results:

1. The Map Pack, that box at the top with the map and 3 business listings



2. The organic results, the regular blue links underneath the map

Ideally, you want to show up in both. And to do that, you'll need to cover a few key steps.

1. Claim & optimize your Google Business Profile (formerly Google My Business)

If you want to appear in the Map Pack, a Google Business Profile is absolutely non-negotiable.

Once your profile is verified, make sure it's fully optimized:

- Add your services, pricing, and business description.
- Set your hours of operation.
- Include your phone number, website, and address.
- Upload a menu if you're a restaurant.
- Choose the most accurate business category.



This is one of the strongest local signals you can send to Google; it tells them you're a legitimate business that serves a specific location.

> **Pro tip:** Once you've set up your Google Business Profile, you can import it into Bing Places for Business, which is Bing's version of a Google Business Profile, in under a minute. Bing only controls about 5% of the search market, but that's still traffic your competitors are probably ignoring. Grab it.

2. Submit to citations & directories

Think of sites like Yelp, Yellow Pages, 411, or Foursquare. These are called local citations or directory listings.

They typically display:

- Business name, logo, and category
- Address and phone number
- Business hours, website, and description

They matter because:

1. They help search engines verify your legitimacy.
2. You often get a backlink (not the strongest, but still something).
3. Real people use these platforms to discover businesses.
4. Reviews on these platforms (especially Yelp) are ranking signals for local SEO.

> **IMPORTANT:** Your Name, Address, and Phone Number (NAP) must be identical across all platforms. No exceptions.

Tools like Semrush or BrightLocal can automate your submissions and make sure everything stays consistent.

3. Get reviews

Reviews are one of the most powerful ranking signals in local SEO. They tell both search engines and real people that you're a trustworthy business.

Here's the thing: Reviews alone won't shoot you to the top of the map pack, but without them you'll never rank.

If you're just starting out and your competitors have hundreds or thousands of reviews, don't panic. They all started at zero. The key is to collect reviews consistently over time.

And no, don't buy fake reviews. That can tank your rankings or get you banned from Google altogether.

Instead, start asking real customers to leave honest reviews. Text them. Email them. Ask them while they're still smiling after a good experience.

The Strategy for Acquiring Reviews

Ready for the big strategy?

Just ask. Ask your customers or clients for a review after they've purchased from you or used your service. I know, it sounds obvious. But you'd be shocked at how many businesses completely ignore this. Or worse, know they *should* ask and just… don't.

Let me tell you a quick story. I met Pedro, a local HVAC business owner, at a Chamber of Commerce event. He was frustrated, and said all his competitors were stealing his customers and pushing him further down the search results on Google. He told me he didn't have the budget to hire an SEO agency and flat-out asked: "What can I do to rank higher on Google myself?"

I asked him how many jobs he was doing a day. His answer? 10 to 20. And I told him the truth: "The easiest thing you can do is start asking your customers for reviews. And you don't even have to do it yourself, have your team ask."

A full year and a half went by before he finally started asking. And during that time? His competitors kept climbing… while his business kept dropping in the rankings. Pedro's story isn't rare. I've heard it over and over again.

Small business owners complain that SEO is a scam or doesn't work, but when you ask if they're even doing the basics, like collecting reviews, the answer is often, "That's too much work." Look, I get it. You're busy running a business. But trust me: Asking for reviews is one of the simplest and most powerful things you can do to improve your local SEO.

Become a Pillar in Your Local Community

This strategy goes a little beyond traditional off-page SEO, but since it happens *off your website* and can help boost your rankings, I'm including it here.

Becoming an active part of your local community doesn't just make you feel good, it can actually lead to high-quality backlinks from local businesses, directories, and news publications. But more than that, it lets you promote your business without actually "advertising." Let me explain.

When you show up at networking events, community initiatives, charity drives, sponsorships, you start building relationships and getting your name out there. People get curious. They google your business. They mention you in newsletters. They link to your site. All without you having to say, "Hey, hire me!" It's the most organic form of exposure you can get, *and* it earns you trust, credibility, and authority, both with people and with search engines.

I signed up for my local Chamber of Commerce on December 31st, 2022. Why do I remember the exact date? Because my business was struggling, and I was determined to start 2023 strong. So there I was, working on my business on New Year's Eve. (Classic small business owner move, right?)

I actually discovered the Chamber while doing some competitor backlink research. I noticed a pattern: Lots of my local competitors had backlinks from the same places. One of those was the Hamilton Chamber of Commerce. So naturally, I wanted those links too. One of the strategies we use at HeyTony is to make sure we're on par with our top 3–5 competitors. If they've got a backlink from somewhere, we want it too. That's literally why I joined the Chamber, for the backlink.

But then something unexpected happened. I got a welcome call from the Chamber telling me about all these other perks I now had access to. The one that stood out? Networking events.

At the time, I was working from home, leading a fully remote team, and spending about 99% of my time alone. I had just moved to Hamilton and didn't know a single person in the city. So I figured, "Why not?" Free food, a drink ticket, and maybe a chance to meet people in the same boat.

I'll be real, I was terrified to go to that first event alone. What if I stood around awkwardly? What if nobody talked to me? What if I was *that guy* standing in the corner pretending to check his email?

To take the pressure off, I gave myself two rules:

1. Don't talk about myself.
2. Don't try to sell anything.

And you know what? Yeah, it was awkward for the first few minutes. But here's the thing: Everyone's there to meet people. Total strangers walked up and started conversations. And joining a group? Totally normal. They *want* you to jump in.

That one event changed everything. I ended up meeting a bunch of amazing local business owners I could actually relate to and learn from. (Shoutout to Cam, Stew, Doug, Nate, Andrew, Marcia, and Paul!) And it all happened because I wanted a backlink.

Surprising, right?

PART III

TECHNICAL SEO

CHAPTER 19

Site Speed

THERE'S NOTHING MORE FRUSTRATING than doing a Google search, clicking a result, and then… waiting.

In a world where everything is available instantly, even a 1-second delay feels like an eternity. That tiny pause? It's often enough to make someone hit the back button and click on the next result, even if that takes longer overall than just waiting a second or two for your page to load. As Veruca Salt famously said in *Willy Wonka and the Chocolate Factory*: "I want it now!"

That's your user. And that's your cue. Your job? Give them what they want, now.

If you haven't guessed yet, this chapter is all about website speed, why it matters, how it impacts your SEO, and more importantly, what you can do to make your site lightning-fast so people (and Google) stick around.

Back in 2016, Google made a big shift: They moved to mobile-first indexing. What does that mean for you?

It means Google considers the mobile version of your website as the *primary* version. Not the desktop one. Not the tablet one.

In simple terms, Google checks how your site performs on different devices, and they even test it using slower connection speeds. So if your site loads quickly on a low-end phone with bad signal, you're winning. Fast load times across all devices, especially mobile, can give your rankings a nice little boost.

Fast Loading Equals Better Rankings

It sounds nice, right? Make your site lightning-fast, and boom, top of Google. Unfortunately, it's not that simple. If speed alone guaranteed rankings, SEO would be a breeze. But that's not how it works.

Yes, faster websites have an edge. They offer a better user experience, and Google loves that. But speed is just one piece of the puzzle.

All the elements we've covered so far—helpful content, keyword usage, internal links, trust signals—they all matter. Speed just helps amplify those efforts.

If you pair fast loading times with quality helpful content, you'll be on the path to higher rankings.

The Downside of Slow Loading

Slower websites often suffer from something called a high bounce rate, which is just a fancy way of saying that people are leaving your site after viewing only one page.

We haven't covered this term yet, but it's important: Bounce rate is the percentage of visitors who land on your site and leave without clicking anything else.

Search engines take this as a hint. If people are leaving right away, it might mean your site isn't delivering a good experience, and that can hurt your rankings.

Think about it: Someone clicks your link on Google because it looks like exactly what they need. But your site loads slowly... or not at all.

What do you do? Maybe you refresh once, but let's be real, you're probably heading back to Google and clicking the next link.

And if enough people do that, Google takes notice. Suddenly, your spot at the top doesn't look so secure. It might belong to someone else, someone with faster load times and better content.

Strategies to Improve Site Speed

Improving your site speed might sound overwhelming at first, but don't worry, we're going to break it down step-by-step.

There are a few key areas that make a big difference: optimizing images, leveraging browser caching, reducing server response time, and cutting down on heavy scripts or plugins.

Since over 40% of all websites are built on WordPress, we'll start there. Then we'll touch on Wix, Squarespace, Shopify, and a few others after that.

WordPress users

Plugins

First up, plugins. As handy as they are, too many plugins can seriously slow down your site. Go through your plugins and remove anything you're not using. Even better, look for ways to consolidate. One good plugin that does the work of two or three is a win.

If you want an easy win, install a plugin like WP Rocket. It can boost your site speed dramatically with just a few clicks.

Hosting

Next, hosting. This one's huge. Think of hosting as the hard drive for your website. It's where all your images, words, and website files live. Basic hosting on places like GoDaddy, Bluehost, and others might save you money upfront, but it's going to cost you in SEO later.

Better hosting = faster site = better rankings.

I personally use CrocWeb for shared hosting and it's incredibly fast. (And no, I'm not sponsored... I just like them.)

Next-Gen Image Formats

One of the biggest culprits for slow sites? Giant image files. I've seen 10MB images being used. Yikes. Sure, they load fast for people with fiber internet, but what about the other 95% of people?

Switching to next-gen image formats like **.webp** can take a 10MB image and shrink it down to 100KB or less without losing quality.

Think of **.webp** like a smarter **.jpg**.

You can convert your images using free online tools (just google it) or programs like Adobe Photoshop.

Using a content delivery network

A content delivery network (CDN) sounds technical, but it's not scary at all. In simple terms, a CDN saves a version of your website on servers around the world so that no matter where someone is visiting from, they get your site fast.

Benefits of a CDN:

- Faster load times
- Reduced bandwidth costs
- More reliable uptime
- Extra layer of security

Setting up a CDN is usually just a few clicks (and maybe a small monthly fee). Totally worth it.

Wix & Squarespace users

If you're using a website builder like Wix or Squarespace, there's good news and bad news.

The good news: They handle most of the technical stuff for you.

The bad news: You're stuck with whatever site speed they can deliver. Your best move on these platforms?

- Optimize your images.
- Don't overload your pages with unnecessary videos, animations, or massive galleries.

Beyond that, you'll mostly have to live with what you get unless you're hiring a pro developer to dig deeper. (And even they have limited optimization options.)

Shopify users

Just like Wix and Squarespace, there's not a whole lot you can control when it comes to site speed on Shopify, unless you're a developer or you hire one.

The best thing you can do is use next-gen image formats (like **.webp**) to keep your site as lightweight and fast as possible.

If you're looking for a little extra help, I've had a few clients who have had great experiences hiring someone on **Fiverr.com** to optimize their Shopify site speed. (This is literally the ONLY time you'll hear me recommend Fiverr for anything SEO-related!)

CHAPTER 20

Mobile-Friendly & Responsive Websites

OVER 60% OF INTERNET TRAFFIC comes from mobile devices, and that number keeps climbing every year as we become even more attached to our phones for work, entertainment, and everything in between. And it's not just younger generations driving this shift. Older generations are getting more comfortable using their mobile devices to browse, connect, and buy online too.

If you haven't guessed yet, having a mobile-friendly website is absolutely crucial for your business. Making sure your site is responsive and mobile-friendly isn't just about ticking a box for Google's algorithm, it's about providing the best experience for every visitor, no matter how they find you.

Here's the good news: Most website builders today, like WordPress, Shopify, Wix, and Squarespace, come with mobile and responsive designs baked right in. It's harder than ever to accidentally build a non-mobile-friendly site. But that doesn't mean you can just "set it and forget it."

Many templates or themes still need a little fine-tuning to create a truly smooth mobile experience. And remember: User experience is a big part of SEO. If your mobile site feels clunky, slow, or confusing, you're leaving rankings (and customers) on the table.

Mobile Responsiveness & SEO

The responsiveness of your website, especially on mobile devices, is a critical factor in how well you rank on search engines. A responsive website au-

tomatically adjusts to fit any screen size, whether it's a smartphone, tablet, laptop, or even a massive desktop monitor.

Search engines want to provide their users with the best experience possible. They want people to find the information they need, fast. And since the majority of users are on mobile devices, it's no surprise Google has been using mobile-first indexing since 2016.

Even though modern website builders like WordPress, Shopify, Wix, and Squarespace come with mobile-responsive designs right out of the box, millions of websites are still falling behind. Some are built with outdated templates, some haven't been updated in years, and some get broken when changes are made to the desktop version without checking mobile.

So how do you make sure your website is truly mobile optimized?

Simple: Pick up your phone and visit your website. (Or better yet, hand your phone to a parent or grandparent and watch what happens!)

Here's what you want to look for:

- Is it immediately clear what your business does?
- Is the text easy to read?
- Does anything look cut off or go off the screen?
- Does it load quickly?
- Are the buttons big enough to tap easily?
- Can someone call you with one click?
- Can they find your contact page or checkout easily?

After reviewing your site, if you're not already ranking #1, go check out the top-ranked competitors in your area. How does their mobile experience compare to yours? Be brutally honest. If theirs is better, it's time to make some changes.

> **A note for any web designers reading this:** Make mobile experience your top priority. Desktop traffic is shrinking. Mobile is where your clients' customers are.

> **A note for any business owners reading this:** Please, I'm begging you, ditch the home page carousels (aka sliders). No one is sitting there waiting for your image to slide over to the next one, especially on mobile. Sliders just slow your site down. Replace the carousels with one clear image and a headline that actually grabs attention.

Consequences of Non-Responsive Design

Websites that don't adapt properly to different screen sizes can experience much higher bounce rates—especially among mobile users who find the site frustrating to navigate or read.

And remember: High bounce rates send a bad signal to search engines. If people click on your site, get frustrated, and immediately go back to the search results to click another site, that tells Google, "Hey, this page didn't give me what I needed." And what happens next? Your rankings start to slip.

At this point in the book, you know the golden rule: Google prioritizes user experience. If your website isn't delivering that, you're handing your competitors an easy win.

CHAPTER 21

Core Web Vitals (aka User Experience)

I KNOW, I KNOW, IT SOUNDS SUPER TECHNICAL. But here's the thing: If your website is mobile-friendly and loads quickly, you're already ahead of the game. Most of what I'm about to tell you just builds on that.

What Are Core Web Vitals?

Let me break it down in plain English: Think of Core Web Vitals as Google's way of asking, "Does this website actually feel good to use?" That's it!

They're basically checking three simple things.

1. Does your website load fast?

Also known as Largest Contentful Paint, or LCP

Your main content should load within 2.5 seconds. Remember when we talked about site speed? Same thing here. Nobody likes sitting around waiting for a page to load, especially your customers. I would even argue that your main content should load faster than that. If it's not loading instantly, you've got some work to do.

2. Can people interact right away?

Also known as Interaction to Next Paint, or INP

When someone clicks a button or a link, your site should respond in less than 200 milliseconds. In normal words: When people click something, it should actually *work*, instantly!

3. Does everything stay where it's supposed to be?

Also known as Cumulative Layout Shift, or CLS

You know when you're about to click something and the whole page jumps because an ad or image suddenly loads? And you accidentally click the wrong thing?

Yeah... Google HATES that. I hate that. And your customers REALLY hate that. Your layout should stay steady while the page loads.

User Experience Beyond SEO

We've all seen great (and terrible) user experiences.

Great user experiences keep customers happy & boost sales

You know the good ones. You go to an online store, easily find the product you're looking for, and there's a big green "Add to Cart" button staring you right in the face. No scrolling. No searching. It's just *there.*

You add the product to your cart, type in your email address, but then get distracted by an Instagram notification. You forget all about the check-out. Life goes on.

A few hours later, *ding*, you get an email: "Finish Checking Out" (with a 10% off coupon attached). You click the link, the product is still in your cart,

the discount is already applied. And oh look, they have Apple Pay and Google Pay! No need to fumble for your credit card. Five seconds later: *Purchase complete.* You get an instant email confirmation, a tracking number, and a promise your order is on its way.

On delivery day? Another email or text pops up giving you an estimated arrival window.

A few weeks later? Another email: "How's everything going? Loving your purchase? Have any questions? (By the way, you might love these other products too...)"—that's called an upsell, and when done right, it feels more helpful than salesy.

Poor user experiences frustrate customers & decrease sales

Now, let's talk about bad user experience. You see an ad for a pair of pants, *the* perfect pants. They're made for your body type. You see them on a model who looks exactly like you. These pants are magic. You click the ad… It takes you to the home page instead of to the product. Confusion sets in.

There are 20 different pairs of pants. They all look kind of the same. You can't find the ones from the ad. You dig. You click around. You think you *maybe* find them. You add them to your cart. Enter your email. You're ready to buy. But there's no Apple Pay. No Google Pay. Now you need your wallet. You're about to leave the room to grab it, but *ding!* Your best friend texts you. She's going to be a mother!

You sit back down at the computer, open a new tab, and start looking up baby names with her. A few hours later she decides on the perfect name: Heighleigh. (You love the name, hate the spelling. It's a tragedeigh.) You forget all about the pants and go make dinner.

Later, when you finally get back to your computer, those 27 open tabs are just a chaotic sea of "unique baby names" and "names that end in -leigh." Frustrated, you close them all. *And you never think about those pants again.*

No email follow-up.

No abandoned cart reminder.

No second chance.

A great user experience doesn't just keep people happy, it increases your chances of making more sales and keeps your customers from getting frustrated and bouncing.

CHAPTER 22

Schema Markup

SCHEMA MARKUP, OR STRUCTURED DATA MARKUP, is behind-the-scenes code you add to your website to help search engines better understand your content. It's not something your visitors will see, but it plays a big role in how search engines interpret what your content is about, and whether they decide to show it to people searching.

So what does schema markup actually do?

- **Gives search engines extra context:** It tells them things like your business hours, address, logo, service descriptions, product pricing, customer reviews—basically, all the stuff that makes your business easier to understand and trust.
- **Clarifies what kind of page it is:** Whether it's a blog post, product page, service page, recipe, or FAQ, Schema helps search engines categorize it correctly.
- **Can lead to rich snippets:** These are enhanced results on Google that show star ratings, pricing, event info, etc. Schema doesn't guarantee them, but it significantly boosts your chances of appearing in these attention-grabbing results.

Don't worry about learning how to write Schema code manually. You can easily generate it with ChatGPT or a schema markup tool (that's what I do).

To do this, paste your page URL or content into ChatGPT and ask it to write you schema markup for that page. It's that easy.

If you're curious about what Schema looks like, it looks like code. And unless you're a developer or just love staring at brackets and quotes, you're better off using a generator or AI to create it.

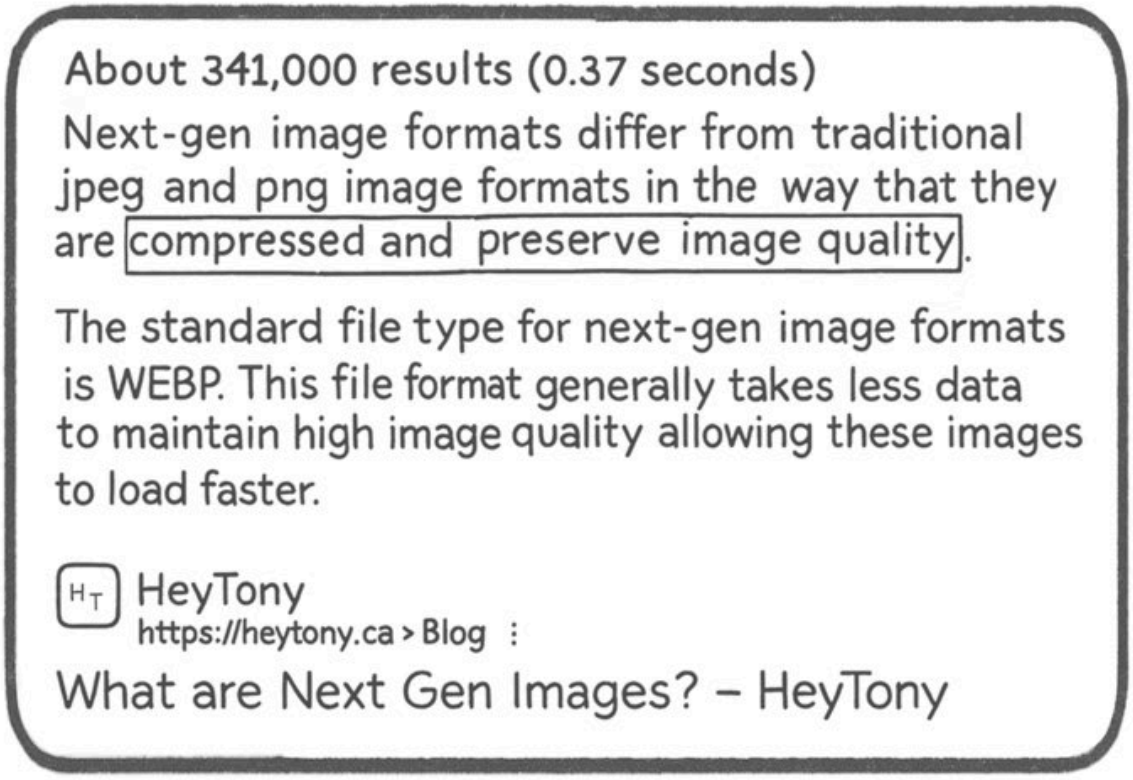
The Power of Rich Snippets

Let's consider a practical example. Imagine someone searches for "what is a next-gen image?". If your blog post about next-gen image formats has Schema markup properly set up, Google might display a rich snippet directly in the search results, like a short explanation or even a "People also ask" box with your content featured.

That enhanced listing (thanks to Schema) makes your result stand out more, increases your click-through rate, and signals to search engines that your content is worth showing to others.

It's one of those small technical tweaks that can make a *big* impact on how visible your content is, especially when you're trying to rank above bigger competitors.

Here's an example of a rich snippet.



Rich snippets are starting to take a backseat in some cases. They're either being replaced by AI-generated overviews or pushed further down the search results. And here's the kicker: Google can still feature your content in a rich snippet even if you don't have Schema markup on the page. Thanks to advancements in AI, Google's getting much better at reading and understanding content on its own. That said, adding Schema still gives you a better shot at standing out, so it's worth doing whenever you can.

CHAPTER 23

Sitemaps

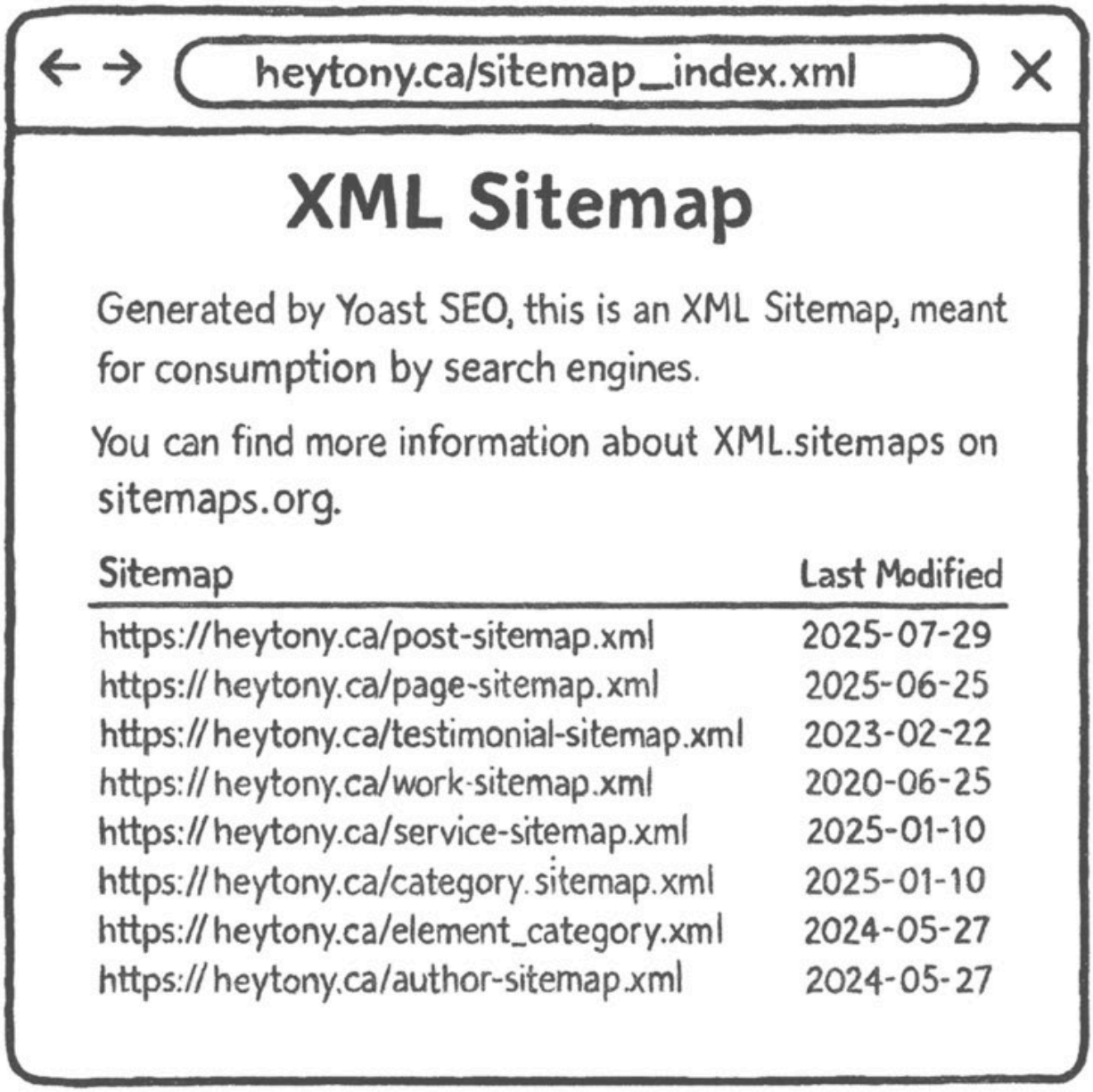
A SITEMAP IS A BEHIND-THE-SCENES FILE that lists every page on your website. It's not meant for your visitors, it's for search engines like Google. Think of it as a roadmap that helps them crawl and understand your site faster and more efficiently.

You can usually view your sitemap by going to your home page and adding **/sitemap.xml** at the end. For example: **heytony.ca/sitemap.xml**.

Most modern website platforms like WordPress, Shopify, Wix, and Squarespace automatically generate a sitemap for you. If you're using WordPress, I recommend installing the Yoast SEO plugin; it does a better job of generating a clean, well-structured sitemap than the default version.

Sitemaps provide valuable details such as:

- The date a page was last updated
- Alternative language versions of a page
- The hierarchy and relationship between different pages on your site



Submitting Your Sitemap to Google

Once you've confirmed that your sitemap exists, you'll want to submit it to Google. This helps them discover your content faster, and it's especially important if your site is brand new.

Here's how to do it:

1. Head over to Google Search Console and create an account (if you haven't already, seriously, go do that).
2. In the left-hand menu, click on "Sitemaps".
3. Add your sitemap URL (something like **yourwebsite.com/sitemap.xml**) and click submit.

Good news: You only need to do this once. Every time you publish or update content, your sitemap will automatically update and notify Google, so there's no need to resubmit individual pages. Just make sure not to submit your home page or blog posts individually; Google only wants the sitemap file.

What If You Don't Submit Your Sitemap?

Can Google still find your site? Yep, but it might take a while.

A few years ago, we had a client who was getting around 100 visitors a month when they signed on with us. Within six months, we grew that to over 10,000 monthly visitors. We used the same strategies you're reading about in this book, using internal and external linking, writing helpful content, and using the keywords in the proper places. For this client we were publishing eight blog posts or page updates per month and building four backlinks.

Naturally, we assumed their sitemap had already been submitted, since Google was already indexing their site. (Spoiler: Never assume, always double-check!) Turns out, they never submitted a sitemap at all. And even without it, we still hit 10,000 monthly visitors.

That said, if you're just starting out, or struggling to get your content indexed, submit your sitemap. It takes less than a minute and can help Google find and index your pages faster.

CHAPTER 24

Robots.txt

AS WE DIVE DEEPER into the technical side of SEO, this is one chapter you can almost certainly skip. Seriously, 99.99% of people will never need to touch their robots.txt file.

The robots.txt file is a simple text file that lives on your website. Like your sitemap, it's usually generated automatically by most website builders (WordPress, Shopify, Wix, etc.) and isn't meant for people to see.

So What Does It Do?

In short, the robots.txt file tells search engines which parts of your website they can and can't crawl. It can be used to:

- Control crawler traffic by steering bots away from certain pages.
- Prevent indexing of low-value or private pages, like tag archives, "thank you" pages, checkout flows, etc.
- Hide orphan pages, pages that aren't linked to from anywhere else on your site. (More on those in an upcoming chapter.)

Why Does This Matter for Seo?

While robots.txt doesn't directly improve rankings, it helps ensure search engines focus on indexing your most important content, rather than wasting

time on pages that don't matter.

But be careful. If you start messing around in there without knowing what you're doing, you can accidentally block important pages from being indexed. That's a fast way to tank your visibility.

My advice? Just leave it alone. Most website builders get it right out of the box. Unless you know what you're doing or are working with a developer, you're better off focusing on everything else we've covered so far.

CHAPTER 25

Duplicate Content

EARLIER THIS YEAR, Charlie reached out to me for help with his SEO. His website traffic had taken a nosedive after a recent Google core algorithm update, and he suspected his current SEO guy had fallen behind the times.

When we audited the site, we saw all the classic outdated tactics:

- Keyword stuffing in the URLs
- Thin content with absurdly high keyword density
- Blog posts clearly written for Google, not humans

Charlie was also ready for a website redesign. His agency had built his site *and* was hosting it on their own server. When he told them he was moving on, they basically held the site hostage, saying he could only keep it live if he continued paying them.

That kind of thing *really* bothers me. If you paid for a website, you should own that website.

So we started from scratch. We built Charlie a brand-new site and had him sign up for his own hosting, so he'd truly own everything.

> **Side note:** If your agency is hosting your site, you might want to consider migrating to your own server. You never know when a company might ghost you, shut down, or lock you out.

This time, SEO was baked into the site from day one. We launched with optimized service pages, a solid home page, and a few strategic blog posts.

From there, we kept publishing high-quality, helpful content with Charlie and his team.

Usually, we start seeing SEO movement by month three, even if it's small. But by month five? Nothing. No traffic spikes. No keyword gains. No movement.

We were doing everything right:

- Helpful content
- Internal linking
- Backlinks
- Preserved old high-ranking URLs and content

Still, zero traction.

I had a gut feeling something weird was happening. So I started digging through the code. And that's when I found it. A plugin was injecting over 2,000 extra words onto every page… even when it wasn't activated.

That meant:

1. Search engines saw hidden content on every page (major red flag).
2. Every page looked nearly identical to Google's crawler, triggering duplicate content penalties.

So we removed it immediately. And within a few months, their rankings started to increase!

Now we have a quality assurance process in place: If we publish 1,500 words, we double-check to see that the word count on the page matches the word count in the document where we write the content.

Take duplicate content seriously. Like, really seriously. Even copying a few sentences across pages can confuse search engines or tank your rankings.

Unique Content

Every page on your website should be unique and cover a specific topic. Not kinda-sorta different. Fully distinct.

When multiple pages on your site cover the same topic, or topics that are *way* too similar, you're running into duplicate content territory. And that can confuse both users *and* search engines.

Let's look at some examples, because I know you're probably wondering where the line is.

These page titles are unique and fine:

- Can You Bring an Apple Watch in a Hot Tub?
- Can You Bring an iPhone into a Hot Tub?

These are different products, and even though the format is similar, the content would address different concerns.

These ones? Not so much:

- 5 Top Restaurants in Hamilton
- The 5 Best Restaurants in Hamilton, Ontario

See the difference? Yeah, exactly. There isn't much of one. Even if you rewrote these slightly, the search engines (and probably your readers) are going to see the same info, just dressed up differently.

When Google finds multiple pages that look the same (same or similar content and / or images), it doesn't know which one to show users. So, it might:

- Choose one and ignore the others
- Or worse, ignore *all* of them.

Even if two nearly identical pages *do* get indexed, they're probably not going to rank well. You're just splitting your potential instead of consolidat-

ing it.

When you go after the same keyword on more than one page, you're cannibalizing your keywords (keyword cannibalization) and your rankings.

This is what happens when two or more of your pages are targeting the same keyword. You end up competing with yourself, like two team members trying to score the same goal at the same time. They'll likely end up fumbling the ball while wrestling each other for it, and give the other team an opportunity to steal. It confuses Google, weakens your rankings, and splits your authority.

Want to see if you've got duplicate keyword targets?

Use Google Search Console to see which pages are ranking for your keywords. If more than one page is showing up for the same search term, you might need to take action.

There are 4 ways to fix duplicate content.

1. **Merge content.** If the pages are similar and *neither* one is ranking well, combine them into a single, stronger page. Delete any duplicate information. *Don't do this if one of the pages is already ranking high; you might lose that spot. Instead, use a 301 redirect from the page that's not ranking.*
2. **Use 301 redirects**. If you delete one version of a page, make sure to redirect it to the version you're keeping. That way, anyone who clicks the old link will land on the right page (and you won't lose any SEO equity).
3. **Update the content**. Instead of merging or deleting, just make one of the pages different! Focus it on a new angle, a different subtopic, or a related search term.
4. **Add canonical tags**. If you *have to* keep duplicate or similar pages, you can tell search engines which version is the "main" one by using canonical tags. You'll see this often on Shopify product pages with small variations.

Managing duplicate content isn't just about avoiding penalties, it's about *consolidating your power*. Make each page on your site serve a clear, distinct

purpose, and you'll get more visibility, more traffic, and fewer headaches trying to figure out why your rankings aren't moving.

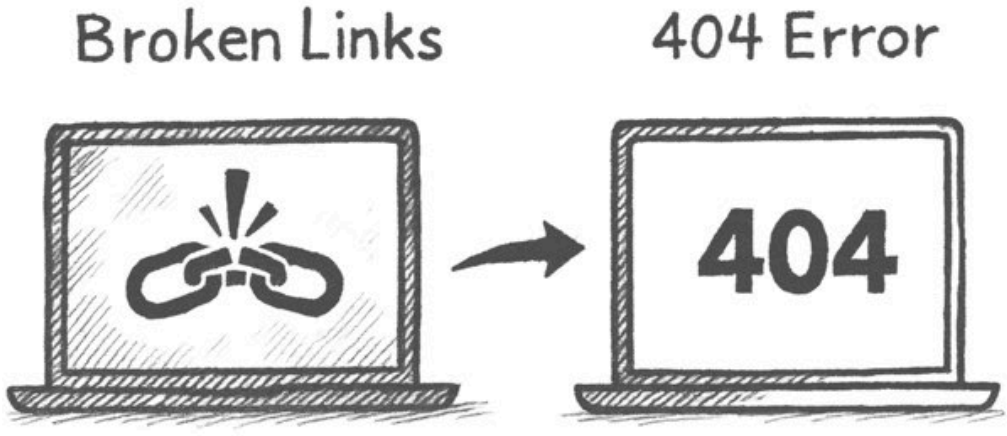
CHAPTER 26

Broken Links (404 Errors)

OWNING A WEBSITE ISN'T A ONE-AND-DONE THING, it requires ongoing maintenance. And one of the easiest things to overlook? Broken links. We're talking both internal links (links to other pages on your own site) and external links (links to other websites).

Now before you panic, no, you don't need to click every single link on your website to see if it works. There are tools for that.

SEO tools like Ahrefs, Semrush, and the HeyTony Site Audit Tool will automatically scan your site and flag any links that lead to a 404 error, which is what you see when a page can't be found.



And let's be honest: Landing on a 404 page when you're looking for something is *super* frustrating. It's a dead end, and users (and search engines) don't like dead ends.

Fixing broken links is a small but powerful way to improve user experience and keep your SEO performance strong. It tells both people *and* Google that you care enough to maintain your website, and that matters.

What Causes Broken Links?

You're doing everything right, publishing helpful content and including both internal and external links. But then, out of nowhere, one of your links breaks and leads to a page that no longer exists.

This usually happens for one of two reasons:

1. You (or someone on your team) deleted a page or changed its URL, and forgot to set up a redirect.
2. An external site updated or removed the page you were linking to, again, without setting up a redirect.

That's all it takes. Someone, somewhere, changed a URL, and now your once-helpful link sends visitors to a dead end.

The Impact of Broken Links on SEO

Broken links can quietly chip away at your SEO performance for a couple of key reasons:

- **Poor User Experience:** When visitors click a link expecting helpful info and hit a dead end, it's frustrating. That frustration can lead to higher bounce rates and fewer returning visitors.

- **Search Engine Signals:** Too many broken links tell search engines that your site might be outdated or neglected, definitely not the message you want to send if you're aiming for top rankings.

Strategies for Fixing Broken Links

Broken links are inevitable, but fixing them doesn't have to be painful. Here are a few simple strategies:

1. **Run Regular Site Audits.** Use tools like Ahrefs or the HeyTony Site Audit Tool to scan your site and flag broken links. These tools do all the heavy lifting for you. Just google them and you'll find what you need.
2. **Swap or Remove.** If you're linking to an external site that's now a 404, try to find a new, trustworthy source to replace it. If you can't? Just remove the link entirely. Broken links add no value and can hurt your credibility.
3. **Turn Broken Links Into Backlinks.** Here's a sneaky-smart SEO move: Find broken links on *other* websites you'd love a backlink from, and reach out. Offer your content as a replacement. Tools like Ahrefs can help you hunt these down. Just make sure the content you're pitching is actually useful to their audience.
4. **Create Your Own Version.** If a valuable external resource is gone, consider writing your own post on the same topic. Not only do you fix the link problem, but you now have more content to rank, better internal linking, and improved topical authority. Win-win-win.

Why Broken Links Matter (More Than You Think)

Keeping your website healthy means staying on top of broken links. Fixing them regularly shows both your visitors *and* search engines that you care about quality, and that you run a legit business.

Remember what I said earlier in the book? Ask yourself: *What would a real business do?* A real business wouldn't leave people hitting dead ends. They'd fix the issues, fast.

Managing broken links is a simple but powerful way to protect your rankings and give your audience a seamless experience.

CHAPTER 27

Crawl Depth

IF YOUR CONTENT IS BURIED DEEP IN YOUR SITE, it sends the message, to both people *and* search engines, that it's not that important. So why should they treat it like it is?

Crawl depth is all about how easy it is to find content on your website. It's how many clicks it takes to get to any given page from your home page. The fewer the clicks, the easier it is for users and search engines to access, and the more important that page appears in Google's eyes.

For years, I didn't think much about crawl depth. My rule was simple: *If a page matters, link to it from the home page or the main menu.*

But as websites grow and more content gets published, that's not always possible. And that's where crawl depth really starts to matter.

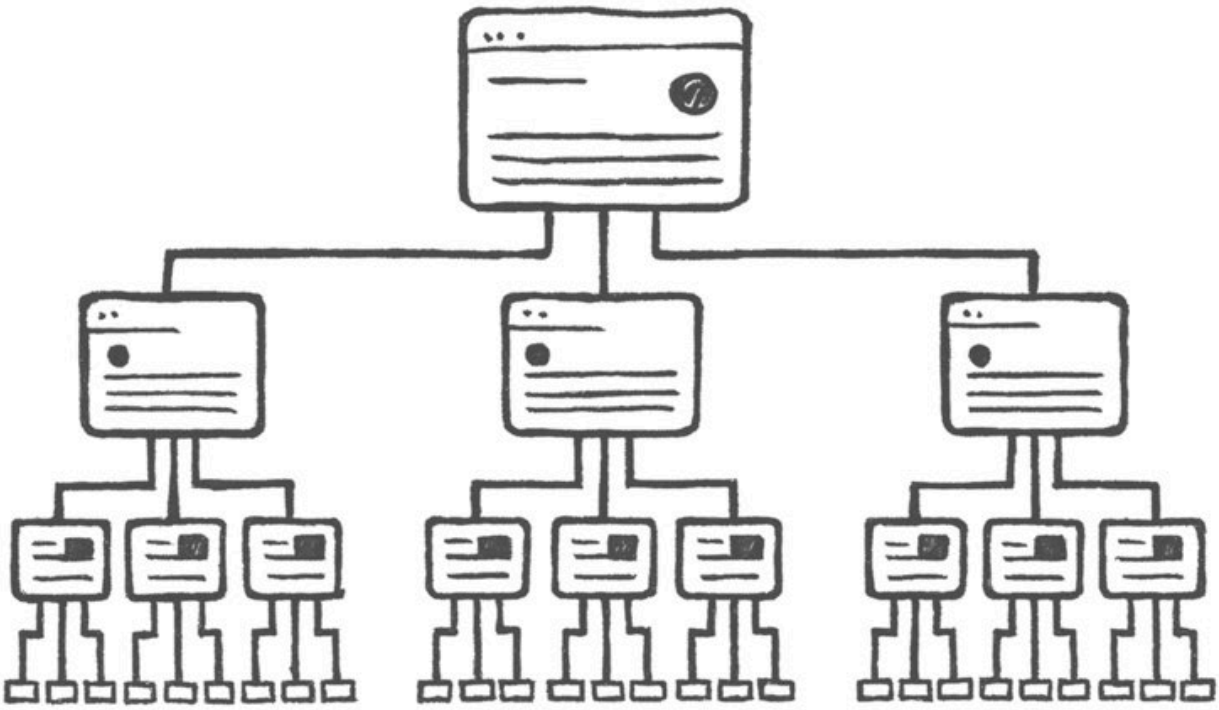
The Impact of Crawl Depth on SEO

Websites with shallow crawl depth, meaning most pages are reachable within three clicks from the home page, tend to rank better. Why? Because search engines can actually find and index all your content.

If it takes five or six clicks to access a page, Google assumes it's not that important. Even if it's the most valuable information known to humankind, if it's buried, it's basically invisible.

One of the biggest objections we hear from clients is, "Can we link to the blog but hide it so people can't find it?" If that's you, don't. If real human

users can't find your content, do you really think Google is going to care about it?



Making Your Content Easy to Find

At HeyTony, we follow a few simple crawl depth rules to make sure important content is easy to find, for both users and search engines.

Start with your navigation and footer. The most important pages on your site should be linked there. This usually includes your main service or product page (the one that lists everything you offer), your blog (to give access to all your content), and a contact page (because people need a way to reach you). You can also include links to pricing, case studies, or anything else that directly supports conversions.

Your home page should link directly to your individual services or top-selling products. This puts the things people actually want to buy one click

away from your home page.

You should also link to your blog categories directly from the home page. Keep it simple, limit yourself to 10 categories max. (You'll never need more than that.) With this setup, every blog post on your site is just two clicks from your home page one click to a category, one click to the blog post.

> **PRO tip:** Add your most recent 5–10 blog posts directly to your home page. Most website platforms have a built-in tool or widget to automate this. Now your latest posts are also just one click away from the home page.

And here's our final rule: Every time we publish a new page or blog post, we link from it to three other relevant pages on the website, and we also link *to* it from three other existing pages. That's part of the internal linking strategy we covered earlier, and it's a powerful way to boost crawlability and rankings.

CHAPTER 28

Orphan Pages

LET ME INTRODUCE YOU to something even worse than buried pages: orphan pages. These aren't just hidden deep in your website, they're completely disconnected. An orphan page is a page that isn't linked to from any other page on your site. It's floating out there on its own, totally isolated. That means users can't navigate to it, and search engines have a hard time discovering it, if they find it at all.

Identifying Orphan Pages

The first step to fixing orphan pages is finding them. You *can* do this manually by combing through your internal links, but let's be honest, that would be a nightmare. A much better option is to use a website audit tool that flags orphan pages for you automatically.

> Not sure where to start? To try out my go-to website audit tool at https://getfoundbook.com/audit (or just google "HeyTony Site Audit Tool").

Fixing Orphan Pages

All you need to do to fix orphaned pages is to link to them. A strong internal linking strategy helps ensure every page on your site is connected and

easy to find, for both users and search engines.

The simplest way to do this? Every time you publish a new page or blog post, link out to 2–3 other relevant pages on your site. Then go back and update 2–3 older posts to link *to* the new content.

This is especially effective because those older posts are already indexed. Adding links from them gives your new content a better shot at being discovered and indexed faster.

Using Landing Pages (Funnel Pages) Strategically

Sometimes you don't want anyone to be able to find a page, including search engines. Wait, this is a book about getting traffic from Google… So why would I tell you to exclude certain pages from being found?

Because not every page on your site is *meant* to rank.

Take landing pages (also called funnel pages). These are standalone pages designed specifically for marketing or ad campaigns. People don't stumble across them in search; they're sent via email, ads, or social media.

Landing pages have one job: convert. Whether it's signing up for a webinar, downloading a guide, or making a purchase, they're laser-focused on a single call-to-action. That's why they typically don't include internal links or navigation—distractions kill conversions.

Landing pages are orphan pages. And in this case, that's perfectly fine. This is a book about SEO, yes, but marketing is bigger than only SEO. Landing pages may be terrible for search rankings, but they're amazing for driving leads and sales.

If you're using landing pages, consider excluding them from your sitemap and disallowing them in your **robots.txt** file. You'll avoid confusing search engines and keep the focus where it belongs, on conversions.

PART IV

SEO TOOLS

THERE ARE HUNDREDS, if not thousands, of SEO tools out there promising to help you rank higher, track your progress, research keywords, and monitor competitors. To save you the overwhelm, I've narrowed it down to a few essentials.

That said, don't get too hung up on the *specific* tools. The most important thing is that you're actively working on your SEO. Regardless of your budget or what the tool claims to do, you really only need tools that cover a few key functions:

- **Tracking:** Monitor your keyword rankings, traffic, and user behavior.
- **Auditing:** Identify technical issues like slow pages, missing tags, or thin content.
- **Keyword Research:** Discover what people are actually searching for so you can target the right terms.
- **On-Page Optimization:** Get real-time feedback on how well your content is optimized for search engines.
- **AI & Content Tools:** Speed up your workflow by generating, refining, or designing content with the help of AI.
- **Competitor Analysis:** Keep tabs on what others in your space are doing, so you can do it better.

Technically, you could do SEO without tools, but… why make things harder than they need to be?

CHAPTER 29

Tracking Tools

Google Search Console

GOOGLE SEARCH CONSOLE is a free tool that lets you register your website with Google and see exactly how your site is performing in organic search. It shows you valuable data like clicks, impressions, average position in the search results, and click-through rate (CTR).

When it comes to understanding what keywords you're actually ranking for and how much organic traffic you're getting, this is hands down the most accurate data source available.

Here's how Google describes it:

> *Google Search Console (GSC) is a free service offered by Google that helps you monitor, maintain, and troubleshoot your site's presence in Google Search results. You don't have to sign up for Search Console to be included in Google Search results, but Search Console helps you understand and improve how Google sees your site.*[1]

So although you can still rank without signing up for an account, I highly recommend signing up. It's free and it'll take you maybe 5 minutes to create the account and connect your website.

When should you sign up for GSC?

I get it, you're excited to start ranking, but pump the brakes for a second.

It's best to wait until your website is fully launched before signing up for a GSC account. Why? Because the moment you create that account, you're essentially telling Google, "Hey, come check out my site!" And if your site is still under construction or missing content, Google will index a half-finished product, and that's not a great first impression.

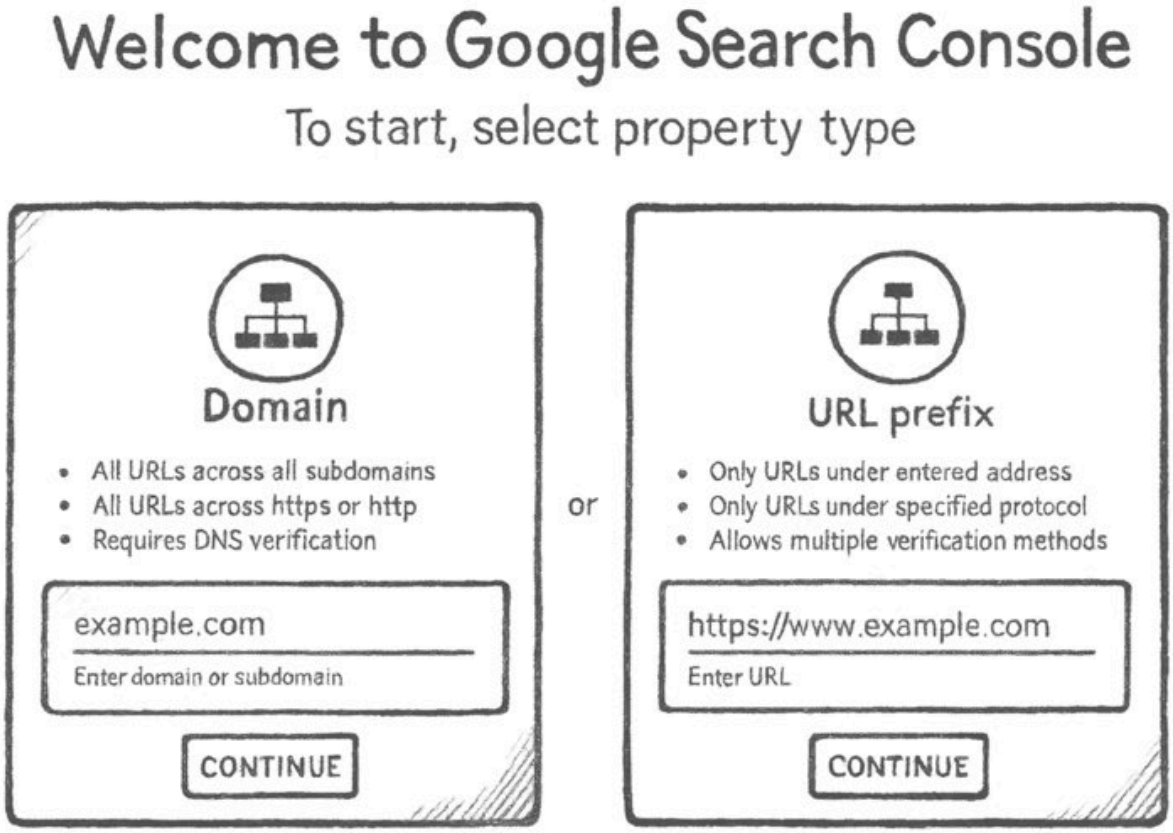
If your site is already live? Go ahead and sign up now. But if you're still building, hold off until everything is polished and ready to go.

Setting up your account

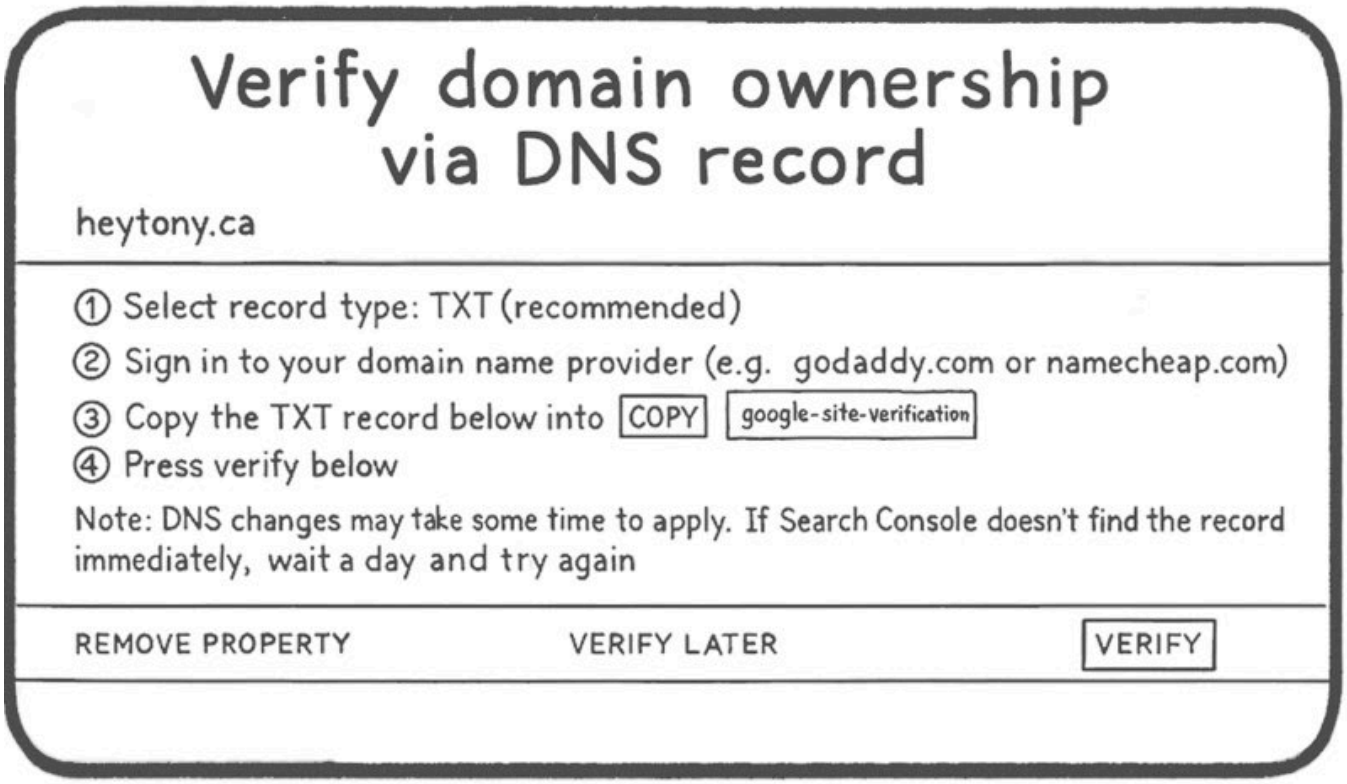
> To set up your Google Search Console account, you can follow the steps I'm about to show you or visit https://getfoundbook.com/gsc to get a video tutorial.

And if you're too lazy to type that link out exactly, just go to Google and search "Google Search Console". It'll be the first link!

1. Click "Start Now" and sign up with your Gmail or Google Workspace email address.
2. You'll see a prompt that says "Welcome to Google Search Console. To start, select property type."



3. Choose Domain (on the left).
4. Enter your website without the www. or https://
5. Follow the steps. You'll need to add the code (txt record) to wherever you registered your domain. I'd love to give you the steps here, but it's slightly different with each domain registrar.



Once you're finished registering your domain, it'll take a few days (possibly weeks) for the data to show. It will ONLY show data as of the date you registered. There is no past historical data available.

The next step is submitting your sitemap.

PS. If you already have a Google Analytics account, sign up for your GSC account with the same email address.

Submitting your sitemap

This is not an essential step, but it is *highly recommended.*

As previously discussed, your sitemap is a hidden page on your site that tells search engines about all the pages on your site. Submitting your sitemap on Google Search Console is very easy and can be done in less than a minute.

1. First, locate your sitemap. You can find it here: **example.com/sitemap.xml**.
2. Alternatively, if you're using Yoast SEO, it can be found here: **example.com/sitemap_index.xml**.
3. Login to Google Search Console and navigate to your domain via the top left box titled "Domain." If your website is already listed, then you're in the right place.



4. Navigate to "Indexing" and then click on "Sitemaps".
5. You'll see a box that says "Add a new sitemap," Simply paste in your sitemap there.



In some cases, you'll only need to post the second part of the URL. For example, **/sitemap.xml** instead of the whole link **example.com/sitemap.xml**.

Click submit, and that's it!

You only need to submit your sitemap once. After that, every time you update or publish a new page, Google will automatically detect the changes through your sitemap.

> **Important:** Do not try to manually add individual blog posts or page URLs here. This is a common mistake. It won't help you get indexed faster and will only result in errors. Once your sitemap is submitted, you're done. There's no need to revisit the sitemaps page unless something breaks.

Bing Webmaster Tools

Bing Webmaster Tools is where you submit your website to, yup, you guessed it, Bing.

Now, I know what you're thinking: *"Who even uses Bing?"* Google seems to dominate the conversation, and for good reason: It holds about 90% of the search engine market share. But here's the thing: Bing still claims around 4%, and that translates to millions of users.

And believe it or not, some people argue that Bing actually has more relevant results than Google. However, you'll never hear marketers brag about ranking #1 on Bing. But when they rank #1 on Google? Oh, they'll tell the whole world.

That's exactly why Bing is an underrated opportunity. While everyone else is laser-focused on Google, you can quietly rank on Bing with far less competition.

Submitting your website to Bing

If you followed the steps to verify your domain and submit your sitemap to Google Search Console, you're in luck, you don't need to do it all again.

Just log into Bing Webmaster Tools with your Google account, and it'll prompt you to import everything directly from Google Search Console. Seriously, it's a few clicks, and you're done.

Low effort. Big reward.

Google Analytics (aka GA4)

Technically, this isn't an SEO tool, but it's crucial for understanding what's happening on your website. If you don't have GA4 (Google Analytics 4) set up yet, go do it right now. Seriously.

Why is GA4 important?

GA4 is Google's latest and most advanced version of its analytics platform. Unlike its predecessor Universal Analytics, GA4 uses an event-based model, which means you get way more flexibility and accuracy when tracking how people interact with your site, across devices.

What can GA4 tell you?

- **Which pages get the most visits.** This helps you spot which content is resonating with your audience so you can double down on what's working.
- **Where your traffic is coming from.** GA4 shows whether people are finding you through search engines, social media, email, or direct visits, so you can fine-tune your strategy.
- **What visitors are doing on your site.** You'll see how long they stay, what they click on, and whether they're completing actions like filling out a form or buying something.

And the best part? It's 100% free. GA4 gives you invaluable insights at zero cost, and the sooner you start collecting data, the more powerful it becomes.

If your website doesn't have GA4 yet, stop reading and go set it up. Your future self will thank you.

Looker Studio

Looker Studio, formerly known as Google Data Studio, is a powerful reporting tool that lets you build custom dashboards using data from multiple sources. In our agency, we mainly use it to pull in and visualize key data from Google Search Console and Google Analytics.

While it's not a *must-have* for SEO beginners, it's a fantastic tool if you want a clear, visual snapshot of how your SEO efforts are performing over time. (Personally, I love watching those graphs climb month over month!)

Want to try it for yourself?

> To access the Looker Studio Template + Tutorial we use for our clients, visit https://getfoundbook.com/looker. It's ready to plug in your data and go.

CHAPTER 30

Auditing Tools

HeyTony Site Audit Tool

AFTER YEARS of relying on other website audit tools that buried the important stuff under layers of confusing data, I finally decided to build my own.

The HeyTony Site Audit Tool was designed to be simple, affordable, and actually helpful, especially for small business owners who aren't SEO experts. It highlights the most important issues preventing your website from ranking and shows you exactly how to fix them.

It's also the first thing we use when we take on a new client. We run their site through the tool and start fixing what matters most.

> To learn more and try the HeyTony Site Audit Tool for yourself, visit https://getfoundbook.com/audit.

Semrush

Another great website audit tool is Semrush. It provides many of the same insights you'll find in the HeyTony Site Audit Tool, like technical issues and on-page SEO problems, but it also comes with a much broader feature set.

At $139 / month, it's definitely priced for more advanced users or businesses with a bigger SEO budget. In addition to audits, it offers powerful

tools for keyword research, competitor tracking, backlink analytics, content analysis, and more.

If you're ready to go deeper into your SEO strategy and need an all-in-one platform, Semrush is a solid investment.

Auditing Your Website for Free

While paid tools can save you a ton of time, I get it… Sometimes the budget is tight, especially when you're just starting out. The good news? You can still audit your website manually for free.

If your site has fewer than 100 pages (which most do), and you're willing to dedicate a bit of time each day, you can complete a full audit in about 3 months, assuming you're reviewing one page per day and spending around an hour per page. And that time frame includes optimizing your pages as you go.

To make the process easier, you'll want to use a Chrome extension like the Page Audit Extension, which pulls all the key SEO data you'll need. From there, it's just a matter of copying and pasting that info into a spreadsheet and following along with the audit training.

> To access the free audit training and start optimizing your site at your own pace without spending a dime, visit https://getfoundbook.com/training.

CHAPTER 31

Keyword Research Tools

THERE ARE HUNDREDS OF KEYWORD RESEARCH TOOLS out there, but I consistently come back to just two that I recommend almost daily: Semrush and Ubersuggest.

Semrush

If you take away one thing from this book, let it be this: Keyword research is the single most important step in the SEO process.

You can write the most helpful, insightful content in the world, but if no one is searching for it, it's not going to show up in search results. Which means no one's going to find it.

That's why I put so much emphasis on using the right keyword research tool. And after trying a ton of them over the past decade, I can confidently say that Semrush is the most accurate when it comes to:

- Search volume
- Keyword difficulty
- Ranking positions

Their Keyword Gap tool is hands down one of my favorite features. It lets you see exactly what keywords your competitors are ranking for, and what you're *missing*. It's like holding a map to all the traffic you could be getting.

This is my go-to keyword research tool. It's so critical to our workflow that I literally couldn't run my SEO agency without it. That said, I'll be honest with you, it's not cheap. And unless you're doing SEO full-time, you probably won't need half of the features it comes with.

Ubersuggest

If you're on a tighter budget or just dipping your toes into the world of SEO, Ubersuggest is the keyword research tool I would recommend. It's affordable ($29 / month), user-friendly, and a great entry point for anyone getting into SEO.

The search volume estimates can sometimes be quite different from other tools, so take the data with a grain of salt. Still, it's a fantastic place to start if you're learning, testing the waters, or simply don't have the budget for Semrush.

ChatGPT

I can't believe I'm writing this, but I've been experimenting with using ChatGPT for keyword research, and it's actually pretty good. While it doesn't provide search volume or keyword difficulty data, it's surprisingly good at suggesting keywords that real people actually use.

I tested this by asking ChatGPT for a list of keywords to optimize a specific page, then ran those suggestions through Semrush to verify them. And for the most part? It crushed it.

Although it's great at generating keyword ideas, it can't tell you how competitive those keywords are or how many people are searching for them (yet). That's a big deal. If you end up optimizing for a keyword that's too difficult or rarely searched, you're likely wasting your time—even if the keyword itself is relevant.

My recommendation is to use ChatGPT as a brainstorming tool, not a final decision-maker. Always validate your keywords with a proper research tool like Semrush or Ubersuggest before committing.

CHAPTER 32

On-Page Optimization Tools

Yoast SEO

WHEN IT COMES to on-page SEO plugins, Yoast SEO is the only tool I consistently recommend. I've been using it for over a decade, and it's still one of the best out there for small businesses.

Yoast is available for both WordPress and Shopify, and they offer both free and premium versions. For most small businesses, the free version is more than enough.

So what does it actually do?

1. It lets you easily update your title tags and meta descriptions.
2. It gives your content an SEO score: Green means you're good, Orange or Red means you've got some optimizing to do.
3. It tells you *exactly* what to fix to improve your content's SEO performance.

If you're just getting started with SEO, Yoast makes on-page optimization way less intimidating.

CHAPTER 33

AI & Content Tools

ChatGPT

AI TOOLS like ChatGPT have completely leveled the playing field for small business owners. You no longer need to be a professional writer or designer; with just a few prompts, you can generate content that looks polished and sounds professional.

But here's the catch: While AI is a powerful assistant, too many people are using it as a replacement for doing the work. And that's where things start to fall apart.

Even though there's nothing inherently wrong with publishing AI-generated content (from a plagiarism standpoint), you're missing two things that matter deeply to both search engines *and* your audience: personal experience and expertise.

AI is great at gathering, summarizing, and rewording information, but it struggles with injecting the human perspective that truly connects with readers. Plus, it's not always great at optimizing content the way we've discussed throughout this book. It needs human oversight.

Let me be super clear: We use ChatGPT every single day for every single client. It's an amazing tool for generating first drafts and saving time. But we always go through it to fact-check, optimize, and, most importantly, add real-life experience, personal stories, and insights that make the content truly valuable.

Canva

When it comes to creating anything visual, social media posts, website graphics, presentations, or lead magnets, Canva is one of the best tools out there.

It makes professional-looking design ridiculously easy, even if you've never touched Photoshop. Need to remove a background from a photo? One click. Want to start with a template? There are thousands. Want to customize it? Super intuitive.

The only downside? If you rely too heavily on Canva's default templates without customizing them, your content is going to look like everyone else's. So take the time to tweak colors, fonts, layouts, and make it your own.

Canva also comes with a huge library of stock images, icons, illustrations, and visual elements you can drop into your designs to instantly elevate them.

Honestly, I wish I'd had Canva when I first started my business. It would've saved me hours (and a lot of frustration).

Instagram, TikTok, Edits, & CapCut

I'm so glad we live in the time we do. Video editing used to mean expensive software, a powerful computer, and a ton of technical skill. Now? You can edit high-quality videos right from your phone.

Both Instagram and TikTok have built-in editors that let you trim clips, add music and graphics, and even auto generate subtitles, with customizable styles to match your brand. On top of that, they've both released standalone editing apps (Instagram Edits and CapCut from TikTok) that offer even more features.

Armed with just your phone and one of these free apps, you can create content that looks polished, professional, and ready to go viral.

CHAPTER 34

Competitor Analysis

Semrush

I KNOW I keep bringing up Semrush, but it's for good reason.

Semrush is one of the most powerful all-in-one SEO tools on the market. It lets you spy on your competition, uncovering exactly which keywords they rank for, how many backlinks they have, what pages are driving traffic, and even which sites are linking to them. If you've read this far, you know how valuable that kind of data is.

When I said earlier that we want to be "on par" with the top 3–5 competitors in your space, this is the tool that makes it possible. You can analyze their domain, spot content gaps, find keyword opportunities they're missing, and even replicate their best backlinks, or replace them with yours (remember that sneaky tactic from earlier?).

While Semrush isn't the cheapest SEO tool out there, its depth of functionality is unmatched. From keyword research and backlink analysis to content optimization and technical audits, it's the kind of tool that grows with you. Whether you're just getting started or managing SEO at scale, Semrush helps you make informed, strategic decisions that lead to long-term growth.

If I could only choose one SEO tool to run my agency with, this would be it.

HeyTony Watchdog

All right, now forget all the nice things I just said about Semrush, because it's time to talk about HeyTony Watchdog.

Here's the thing: Semrush gives you a ton of data, traffic trends, keywords, backlinks, you name it. But what it doesn't show you is exactly what your competitors are changing on their website.

That's where Watchdog comes in.

I built this tool to answer a simple question: What if you could not only track your competitors' rankings... but actually see what they're doing to get there?

Things like:

- Did they change their title tag or meta description?
- Are they updating their on-page content?
- Did they add internal links?
- Which specific keywords are they now targeting?

Are they building new service pages? Updating pricing? Launching something new?

Watchdog tracks all of that.

It monitors your competitors' websites weekly and sends you a simple, easy-to-understand report showing:

- If they made changes
- *Where* on the site those changes happened
- And *what* those changes were

Instead of digging through 50 tabs, manually comparing versions, or waiting until they outrank you to notice something's up, you'll have a front-row seat to every strategic move they make, the moment they make it. It's like having a secret weapon that keeps an eye on your competition... while you sleep.

And let's be real, you're already wearing 17 hats as a business owner. You don't have time to play detective on your competitors' websites every week.

CHAPTER 35

Local SEO Tools

Google Business Profile

IF YOU'RE A LOCAL BUSINESS, creating a Google Business Profile (GBP) is absolutely essential, especially if you want to show up in the Google Map Pack (those top local listings that appear on Google search results with a map).

We already covered how to set up and optimize your GBP in Chapter 18, but here's a quick reminder of why this tool is so important. Your Google Business Profile allows you to see how well you're performing locally. You'll get access to valuable insights like:

- Which keywords are triggering your listing
- How many people are clicking to your website
- How many calls, messages, or bookings you're getting directly from Google

It's 100% free, packed with useful data, and directly influences your visibility in local search. There's literally no downside to creating and optimizing your Google Business Profile. If you're a local business, this is a no-brainer.

Bing Places for Business

This is Bing's version of a Google Business Profile, and it offers many of the same benefits, just on Bing's search engine.

You'll be able to showcase your business information, services, products, hours, contact details, and more. Plus, you'll get valuable insights into how users are interacting with your business on Bing, like clicks, calls, and other actions.

The best part? Setting it up is super easy. Just like with Bing Webmaster Tools, Bing offers a one-click integration with your Google Business Profile. That means you can import all your existing information from Google, no need to manually re-enter everything. It's fast, it's free, and it's another opportunity to get found online.

BrightLocal

Remember back in Chapter 18 when we talked about citations (aka directory listings)? These help establish your business as legitimate in the eyes of both search engines and potential customers. And when it comes to local SEO, *legitimacy equals visibility.*

BrightLocal is one of the best tools out there for managing and submitting your business to dozens of local directories, all in one place. It ensures your NAP (Name, Address, Phone Number) stays consistent across the web, which is a key ranking factor for showing up in the Map Pack and local search results.

But it doesn't stop there. BrightLocal also comes with a solid set of on-page SEO tools, which flag any missing elements on your pages like:

- H1 & H2 tags
- Title tags
- Meta descriptions

Basically, it tells you if anything is missing that might be holding your pages back.

Their local reporting features are especially valuable. For years, this was our go-to reporting tool for local clients. It gives you:

- A clear monthly snapshot of your keyword rankings
- Map grid tracking to show how well you rank in different parts of your city or region
- Competitive insights so you can see where you stand

If you're a local business, BrightLocal is a no-brainer. It's built specifically to help you rank in your area and it does that job really, really well.

Semrush Local

Semrush Local is like BrightLocal, but on steroids. It does everything BrightLocal does, like submitting your business to local directories and managing your citations, and if you're already using Semrush, you'll have access to their additional features like keyword research and competitive analysis.

One of the features I really appreciate from a small business perspective is how payment is structured. Instead of paying a large lump sum upfront like you do with BrightLocal, Semrush Local uses a monthly billing model, which is much easier on your cash flow. You still get the full value, just spread out over time.

If you're already using Semrush for keyword research or competitor tracking, adding Semrush Local is a seamless upgrade, giving you one platform to manage your SEO, local rankings, directory listings, and reputation, all in one place.

PART V

HOW TO OPTIMIZE YOUR WEBSITE

UP UNTIL THIS POINT most of what you've read in this book is catching you up on the foundations of SEO. In this part of the book we're going to be taking that theory and turning it into a full-blown SEO strategy.

This is the exact same process we use inside my agency to get results for our clients. I do want to mention that even if you do everything I'm about to tell you, your website may not rank. It's not your fault; search engines have their own algorithms that do weird things sometimes! And keep in mind that one of the secrets to SEO (and all marketing for that matter) is patience. You can do all of these optimizations and not see any shift for 6–12 months. I know that's a long time, but if you stick with it, you'll start to see movement.

CHAPTER 36

Keyword Research

KEYWORD RESEARCH IS THE FOUNDATION of all great content. Without it, you risk writing helpful content that never gets seen, either because it's not optimized for any keyword or because it's optimized for the wrong one.

Despite what some "experts" might tell you, keyword research should always be your first step. It helps you understand what people are actually searching for, so you can create content that matches their intent and gets found.

And because I don't want you to get stuck before you even start, here's a full breakdown of how to do keyword research, using both free and paid methods. Let's make sure your content actually gets discovered.

Finding Keywords Using Keyword Research Tools

There are a few reliable ways to find the right keywords for your website, and keyword research tools like Semrush or Ubersuggest make the process a whole lot easier. While I personally use Semrush, most keyword research tools will get the job done just fine. Here are 4 tried-and-true strategies.

1. Analyzing competitor websites

Start by dropping your competitors' website URLs into your keyword tool. This will give you a full list of keywords their entire website ranks for, and

show you which specific pages are ranking.

It's a fast way to gauge interest in topics related to your industry and a great way to cherry-pick keywords that are relevant to your business.

2. Analyzing specific pages

If you want to get more specific, paste a single page from a competitor's site, like their service or product page, into your keyword tool.

For example, if you're a dentist and your competitor has a page about teeth whitening, you can see which exact keywords that page is ranking for and use that insight to optimize your own.

3. Keyword gap

This one's my favorite. Most tools have a feature called Keyword Gap or Gap Analysis that lets you compare your website to your competitors'.

It'll show you all the keywords they rank for that you don't. These are valuable opportunities to create new content or optimize existing pages so you can close the gap and potentially outrank them.

4. Guessing

Sometimes your competitors just… suck. They don't rank for much, and they aren't giving you anything valuable to work with in terms of keyword ideas. When that happens, the best move might be to trust your instincts and start guessing.

Let's say you're a house painter in Houston. You can start with logical guesses like:

"house painter Houston"
"Houston painting services"

"interior painters Houston"

Plug those into your keyword research tool. It'll tell you whether people are actually searching for them, and even better, it'll show you related keywords and variations that are more commonly used.

This approach takes a bit more upfront effort, but here's the upside: If your competitors aren't targeting these keywords, they might be easier to rank for. And that's a huge opportunity for you.

Finding Keywords for Free

Whether you're bootstrapping or have a marketing budget, these keyword research tactics are worth using. Sometimes your competitors are just flat-out bad at SEO, and there's little you can learn from their sites. In those cases, you'll need to get creative, and these methods can help.

Using ChatGPT / AI

ChatGPT is surprisingly good at generating keyword ideas. The catch? You still need to verify those keywords using a proper keyword research tool like Semrush or Ubersuggest. This will allow you to check search volume and keyword difficulty, and ensure you're not chasing something no one is searching for.

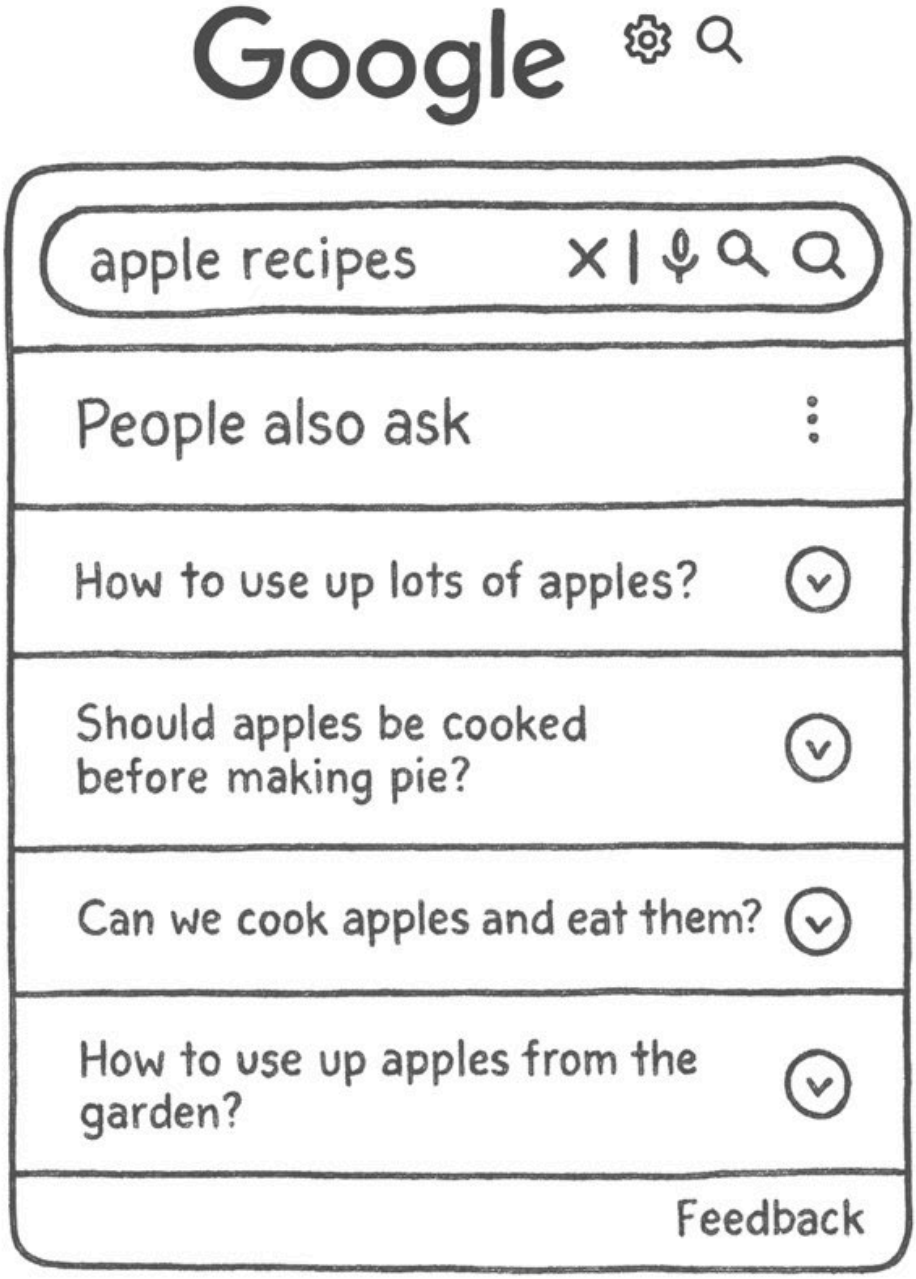
One of my favorite prompts is pasting a URL into ChatGPT and asking: "What keywords could this page be optimized for?" It often returns relevant keyword suggestions based on the content.

You can also use ChatGPT to brainstorm blog post ideas, product or service topics, or even help plan your content calendar. It's not a replacement for keyword tools, but it's a fantastic supplement, especially when you feel stuck.

Using "People also ask"

This one's super simple. Head to Google and search for any keyword related to your business. Scroll down until you see the "People also ask" section. It contains a list of related questions that real users are typing into Google. You can use these as blog post ideas.

And here's a little trick: Click one of the questions, then quickly close it. Doing that will trigger Google to load even more related questions. You can keep doing this to unlock a growing list of relevant blog topics.



Using AnswerThePublic

Go to **answerthepublic.com**, type in a keyword, brand, product, or topic, and hit search. It will generate a giant visual list of questions people are asking about that topic.

While it doesn't give you search volume or keyword difficulty, it does give you insight into what people actually want to know. If the question shows up there, someone's searching for it, so answer it on your site in the form of a blog post.

As of writing this book, you get 3 free searches per day without a paid plan.

Using questions you hear from your customers

This might be the most underrated source of content ideas. If a customer asks you a question in person, on social media, via email, or in a sales call, that's a topic worth writing about. Remember Marcus Sheridan? He used this strategy to turn his struggling pool company into a 9-figure business.

Why? Because if one person asks, you can bet there are several others, if not hundreds more, searching for the same thing online. These real-world interactions are gold mines for SEO-friendly blog content.

Choosing Which Keywords to Use

Now that you know how to find keywords, the next step is knowing which ones to actually use. It might sound simple; just go after the keywords with the most searches, right?

Not quite.

The most searched keywords are often the most competitive, which means you'll have a much harder time ranking for them, especially early on. Instead, we're going to take a smarter approach. One that gets your content

seen faster and actually drives traffic to your website. That doesn't mean you should ignore the most popular keywords completely. But if your website is new or hasn't built up much authority (trust) yet, you're likely not ready to rank for them.

If you're creating content that answers questions people are actively asking in your industry, you're already on the right track. These longer, more specific phrases (long-tail keywords) often won't show up in keyword tools with a lot of search volume, but that doesn't mean they're not valuable.

So how do you choose?

Think of the most popular search phrase as the primary keyword. Then look for secondary keywords, variations, or related terms that are easier to rank for. For example, the primary keyword for a plumber in Detroit might be:

"plumber Detroit"

While secondary keyword options could include:

"plumber in Detroit""plumbing services Detroit MI"
"local plumbing companies in Detroit"

While everyone else is fighting for that top primary keyword, we're going to sneak in through the back door and rank for the secondary keywords first.

Yes, those secondary keywords get less traffic, but they're much easier to rank for, especially when your site is just getting started. And that traffic still matters. It builds momentum, trust, and topical authority with search engines.

This strategy also applies to blog content. If a primary keyword is too competitive, look for alternative phrasings or long-tail questions that are easier to win.

That said, if the primary keyword looks easy to rank for? Go for it! But most of the time, your best bet is to prioritize keywords with low difficulty, even if they have lower search volume. Especially for blog content.

Why?

Because as traffic starts rolling in from those easier wins, search engines begin to trust your site more, and that trust unlocks the potential to rank for more competitive keywords down the line.

Why low search volume keywords matter

When we talk about targeting low search volume keywords, we're typically looking at keywords that get 10 to 100 searches per month.

I know that might not sound like much. But stick with me.

Let's say you're writing 2 blog posts per week, and each post targets a keyword with around 50 searches per month. That's 100 searches per week, or about 400 potential searches per month your site could be found for.

Now, that's just based on a single keyword per post. In reality, your content will likely rank for multiple keyword variations, meaning the real number will be even higher. But let's keep things simple and stick with the 400 searches per month.

Over 12 months, that adds up to 4,800 monthly searches or almost 60,000 searches per year. And that's not even considering the fact that, as your site gains authority, you'll naturally start ranking for more competitive (and higher volume) keywords, something we typically see with our clients around the 6–9 month mark. This is called the avalanche technique.

Think of it like a snowball rolling down a hill. It starts off small and slow. But as it keeps rolling, it builds momentum, gets bigger, and picks up speed. Eventually, it becomes unstoppable.

The same thing happens with SEO. You start by publishing content around easy, low-volume keywords. But as your traffic and topical authority grow, search engines begin to trust your site. Once that happens, you'll start ranking for those more competitive, high-traffic keywords too.

But here's the catch: You can't start with the most competitive keywords. You have to earn your way there. It takes consistency, patience, and persistence. But if you stick with it, you'll see your traffic snowball and your rankings grow exponentially.

CHAPTER 37

Writing & Optimizing Your Content

NOW THAT YOU'VE FOUND A KEYWORD you want to rank for, it's time to create a mini-roadmap to help you write (or optimize) your content effectively.

Here's the thing: If someone is already ranking #1 for that keyword, that means Google liked something about their page. So we're going to reverse-engineer it.

This isn't a full-blown SEO audit, this is what I call a quick and dirty competitor analysis.

Creating a Mini Content Roadmap

We're going to analyze a few key elements of the top-ranking page, including:

- Keyword density
- Word count
- Where and how often they use the keyword
- Page speed
- Backlinks and referring domains

Open up a spreadsheet and create 3 columns:

- First column = Metric you're tracking
- Second column = Your page

- Third column = Top-ranking competitor's page

Then, go through and fill out the data for the competitor. You'll need:

- An SEO Chrome extension (like the HeyTony Page Audit Extension)
- A keyword tool like Semrush or Ubersuggest
- HeyTony Content Analyzer
- Google PageSpeed Insights (**https://pagespeed.web.dev**) for loading performance

If you don't have access to a paid SEO tool, you can skip backlinks and referring domains for now, but I highly recommend keeping an eye on that data. If your competitor has even a few backlinks, you'll need to work on getting some too.

The good news? Once this mini-audit is done, you'll have a crystal-clear view of what you need to do to outrank them.

This approach works most of the time. Sometimes the competition is tougher, but this process gives you a huge head start and sets the foundation for SEO success.

METRIC	YOUR SITE	COMPETITOR'S SITE
Target Link	heytony.ca (Your Page)	
Target Keyword	digital marketing agency	
How Many Times Are They Using the Keyword?	12	
Title Tag	The Best Digital Marketing Agency In Hamilton | HeyTony	
Meta Description	HeyTony is a digital marketing agency in Hamilton. We offer website design, social media advertising, SEO services, and more online advertising services tailored specifically to helping you grow your business.	
H1 Tag	Level up your digital marketing	
H2 Tags	– Our approach to digital marketing – Our digital marketing services – What digital marketing services do you offer? – Do you work with small businesses? – Latest digital marketing news	
Word Count	1,434	
Keyword Usage: Digital Marketing Agency (Main keyword)	0 on page 2 (title tag & meta desc.) 0.1% keyword density	
Referring Domains / Backlinks	25 referring domains 68 backlinks	
Page Speed Desktop	85 / 100	
Page Speed Mobile	65 / 100	

How to find the metrics

- **Keyword Usage: CMD+F** (Mac) or **CTRL+F** (Windows), paste the keyword to see how many times they're using it on the page.

- **Title Tag, Meta Description, H1, H2, word count:** HeyTony Page Audit Extension
- **Keyword Usage:** I made a tool for this called Content Analyzer (it's free) and you can find it here: **https://heytony.ca/content-analyzer/**
- **Referring domains / backlinks:** Semrush or Ubersuggest
- **Page Speed:** PageSpeed Insights (**https://pagespeed.web.dev**)

> If you want a copy of this audit spreadsheet, go to https://get-foundbook.com/spreadsheet get access.

Writing Your Content

Creating an outline

Now that you've got your roadmap, it's time to write a killer piece of content. But let's be real: The hardest part is staring at a blank screen, not knowing where to start.

Here's a trick we use at HeyTony to break through the blank-page paralysis:

1. Open the top 3–5 ranking pages for the keyword you're targeting.
2. Copy all of their heading tags (H1s, H2s, H3s, etc.) into a blank document.
3. Do this for each of the 3–5 pages and combine them into one doc.
4. Remove anything irrelevant like "Related Posts," newsletter signup prompts, or off-topic headings.
5. Insert any relevant secondary keywords as H2s or H3s, but only if they make sense within the context.
6. Rewrite and reword the headings so they're not identical to the competition. You don't want Google flagging your content as

duplicate.

What you're left with is a skeleton outline, a structured roadmap that covers the major talking points you'll need to hit. This should take you no more than 5–10 minutes.

From here, all you have to do is fill in the blanks.

> To download an example outline template we use at HeyTony, visit https://getfoundbook.com/outline.

Drafting your content

We're going to use AI to help with the heavy lifting. At the time of writing, my go-to tools are ChatGPT and Claude.

Step 1: Gather Content from Competitors

Start by copying the content from each of the top 3–5 ranking pages for your target keyword. Use **CMD+A** (Mac) or **CTRL+A** (PC) to select everything on the page, then copy it.

One by one, paste each full page into ChatGPT and ask it to summarize the content. You don't need to read the summaries; we're just training the AI to understand what's already out there.

Step 2: Paste Your Outline

Now that the AI is familiar with what the top competitors are saying, paste your custom outline into the same conversation.

Then prompt the AI with something like:

"Write an article based on this outline."

If you're working on a product or service page instead, just replace *"article"* with *"product page"* or *"service page."*

This should give you a solid draft based on your structure and the existing landscape of content.

> **Important:** Don't copy and paste this AI-generated draft directly to your website. It still needs your voice, your expertise, and your human touch.

Step 3: Add Your Experience & Expertise

This is where your content becomes truly unique. You can:

- Add real-world examples or case studies manually, or…
- Film yourself talking through the topic, share personal stories, or explain client wins. Then paste the transcript into the same AI conversation.

You can even ask:

"Summarize this transcript and include my experiences in the final article."

Then re-prompt with:

"Write the article based on this outline. Make sure to include my personal stories, experiences, and case studies from the transcript."

This bakes your experience and expertise directly into the content, which is exactly what search engines and humans want.

Step 4: Final Touches

Once you've got the draft:

- Make sure your H1 includes the target keyword.
- Ensure at least one H2 includes the keyword.
- Fact-check the content.
- Add images, internal links, and external sources where appropriate.
- Double-check your roadmap to make sure you're using the keyword enough times and in the right places. And don't overdo it; if your competitors are using the keyword 7 times, use it 8 times.

You're now holding a personalized, optimized, experience-rich piece of content that's leagues ahead of your competition.

CHAPTER 38

Product Page Optimization

THIS IS GOING TO BE A REALLY SHORT CHAPTER because all you need to do is what was mentioned in the previous chapter. However, there are two things you need to know and keep in mind.

1. Unique Product Names Are NOT Always Beneficial

Have you ever heard of the *Florpavia* couch? No? Exactly. Neither have your potential customers. Unless you're already a household name or have a massive audience elsewhere, giving your product a quirky, made-up name is a terrible move when it comes to SEO. I hate to say it, but it's true.

The beauty of SEO is that people are actively searching for things, things you might sell! But if your mid-century modern sofa (a phrase that gets a ton of monthly searches, by the way) is called *Florpavia*, how is Google supposed to know it's a mid-century modern sofa? It won't. So your product never shows up in the results.

This exact scenario happened with a client of ours, John.

John hired my agency to help his online store get more customers. His business was struggling, and he didn't have much runway left. (Side note: If you're in this position—tight on cash and hoping SEO will save you next month—SEO is probably not the answer.)

Anyway, John was adamant that we not change any of his product names. He had these highly stylized, brand-centric product titles, but no

one was searching for them. We proposed a simple fix: He could update the product titles to something people are *actually* searching for, and move his unique product name underneath in the description or subtitle. That way, he could keep the creative name *and* improve his visibility on Google.

We showed him the research. We showed him the data, but he still refused to changed his product names. On top of that, we wrote blog posts, optimized the content, built the links… we did all the SEO things.

Can you guess what happened?

Six months later, John cancelled with us. SEO hadn't brought in the money fast enough, and his ads weren't performing either. (I can only imagine how many recommendations he ignored from his ads team.)

SEO isn't magic. It's strategy. And sometimes that strategy means letting go of your ego and making small changes to help your business thrive. Especially when the fix is as simple as adjusting your product names… for the *website* only.

The product title is usually the H1 tag and the title tag on your page. Both are essential for SEO. If your H1 says "*Florpavia*" instead of "Mid-Century Modern Sofa," you're losing the game before it even starts.

So, yeah, maybe save the fancy names for your packaging. On your site? Call it what it is.

2. Product Descriptions Don't Have to Be Dull

One of the things John *did* let us tweak was his product descriptions. You know, the bullet points or couple of lines explaining what the product is, who it's for, and what problem it solves?

Let's take a page from the king of e-commerce: Amazon.

At the very top of a product listing, you'll find the essentials: product name, star rating, price, and the "Buy Now" button. Just below that is the About This Item and Product Details section. These parts don't just add context, they build trust, answer questions, and help customers feel confident clicking "Add to Cart."

And here's the wild part: We *all* read this stuff when we're shopping online. But when it comes to our own websites? We often forget to include it. Or worse, we just throw something together and promise ourselves we'll come back to it later. Spoiler alert: Most people never do.

If you already have product descriptions, great! But let's talk about how to optimize them so they're actually helping you rank.

Where most businesses go wrong

1. Copy-pasting from the manufacturer. Google hates duplicate content. If your product description appears word-for-word on 50 other sites, guess what? You're not going to rank.
2. Treating product descriptions like an afterthought. Throwing something together to fill the white space to make your page look more complete.

How to Optimize Product Pages

You're going to apply the same process from the last chapter:

- Find the keyword for your product.
- Analyze your competitors.
- Write a helpful, original description that makes *you* the best result on the page.

Treat your product page like a blog post (sort of)

Here's the secret most people miss: Product pages can have more than just a title and a few bullets. You can use:

- H2 tags for organizing sections

- Internal links to related products or helpful blogs
- FAQs for common customer questions
- Your own expertise and opinion

Now, don't panic: I'm *not* saying shove 1,000 words to the top of the page. The top section should be clean and conversion-focused:

- Product photo(s)
- Product name (with the keyword!)
- Star rating (if you've got 'em)
- Price
- "Add to Cart" button

Everything else can go *underneath* that. Most visitors may not scroll all the way down, but the ones who do are likely on the fence. Your helpful, well-structured content down there could be the thing that gets them to buy.

And for search engines? All that additional context, keyword usage, and structure gives you a huge leg up.

So yes, product descriptions matter. *A lot*.

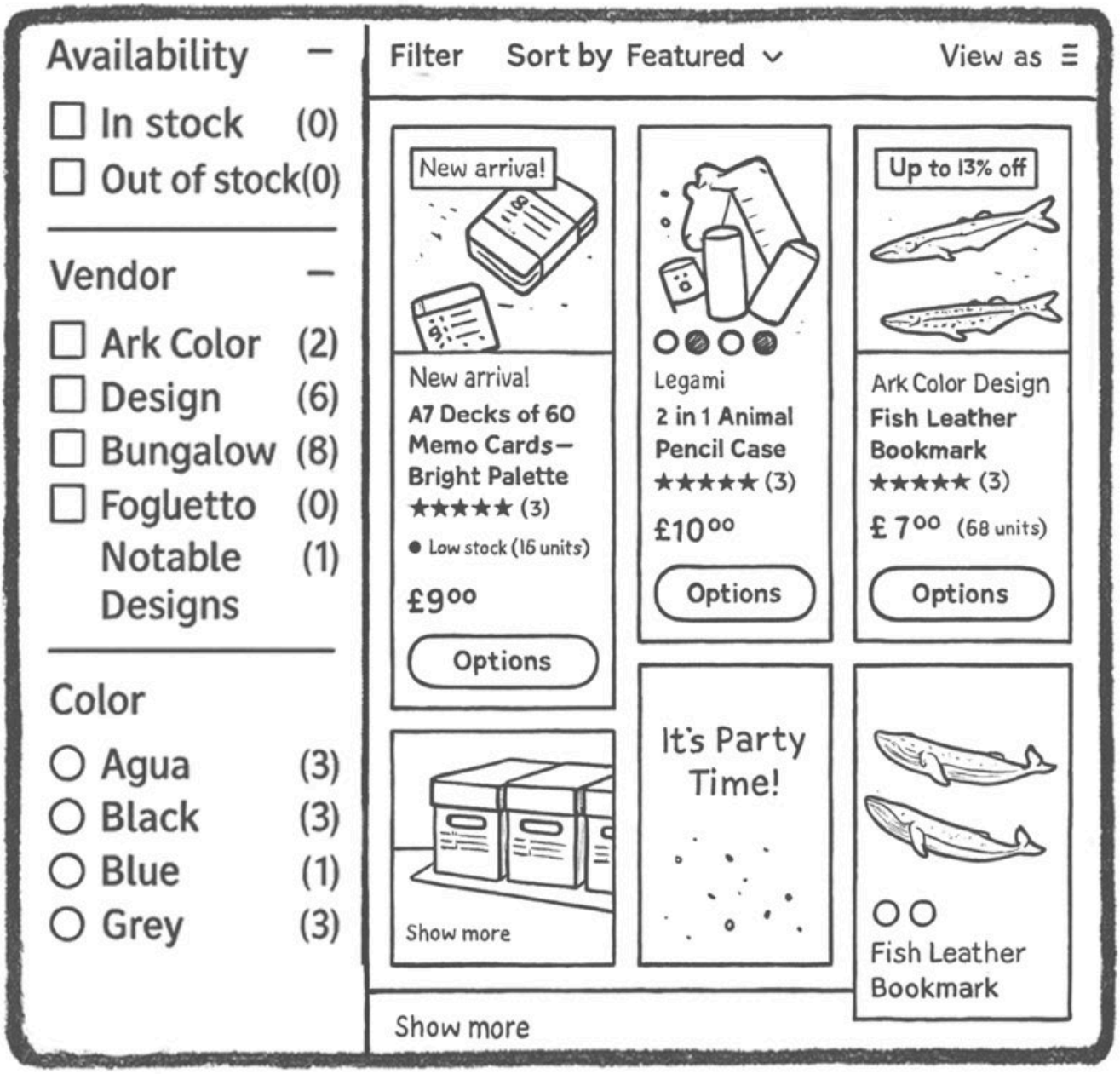
CHAPTER 39

Category Page Optimization

CATEGORY PAGES ARE EASILY one of the most underutilized and under-optimized assets on most online stores, and that's a massive missed opportunity. Category pages can rank. And not just rank, they can rank *really well*.

Let's take an example: Say you have a category page for "coffee machines." When you land on that page, it probably looks familiar. On the left, you've got filters like brand names, price ranges, star ratings, and other product attributes. On the right, you'll usually see a grid of products that fall under that category.

And that's where most people stop. Why? Because most e-commerce platforms make it seem like that's all a category page is meant to do: display products. They don't make it obvious that you can (and should) add more content to these pages.



Category pages are SEO gold. They sit higher in the hierarchy than product pages and usually target shorter, broader keywords, meaning more search volume and more potential traffic. If someone searches "best coffee machines," they probably aren't looking for a specific model yet. They want options, comparisons, and guidance.

That's exactly what your category page should give them.

If all your page does is show product thumbnails, you're missing a major chance to:

- Rank for big, valuable keywords
- Keep users engaged
- Funnel visitors into deeper product pages
- Build topical authority

In this chapter, I'll show you exactly how to optimize your category pages, not just for search engines, but for people. Because that's the combo that wins.

Let's turn your product listings into conversion and ranking machines.

Optimizing Category Pages

Let's talk about turning your category pages into SEO powerhouses.

Instead of using a broad, generic keyword like "coffee machines" as your H1 tag, you can be more strategic and specific. Use a keyword that people are *actually* searching for, something like "drip coffee machines" or "stovetop espresso makers." These longer-tail variations usually have lower competition but still carry strong search volume.

Now, you might be thinking: "But what if the category includes a mix of machines, drip, espresso, and stovetop? Won't that confuse things?" Exactly. That's your signal to break that catch-all category into multiple specific ones.

Instead of one generic "coffee machine" category, create separate pages for:

- Drip coffee makers
- Espresso machines
- French presses
- Stovetop coffee pots

Give each one its own optimized category page. This not only helps search engines better understand your site, it also helps real people find ex-

actly what they're looking for. More pages. More keywords. More ranking opportunities.

But don't go overboard. You don't want hundreds of nearly identical category pages that overwhelm users or dilute your SEO strategy. Keep it focused. Keep it useful.

How to Optimize Category Pages

Once you've nailed down your keywords and narrowed your categories, it's time to optimize the pages.

Here's how:

1. Keyword & Competitive Research

Start with proper keyword research (using Semrush, Ubersuggest, or even ChatGPT for ideas) to identify the best keyword for each category. Then check the top 3 ranking pages to see how they've structured their content and what keywords they're using. All of this is covered in Chapter 36.

2. Write Content Like a Blog Post

Think of your category page as more than just a product grid. It's a page that can rank, so treat it like a blog post:

- Use your target keyword in the H1 tag.
- Add H2s below the product grid (e.g., "How to Choose the Best Drip Coffee Machine").
- Include FAQs that real customers ask.
- Share opinions, tips, or buyer's guides.

3. Use Internal Linking

Link out to related blog posts, products, or service pages. For example, link to your "Coffee Machine Maintenance Guide" or "How to Brew the Perfect Cup" blog posts.

4. Place the Content in the Right Spot

Don't make people scroll through a wall of text just to get to your products. Keep the product grid at the top where people expect it, and place all your optimized content below the product listings.

- Search engines will still crawl and index it.
- Users who scroll will find it helpful.
- And you'll keep your user experience clean and conversion-friendly.

Most stores stop at just listing products, but you're not most stores.

With just a little extra effort, your category pages can do double-duty: sell products AND bring in organic traffic, which means more free visitors, more visibility, and more sales.

CHAPTER 40

Service Page Optimization

IF YOU'RE A SERVICE-BASED BUSINESS, this chapter is for you.

Most service businesses offer more than one thing. Take my agency, HeyTony, for example. We offer website design, SEO, Meta ads, Google ads, and a few other things. And guess what? Each service gets its own page.

Why? Because each page on your website should be about *one specific topic*.

If I were to throw all my services onto one massive page, what would the main keyword be? *"Digital marketing"?* That's way too broad. And from an SEO standpoint, it's a wasted opportunity.

Why Service Pages Matter So Much

Service pages are actually easier to optimize than product or category pages (at least in my opinion). Why? Because when someone is searching for a service, they're already looking for information.

They're problem-aware. And if you can answer their questions clearly and quickly, you're more likely to win the lead.

- Here's what you want to cover on each service page:
- What the service is (Use plain English, not jargon.)
- Who it's for (Speak directly to your ideal customer.)
- What problems it solves
- What your process looks like

- What it costs (or a general price range) (If you're not ready to list prices, at least address the cost.)
- How long it takes
- What makes your approach unique
- Common questions (Yes, add an FAQ section.)
- Testimonials, before / after results, case studies, logos, reviews, etc.
- Call-to-action (Tell people what to do next. Book a call? Fill out a form? Don't leave them guessing.)

Treat your service page like a blog post (sort of)

Think of each service page like a blog post. Make sure you're using your target keyword in:

- The H1 tag (the title of the page)
- At least one H2 tag
- The URL
- The title tag and meta description
- The content (sprinkled naturally throughout)

Don't forget to include internal links to related blog posts, case studies, or even other services. This strengthens your topical relevance and improves your SEO.

A Real-World Example

Last year, I ran into an issue with my air conditioner. The outside unit kept freezing up, even though the system was only 2 years old. (Brand new, in HVAC years!)

Naturally, the first thing I did was call my dad and say, "Dad, wtf? This thing's basically new. What do I do?" He told me to shut the whole system

off, let the ice melt, and try turning it back on later. So I did. And… nothing. Still frozen. And I was still sweating.

At that point, I decided I needed a professional. So I pulled out my phone and searched "air conditioner repair Hamilton." What did I find? Pages dedicated to air conditioner repair in Hamilton. Imagine that!

These companies didn't just say "We fix heating and cooling problems." They had full-on pages specifically about air conditioner repair, optimized for the city I was in. And guess what? Those were the pages I clicked on. And one of those companies got my business.

Their service pages included things like:

- Average wait times (helpful during a heatwave)
- Hourly rates and pricing info
- Common AC problems (like freezing units)
- DIY tips to try before calling
- Glowing customer reviews
- What to expect when the technician arrives
- Prep instructions and safety protocols

The service pages for the company I chose made it incredibly easy to trust them, and even easier to make the call.

They couldn't come the same day (heatwaves will do that), but when they did, the tech showed up, fixed it fast, and I finally got a decent night's sleep without waking up drenched.

So be specific. Be helpful. Be thorough. Your service page should answer every question a potential customer might have—before they ever pick up the phone or fill out a form. Because when someone is in need, the best page wins. *Every* time.

CHAPTER 41

What If My Website Isn't Ranking?

SO YOU'VE FOLLOWED THE STEPS. You've done the keyword research. You've created the content. You've optimized the page. But you're still not ranking.

Don't panic. This happens. And there are a few key things you can check and tweak before jumping to conclusions.

1. Revisit Your Mini Audit

Head back to Chapter 37 and redo your mini audit. That process gives you a snapshot of how your page stacks up against your competitors. If you've genuinely followed your roadmap and your content is more helpful, more detailed, and better optimized but you're still not ranking, ask yourself: Have you waited long enough?

Search engines take time. Sometimes it takes 3–6 months, and in rare cases, even longer. I once had a page that took over a year to climb the rankings, but when it did, it paid off.

2. Check If the Page Is Indexed

If you're not showing up in the search results at all, it might be because your page isn't even indexed.

Open Google Search Console, paste the exact URL of your page into the search bar at the top, and hit "Enter". If the page isn't indexed, that means

Google hasn't added it to their search results yet.

Here's what you can do:

- Build backlinks to that page (this shows Google that others value your content).
- Internally link to that page from other pages on your site that *are* indexed (especially from pages that get traffic).
- Check Google's reasoning. If they give you a reason for not indexing the page, it's usually one of two things:
  1. The content is duplicate.
  2. The content is too thin (not helpful or too short).

3. Check for Over-Optimization

Yes, there's such a thing as too much SEO.

The goal isn't to blow your competitors out of the water, it's to slightly outdo them. If their page has 1,000 words, write 1,100. If they use the keyword 5 times, aim for 6, not 16. If their site has a few internal links, add a few more, not 100.

Too much optimization can trigger red flags.

4. You Might Need More Authority

If your content is great, your on-page SEO is solid, and the page is indexed but you're still not ranking, you might just need more authority.

Keep blogging. Keep earning backlinks. Keep internally linking to the page.

SEO is a long game. Every helpful piece of content you publish adds to your topical authority. Over time, your site becomes more trustworthy in Google's eyes, and you'll start ranking for more competitive keywords.

You Can't Win Them All

Look, I know it's frustrating, but you won't rank #1 for every keyword, and that's okay.

Focus on growing your overall traffic. As long as your site is consistently gaining visitors, you're moving in the right direction. That momentum will help everything else rank better too.

What If Traffic Drops After Optimizing a Page?

Sometimes you optimize a page and… traffic drops. Before you freak out, give it a few weeks. Rankings can fluctuate right after making changes.

If traffic doesn't bounce back, you may have made changes Google didn't like. No shame in that, it happens.

Here's what to do:

1. Roll the page back to the previous version (check your revision history).
2. Monitor the results.
3. If it rebounds, great! If not, try optimizing again, but this time, make small, incremental tweaks instead of overhauling everything at once.

Sometimes all it takes is a single well-placed keyword or a better headline to get back on track.

CHAPTER 42

An SEO Horror Story

TODAY I WAS ON A CALL WITH MY TEAM and they told me one of our clients deleted an article from their website over the holidays. Okay, no problem. Sometimes an employee deletes a blog post or page by mistake. No big deal. We have backup copies of everything and can get it back pretty easily.

The team proceeded to tell me that it wasn't an intern who'd deleted the page accidentally, it was the CEO. The CEO! And he had deliberately removed the page. What had my team done? How bad was this piece of content that it would merit the CEO going in and removing it?

It turns out that this CEO didn't think the content topic was close enough to their product (it was), and he wanted something that would drive instant conversions (impossible). So he went in and removed that page from their website.

The problem is that this blog post got more traffic than any other page on the company's website. Not only does removing it make our reports look bad (and we'll probably get fired in a few months), but their overall website traffic will suffer greatly. Let me explain.

The Goal of SEO

The goal of any website doing SEO is to generate more traffic and increase revenue, right? Right. Now that we're on the same page, let's get into the impact this is going to have on their site.

The Consequences of Deleting a High-Traffic Page

By deleting a high-traffic page, the company will:

1. **Lose Overall Traffic:** This will likely impact their domain authority (or credibility score).
2. **Decrease Credibility:** Their credibility going down will make it harder to rank for any keywords, especially the "money" keywords.
3. **Lose Topical Authority:** Search engines will have a harder time seeing them as a topical authority (making it harder to rank for the "money" keywords).
4. **Lose Link Equity:** That blog post was linking to other blog posts on their site as well as to some of their main service pages. Since this page had a lot of credibility, it was "sharing" some of that credibility with the pages it was linking to. So that loss of credibility impacts much more than just that page (again, making it harder to rank for the "money" keywords).
5. **Lose Backlinks:** Removing that URL got rid of any backlinks it had. All of the sites linking to that page (if they're doing SEO) will be notified that they're linking to a broken link (a page that doesn't exist anymore). They will remove those links and may even replace them with competitor links (making it even harder to rank for the "money" keywords)!
6. **Miss Future Opportunities:** Since that blog post was a helpful piece of content and it no longer exists, the client is missing out on future organic backlinking opportunities (people linking to the content because it's helpful).

Remember how many backlinks Brian from **Backlinko.com** got for free? Yeah, that's not even going to be a possibility for this client because the blog post was taken down.

Checklist Before Removing a Page

If you're planning on removing a page from your website, here's a quick checklist you can refer to before you do anything.

1. **Backlinks Check:**
    - Does this page have backlinks?
    - If it does, and they are good backlinks that you want to keep, don't remove the page. Instead, update the content.
2. **Traffic Analysis:**
    - If the page does not have good backlinks, check if it's getting traffic organically.
    - If it is, you may want to keep that page.
    - Feel free to make some minor edits as that could impact its search rankings.
3. **Final Warning:**
    - If you really don't want that page on your site despite it having good backlinks and / or getting a significant amount of traffic, know that it may make it harder for you to rank and you may even lose rankings across your entire site.

PART VI

MAXIMIZING YOUR EFFORTS

I USED TO POSITION MYSELF as a *growth agency* rather than just an SEO agency, because if you want to increase your chances of success online, you need to focus on more than just one area. And while SEO is incredibly important, it's just one piece of the puzzle.

So why don't I call myself a growth agency anymore? Simple: People didn't know what that meant. I'd constantly get questions like: "What exactly do you do?" "Can you help us with SEO? Ads? Social media? Can you build a marketplace site?" It was too ambiguous. And honestly, all I really wanted to do was SEO; it's where I thrive. I have a system, it works, and I enjoy it. So now I just say, "We're an SEO agency." Straightforward. Clear. No confusion.

If you're reading this and starting to feel overwhelmed by the thought of having to learn *even more* marketing strategies beyond SEO, I totally get it. As business owners, we wear all the hats, especially in the beginning when there's no budget to outsource and no team to delegate to. You're stuck doing it all. But here's the good news: It gets better.

If you can grasp the concepts in this book and start applying them, even a few at a time, you'll eventually reach a point where you can hire help. Whether that's a freelancer, an agency, or a full-time employee, you'll be in a better position to scale your efforts.

A lot of people think that if they can just get someone to visit their website, *bam*, the sale will happen. Especially if the product is amazing. But unfortunately, that's not how it works.

Even with a great product or service, people don't always buy right away. Sometimes they need a little convincing. A follow-up. A reminder. A second, third, or fourth interaction. That's where things like retargeting and nurture campaigns come in. (We'll get into those shortly.)

And let's be honest, there are a lot of bad products out there. I'm not saying yours is one of them, but everyone thinks their product is great. The one thing even the best marketing can't fix is a product that people don't want. You might make a few sales, but at what cost?

In this section, we're going to explore the other key marketing channels that, when used correctly, *and in tandem with SEO*, create exponential results. They're like puzzle pieces that, when combined, make your marketing greater than the sum of its parts.

CHAPTER 43

Paid Search

PAID SEARCH IS WHEN YOU BID on specific keywords in search engines like Google or Bing to appear in the "ad" section at the top of the search results. These are also known as sponsored results. While paid ads typically get fewer clicks than the top organic listings, they can still generate a strong return on investment when done right.



Paid search is especially useful when you're just getting started with SEO and don't want to wait months to see results. With paid ads, you can start driving traffic to your site almost immediately.

Think of it this way: With paid search, you can *instantly* show up at the top of the page (in the sponsored section) for the exact keywords your potential customers are already searching for, while you work on building your long-term SEO strategy in the background. Once you start ranking organically for those keywords, you can start phasing them out of your paid campaign and save money.

Some businesses skip SEO entirely and focus solely on paid ads to drive leads and sales. And while this can be effective in the short term, keep in mind that you'll have to keep paying to stay visible. The minute you stop running ads, your traffic stops.

Paid search is a great short-term win or long-term supplement, but if you're looking for sustainable, compounding results, SEO is the investment that pays off over time.

Can Paid Ads Help You Rank Higher Organically?

Yes, but probably not in the way you think.

Giving Google your hard-earned money doesn't mean they'll reward you with better organic rankings. Let's be real: Why would Google want to help you stop paying them by ranking you higher for free?

But here's where paid ads *do* help: One of the lesser-known organic ranking factors is diversified traffic sources, and search engines pay attention to this strategy.

I heard a great line on the *Authority Hacker* podcast that sums it up perfectly: "Spammers don't spend money on ads." I laughed out loud when I heard that, because it's true.

Running paid ads signals to Google that you're a *real* business. It shows that people are visiting your site from multiple places, not just search results. To search engines, that's what a legitimate business looks like. One that gets traffic from:

- Organic search
- Organic social media
- Paid social media
- Email marketing
- Referral traffic (from other websites)
- Direct traffic (people typing your URL or scanning a QR code)

You don't need to do all of these, but showing up in *more than one place* makes your business look a lot more credible in Google's eyes. So no, paid ads won't directly boost your rankings… but they might just help build the *trust signals* that do.

CHAPTER 44

Organic Social

I HAVE A LOVE-HATE RELATIONSHIP with organic social media.

If you're not familiar with the term, "organic social" simply means posting on social media *without* paying for reach. It's free, but that doesn't mean it's easy, or enjoyable.

The Hate

Right after college, I landed an internship at a large traditional advertising agency. I worked in the social media department. My job? Collaborate with the content strategists to come up with concepts, shoot and edit content, write captions, pitch ideas to clients, and get it all published.

Sounds straightforward, right? Think of an idea. Create a post. Get approval. Hit publish. Nope. Not even close.

Here's what the process *actually* looked like:

- Brainstorm concepts
- Pitch them internally
- Get rejected and revise
- Re-pitch internally
- Finally get approval
- Go out into the world to shoot photos (with *my own phone*, by the way)
- Crop, edit, and send them in

- Get told to use stock photos instead
- Find stock photos
- Get approval from the client to purchase them
- Contact the production team
- Wait days for the photos to be purchased and sent over
- Add graphics and text
- Drop the images into a PowerPoint deck for another round of approvals
- Wait…
- Grit teeth as client rejects half the concepts
- Repeat the whole process
- Eventually schedule and post
- Monitor comments and DMs
- Create full-on monthly performance presentations (yes, actual slide decks, not just spreadsheets)

All of that. For a *single* social media post.

And what frustrated me the most? Half of it could've been avoided if I'd been allowed to buy a $50 stock photo on day one.

You like math? Do the numbers. Each post took *me* about 10 hours. That's not including the other team members involved.

Now here's the kicker. Despite how chaotic and inefficient that process was, my content performed *really well*. Better engagement than they'd seen in years. And no, I can't name names, but these were *huge*, household-name brands.

So… yeah. I quit. I left the agency, left the industry, and went to work on film sets. I was burnt out.

Eventually, I left *social media altogether*. No posts. No logins. Nothing.

The Love

We're living in the best time in human history to be a business owner. There are *so many* free ways to advertise what you sell, and social media is one of

the biggest. (SEO, too, but hey, we're talking about social right now.)

Back in 2017, one of my first freelance clients was a YouTuber with around 100,000 subscribers. His strategy? Give away 99.99% of his knowledge for free. People would pay *handsomely* for the rest.

And he was right.

Every month, I watched sales roll in. No SEO. No paid ads. Just a massive email list and nonstop organic content. (By the way, I cover email marketing in an upcoming chapter. Don't skip it.)

I was right back in the content creation world again. This time, it was different. I wasn't just managing posts, I was doing everything *except* appearing in the videos. I came up with concepts, titles, and thumbnails. Wrote YouTube descriptions. Turned videos into blog posts. Emailed his list. Chopped up clips for social. Wrote scripts. Scheduled content. I was a *machine.*

Over the years working with him, I watched his business explode. More views. More followers. More money. All from organic content. It was unreal.

But even after all that, I *still* wasn't convinced organic social could help *my* business. I had all the skills and experience, but I felt like I didn't have any "knowledge" to give away.

When I finally *did* have the knowledge, I tried the typical "one-photo-a-week-with-a-tip" approach. Shocker: No one reached out. No DMs. No calls. No sales. I was like, "This sucks," and quit social media… again. Back to referrals I went. It was easy. Do great work. Wait for clients to send others my way. Simple.

Then, in early 2023, when my business hit a major slump, I decided to give social one last shot. But this time, I went all in. I had just read *Jab, Jab, Jab, Right Hook* by GaryVee (I've mentioned this book a few times, and seriously, go read it).

I realized I didn't know anything about the current social media landscape. I still thought IGTV was a thing. What the hell was a "reel"? TikTok? Sounded like an app for clock collectors.

So I started posting videos. One every single day. And slowly, I got better. Learned the platforms. Built momentum. And… it worked. I grew a

massive following. Organic social media changed my life—and it didn't cost me a dime.

I go into the full story back in Chapter 17 (go read it if you skipped ahead!), but if you're reading this book, chances are social media played *some* role in how you found me. If it didn't… hey, go check out my content! I post daily tips and tutorials just like what you're reading here: **@heytony.agency**

CHAPTER 45

Paid Social

PAID SOCIAL IS EXACTLY WHAT IT SOUNDS LIKE: paying for ad placements on platforms like Facebook, Instagram, TikTok, Pinterest, and others. And when done right, it works *really* well. It's not rocket science either. In fact, the platforms have made it pretty easy to set up campaigns, choose who sees your ads, and track results.

If you have a budget, paid social is one of the fastest ways to grow your business. You can build an email list, get leads, drive conversions, and scale your revenue—all without waiting months for organic strategies to kick in. But... you need more than just a credit card.

You need a strategy. You need to understand your customer. You need to know how to write a hook, tell a story, create a scroll-stopping visual, and follow up with the right offer. And, let's be honest, you need a little mix of courage, patience, and pure gumption.

Sometimes the first ad flops. Sometimes you get zero sales. Sometimes it feels like you're just burning money. (Been there.) But if you can figure out what works, refine it, and scale it, paid social can completely transform your business.

We'll go deeper into paid ad strategies in the next few chapters, but for now just remember this: SEO is slow. Paid social is fast. Doing both at the same time? That's how you win.

The Power of Meta Platforms

The king of kings, the crème de la crème, the top of the heap when it comes to ads platforms is Meta (which includes Facebook and Instagram). Over 77% of the global population of internet users are using one of their platforms. And guess what? You can advertise to all of them!

Small town in Wisconsin? Check. Toronto? Check. How about London? You bet. Meta even has a version of Facebook called "Facebook Lite" which is an ultralightweight platform that lets people connect with their friends and family in countries where the internet is spotty and slow. If you didn't understand the reach that this platform had before reading this book, you should sure as hell know now!

And by the way, that's over 3 BILLION with a B monthly users. People are addicted to their platforms, for better or worse (let's face it, it's for the worse), and as business owners it's an amazing way to reach new customers.

I'm clearly gushing over Meta at this point, but it's all to tell you this: Their ads platform is by far the best out of any social media ads platform out there. So much so that other social media sites mimic, if not outright steal their layout, design, and functionality.

Understanding Ad Structure

There are 3 basic things you need to understand before you run ads on any platform.

1. **Campaigns:** These are basically the folder that holds your targeting and ads. For example, if you're running Black Friday ads, you'll likely have a campaign "folder" called "Black Friday 2025."
2. **Ad Set (or targeting):** Your ad set is where you determine WHO you want to see your ads. This could be age, interests, behaviors, geographic locations, or other first-party data like people who visited your website or engaged with you on social media.
3. **Ads:** This is what people refer to as the "creative." It's the text and images (or video) that make up your ads.

A Practical Example

Let's explore what a campaign could look like if you were an HVAC company.

CAMPAIGN	AD SET(S)	ADS
Black Friday 2025	People who are interested in "dogs"	– Ad 1 – Ad 2 – Ad 3 – Ad 4

It's a pretty simple setup, and will likely not yield great results. It's far too broad. The goal here is to find the people most likely to purchase your product or service.

> **Company:** Tony's HVAC Services
> **Problem:** A new HVAC company moved to town and they're eating up all the business. Tony and his company don't know what to do; they're struggling to grow. The phone used to ring constantly, but now they're lucky if they get a call or two a day.

So here's the thing about Tony. Last year was a really great year and he saved some money to use to advertise his business. He never used to do this, but last year he read a book called *Profit First* and put some money aside. *Profit First* is a really great book by the way—the strategies and tactics I learned in that book actually saved my business in 2023.

So here's what a basic campaign COULD look like for Tony's HVAC.

CAMPAIGN(S)	AD SET(S) – TARGETING	ADS
Spring AC checkup	**Targeting:** Retargeting **Includes:** Website visitors from the last year, their existing customer list, people who engaged with them on Meta's platforms. **Geo Location:** Their town + 10 miles	– Ad 1 – Ad 2 – Ad 3 – Ad 4
	Targeting: Geographic **Includes:** Anyone within their town + 10 miles **Excludes:** Previous customers, website visitors, and people who have engaged with them. **Geo Location:** Their town + 10 miles	– Ad 1 – Ad 2 – Ad 3 – Ad 4

The first ad set, "Retargeting," allows them to reach people who already know about them, bought from them, or engaged with them.

The second ad set, "Geographic," lets them reach everyone else. You can exclude certain groups from your targeting, which is recommended so you don't reach the same people with different messaging.

Messaging strategy

For people who already know about Tony's HVAC, the messaging might focus on how well their AC ran last summer during the heat wave, encouraging them to book an appointment ASAP to reserve their spot for routine maintenance.

For people who don't know about Tony's HVAC, the messaging could be about the importance of routine maintenance for their AC unit.

Budget considerations

If Tony wanted to blanket his entire city of 160,000 people, he would have to spend between $1,000 and $3,000. But Tony's no fool. He knows he doesn't need to reach people who likely don't own a home. So he decides to target people between the ages of 25 and 60.

He narrows his audience down to 43,000–100,000 people. Then, noting that most of his previous calls came from women, his audience size shrinks to between 57,800 and 68,000.

So for a mere $500, Tony can reach most of his target audience with a highly specific message.

Beyond advertising

Again, Tony's a pretty smart guy. So he takes his paid social strategy and turns it into an organic social media series hosted by one of his female technicians showing women how to do these checks themselves. Now you might be thinking, "But won't they just fix the problem themselves and not pay Tony?" Yes, some people will, but in reality, a majority of them will either give up, find it too difficult or frustrating, and call Tony!

That might seem far-fetched if you haven't taken a serious look at your organic social media strategy, but it really works. And I know firsthand that it does!

But Tony doesn't stop there. He sees that there's a demand for women who would rather have a female technician come into their home, so what does he do? He hires more female technicians, creating jobs and opportunities in an industry that historically has been male dominated.

Now this is just an example of one of the many ways Tony could go with his business and marketing. This example isn't meant to exclude any type of person, gender, race, etc. Except those who aren't home owners who could actually hire him. We definitely want to exclude those people!

Other Platforms

In this chapter we focused heavily on the Meta platforms, but you can rinse and repeat this strategy with any other social media platforms. The only difference would be who and how you can target your ideal customers, and the format of the ads you can run.

> **Side note:** The best time to advertise and grow the business is when things are REALLY good.

CHAPTER 46

Email Marketing

"EMAIL MARKETING IS DEAD"—idiots on the internet

Email marketing is one of my favorite types of marketing. Hell, you may even be reading this book because you found out about it from an email I sent you! Email has made me by far more money than all of the other platforms combined.

If you thought the Meta statistics in the previous chapter were impressive, check these out. There are almost 5 BILLION email users worldwide. According to studies,[1] the average return on investment for email marketing is $36 for every $1 spent (some studies say it's even higher than that!). With numbers like those, email marketing should be at the very top of your list.

The only problem with email marketing is that you need to have someone's email address to reach them. And email marketing software isn't free.

Getting Email Addresses: Lead Magnets

The first thing you're going to need is a lead magnet.

Lead magnets are something of value that you give away for free in exchange for an email address. These could be:

- Checklists
- Cheatsheets
- Ebooks

- Discount codes
- Free quotes
- Digital products
- Courses

Typically, Lead magnets are something that doesn't cost you any money to fulfill. Otherwise, you could go broke!

One of the best ways to create a lead magnet that converts is to give away what other people charge for. Your competition doesn't want to tell their customers about the ranking factors that go into SEO, for example? Create a free course explaining to them in easy-to-understand language exactly what those ranking factors are. Other people charge for this, I do not. So what if you end up pissing a couple people off; you're here to help your customers or clients, not your competitors.

One thing I will mention is that unless you plan to devalue yourself and your entire industry, do not work for free or get into a discount race to the bottom.

Ways to Collect Email Addresses

Social Media

Paid Social

This is the easiest way to get someone's email, but it costs money. The concept works like this: You run ads giving away something for free, and people give you their email address in return. What you're giving away needs to create so much value that someone is willing to give you their email address.

Organic Social Media

The same concept applies to organic social media as it does paid social media, but instead of paying to reach people, you can reach them for free. The caveat here is that you need to spend a lot of time and effort creating content and building an audience who sees you as a leader in your industry.

Currently, Instagram is the single best social media platform in the world to turn followers into email subscribers. This is because they allow third-party platforms like ManyChat to connect directly to your Instagram account and do certain things for you.

Website / SEO

This is another one of my favorite ways to grow my email list, and any smart marketer is doing this. And to top it all off, it's free. Well, you know, almost free. Social media is truly free, whereas with SEO you'll need software, website hosting, a domain, and probably a few plugins or themes.

Placing Lead Magnets

Your first thought might be to add a widget that says "Subscribe to Newsletter" on your website. Unfortunately, that doesn't work anymore.

You need to give people a good reason to give you their email address. Here are some common places to insert a lead magnet:

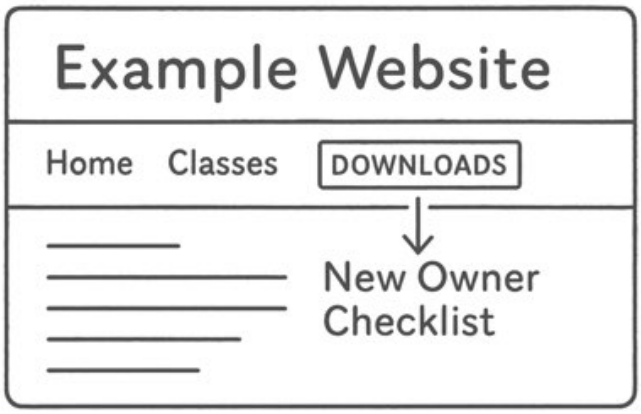
1. **Blog sidebar.** Not very effective. People have developed banner blindness.



2. **In content.** Placing your lead magnet signup between paragraphs can be very effective if it's related to the blog post or page.



3. **Navigation menu.** You can sometimes find lead magnets directly in a website's navigation menu. For example, a puppy training academy might have a tab that says "New Owner Checklist."



4. **Popups.**
    - Exit intent popups are most effective.
    - Can appear from bottom left or right without blocking content.
    - Only appear when a user is about to leave the website.



4. **Sticky banners.**
    - Often seen on product or service sites.
    - Offer something like “10% off your first order” or “Get a free quote.”

- Warning: Do NOT have both top and bottom sticky banners at once.



Nurturing Your Email List

This is my favorite part of the process—you get to be someone's best friend. They signed up for your lead magnet, so you know they're looking for YOUR help.

How do you do this? By creating an immense amount of value. When the opportunity presents itself, they'll be happy to buy from you.

Email frequency

You'll find the email frequency that works best through trial and error, but I would do no less than one email per week. Consider the length of your customers' buying cycle:

- More expensive products = longer buying cycle

- Emergency services = very short buying cycle

The point is to be so valuable that when they think of your niche, they think of you.

This is where you "nurture" your new subscribers. In this step, you'll give them so much free value for signing up to your list that they can't believe it. They will think of you as their pot of gold at the end of the rainbow, their unicorn, their four-leaf clover. They may not remember exactly how they got on your list, but they're ecstatic that they did.

You may be thinking: *Okay, so what's this additional value I have to give away now? I thought I just needed to create value with a lead magnet, get them on my list, and then get them to buy my thing. Haven't I given them enough? Do they want my kidney? My firstborn? When will this end?!*

Here's a saying I live by: People love to buy, but hate to be sold to. It's your job to make them feel like they're not being sold. *But how will I make money*, you're probably wondering? By creating such an immense amount of value that they'll be happy to buy from you when the opportunity presents itself. Even if they're not ready to buy, they won't mind your "salesy" emails because of all the value they've gotten from you.

Creating additional value doesn't have to be anything crazy. Let's go back to Tony's HVAC from earlier in the book. He could create value by reminding his subscribers once a quarter to change their air filter on their furnace. But that would only be 4 emails a year, hardly enough to nurture and gain trust. If you don't email them for 3 months, they'll likely forget why they signed up and unsubscribe.

Usually, the more expensive your product or service, the longer it will take someone to go from searching for information to making a purchase. However, if you have emergency services such as a plumber for backed-up drains, your buying cycle will be very short, regardless of the price.

That doesn't mean you shouldn't have an email list or that you don't need to nurture it. Do you want them to call YOU or your competitors the next time their basement is flooding? It's your job to keep your business top of mind.

Email marketing is not about selling; it's about developing a relationship of trust and nurturing a potential customer until they're ready to buy from you. And the great thing about email marketing is that you own the list—meaning that you don't need to worry about algorithm changes in order to contact your customers or leads.

CHAPTER 47

Tying It All Together

THIS IS MY FAVORITE PART of digital marketing: tying all of your efforts together. We've talked about SEO, paid media, social media, and email marketing. Alone they're all good strategies, but together they are greater than the sum of their parts.

Ultimately, you want someone to buy your product or service, so here's how you could use all of those platforms to work together.

Three Key Customer Actions

There are three actions you want your potential customers or clients to take and this goes for any business.

1. Buy from you right now.
2. Buy from you later.
3. Like you so much that they recommend you.

The Dream Scenario

After working with hundreds of businesses, I've noticed a consistent pattern: The most successful ones don't rely on just one strategy. They combine paid and organic marketing to bring in leads, convert them into customers, and turn those customers into raving fans.

Think of this like a machine: You're pouring people in at the top, and out the other end comes a steady stream of sales, referrals, and loyal customers. Here's how that machine works:

Filling the bucket (top of funnel)

The first step is bringing people *into* your world. The more channels you use to get in front of potential customers, the more water (aka leads) you'll have in your bucket.

Use a mix of organic search, paid search, organic social, and paid social to drive traffic to:

- Your products or services
- Lead magnets (free resources that capture emails or contact info)
- Helpful content that builds trust

The more touchpoints you create, the higher the chance that someone will say, *"Hey, I've seen this brand before."* That's where the magic begins.

Keeping people in your ecosystem (middle of funnel)

These are the people who already know you exist. They've visited your website, clicked on an ad, followed you on social media, or signed up for your email list. This is where nurturing comes into play.

Use retargeting to stay top-of-mind with:

- Website visitors
- Email subscribers
- Past customers
- Social media engagers

Tools you can use here:

- Retargeting ads (Meta, Google, TikTok, etc.)
- Lead magnets (again!)
- Product or service promotions

Use email marketing to:

- Nurture and build trust
- Deliver continuous value
- Stay in touch until they're ready to buy (or refer you)

Turning fans into customers (bottom of funnel)

Now that people know you, trust you, and see you as an expert, they're *primed* to buy. This is where fans become customers. At this stage, it's your game to lose.

You've already done the hard work:

- Delivered value
- Solved problems
- Built trust

Now it's about giving them the *nudge* they need to take action.

Use Retargeting to Seal the Deal

If someone visits a high-intent page on your website, like a service, product, or pricing page, but doesn't convert, that's your cue. You can retarget them with personalized ads that:

- Remind them of the product or service they viewed
- Offer a time-sensitive deal or discount
- Share testimonials or social proof to reduce hesitation

- Encourage them to book a call, consultation, or complete their purchase

This isn't guesswork, it's strategic follow-up based on their behavior.

Automate Follow-Ups with Email

Many email marketing tools (like Klaviyo, Mailchimp, or ActiveCampaign) let you set up behavior-based automations, but the person has to already be on your email list.

Here's how to use it effectively: Visited but didn't convert? If they land on your service page but don't fill out your contact form, send a follow-up email: "Need help deciding? Here's how we can make it easier…" or "We're offering a limited-time bonus this week, want in?"

Abandoned checkout? Trigger an email with: "You left something in your cart" or "Here's 10% off if you complete your order within 24 hours."

These gentle nudges can dramatically increase conversions, especially when the message feels personal and timely.

Don't Stop After the Sale

Making the first sale is *just the beginning*. Keep your customers engaged with content that:

- Helps them get the most out of their purchase
- Shows them complementary products or services
- Offers exclusive access, discounts, or loyalty perks
- Asks for feedback or referrals
- Tells them what's coming next

Because happy customers become repeat buyers. And repeat buyers become brand advocates.

CHAPTER 48

What's Next?

YOU'VE MADE IT TO THE END OF THIS BOOK, but the truth is this isn't the end. It's the starting line.

You now know how search engines actually work. You know how to structure your website, how to create content that people (and Google) actually care about, and how to position your business to get found. That knowledge only matters if you do something with it. Reading is easy. Implementation is rare. And rare is where results live.

Don't overcomplicate it. Don't wait until you "feel ready." Pick one thing you learned here and put it into action today. That's how momentum is built—not through grand gestures, but by stacking small wins over time.

And remember, this isn't just about traffic or rankings. It's about what those rankings represent: people. Every search is a human being looking for an answer, a solution, or a business they can trust. When you show up for them, consistently, you earn that trust. That's how you turn clicks into customers, and customers into a business that lasts.

We are living in the greatest time in history to be an entrepreneur. Never before has it been this possible to compete with the big guys, to build something meaningful, and to do it without waiting for permission. The tools are free. The opportunity is here. The only question left is whether you'll take it.

So go. Execute. Get found.

Glossary

.jpg

A common compressed image file format, best for photos.

.png

An image file format that supports transparency, often used for logos or graphics.

.webp

A modern image format with smaller file sizes than .jpg / .png.

301 redirect

A permanent redirect from one URL to another, preserving SEO value.

404 error

A “page not found” error when a URL doesn’t exist.

ActiveCampaign

An email marketing and automation platform.

Ad campaign

The overall structure in an ad platform that contains ad sets and ads.

Ad sets

Groups of ads that share targeting, budget, and placement settings.

Ads

The individual creative pieces shown to users (text, image, or video).

Ahrefs

An SEO tool for keyword research, backlink analysis, and site audits.

AI

Artificial intelligence; computer systems that simulate human thinking and decision-making.

AI-generated overviews

Search results summaries written by artificial intelligence.

Algorithm

A set of rules platforms use to show content to their users. Search engines use one of these to rank web pages.

Alt text

Descriptive text added to images for accessibility and SEO.

Anchor text

The clickable text in a hyperlink.

AnswerThePublic

A keyword research tool that shows common search questions.

Attributes

Extra details about an element (like image size or product color) in code or listings.

Avalanche technique

An SEO strategy of ranking for easy, low-volume keywords first, then moving to harder ones.

Backlinks

Links from other websites back to your site.

Bing Places

Microsoft's local business listing platform, like Google Business Profile.

Bing Webmaster Tools

Microsoft's free suite for monitoring and optimizing a site's performance in Bing search.

Black hat SEO

Manipulative tactics that violate search engine guidelines (e.g., spammy links); risky and penalized.

Bluehost

A web hosting provider known for shared WordPress hosting.

Bounce rate / High bounce rate

Percent of sessions with only one page view; high = visitors leave without engaging.

Breadcrumbs

Navigational links showing a page's position in the site hierarchy.

BrightLocal

Local SEO toolset for listings, reviews, audits, and rank tracking.

Broken links

Links that lead to missing pages (404s) or invalid URLs.

Browser caching

Storing site files locally so returning visitors load pages faster.

Bullets

List markers that make information scannable and easier to read.

Buttons

Clickable user interface elements that trigger actions (e.g., "Buy," "Subscribe").

Call to action (CTA)

A prompt telling users what to do next (e.g., "Book a demo").

Canonical tags

HTML tags pointing to the preferred URL to avoid duplicate content issues.

Canva

Online design tool for graphics, social posts, and simple layouts.

CapCut

Video editing app popular for short-form social video.

Category page

A page that groups related products or articles under a topic.

ChatGPT

An AI chatbot that generates and edits text and images based on prompts.

Claude

An AI assistant by Anthropic for writing, analysis, and question and answer (Q&A).

Clickbait

Sensational headlines designed to attract clicks, often over-promising.

Content

Any information published on your site: text, images, video, etc.

Core Web Vitals

Google's user-experience metrics (loading, interactivity, visual stability) that impact rankings.

Crawl

When search engines scan a website's pages to index them.

Crawl depth

How many clicks it takes to reach a page from the home page.

CrocWeb

A Canadian web hosting provider.

Cumulative Layout Shift (CLS)

A Core Web Vital measuring how much a page layout shifts unexpectedly while loading.

Dofollow

Standard links that pass SEO authority to the linked page.

Domain authority (DA)

A metric (coined by Moz) estimating how likely a site is to rank.

Edits (the app)

A free video editing tool by Meta.

Email marketing

Using email to nurture leads, engage audiences, or drive sales.

Embedding

Adding external content (like a video, map, or form) directly onto a page.

Evergreen

Content that stays relevant over time.

External links

Links from your site pointing to other websites.

Footer

The bottom section of a web page, usually with links and contact info.

Funnel

The stages a customer goes through from awareness to purchase.

Funnel pages

Web pages designed for each step of the funnel (landing, checkout, thank you).

GA4

Google Analytics 4, Google's website and app tracking platform.

Gap analysis

Identifying missing content or strategies compared to competitors.

GoDaddy

A domain registrar and web hosting company.

Google Business Profile

Free Google listing for businesses to appear in maps and local search.

Google+

Google's discontinued social media platform (shut down in 2019).

Guest posting

Publishing an article on another website to gain exposure and backlinks.

H1 tag

The main heading of a web page; signals the primary topic.

H2 tag

A subheading under the H1; organizes content structure.

Header

The top section of a web page, usually with logo and navigation.

Heading tags

HTML tags (H1–H6) that define page structure and hierarchy.

High conversion

When a page or campaign turns a high percentage of visitors into leads / customers.

High intent

Searches that show strong buying or action-ready signals (e.g., “buy running shoes”).

High-authority sites

Trusted websites with strong rankings and backlinks (e.g., major news outlets).

Hosting

A service that stores your website files and makes them accessible online.

Image alt text

Written descriptions of images for accessibility and SEO.

Image links

Hyperlinks applied to an image instead of text.

Infographics

Visual graphics that present data or concepts in an easy-to-understand format.

Instagram

A social media platform for sharing photos, videos, and reels.

Interaction to Next Paint (INP)

A Core Web Vital measuring how quickly a page responds to a user’s first interaction (formerly First Input Delay, FID).

Internal links

Links from one page of your site to another.

Keyword cannibalization

When multiple pages target the same keyword, competing with each other.

Keyword density

The percentage of times a keyword appears compared to total words on a page.

Keyword gap

Keywords competitors rank for that your site does not.

Keyword research

Finding search terms people use so you can target them with content.

Keyword stuffing

Overusing keywords unnaturally on a page to manipulate rankings.

Klaviyo

An email and SMS marketing platform for e-commerce brands.

Landing page

A focused page designed to capture leads or drive a single action.

Largest Contentful Paint (LCP)

A Core Web Vital measuring how quickly the main content loads.

Lead magnets

Free offers (like guides or checklists) used to collect contact info.

Link

A connection from one web page to another, internal or external.

Link equity

The SEO value that passes from one page to another through links.

Link insertion

Adding a backlink into existing content on another site.

Link juice

Informal term for the ranking power passed through links.

List

A collection of items presented in bullet points or numbered format.

Long-tail keywords

Longer, more specific search phrases with lower competition.

Looker Studio

Google's free tool for creating interactive reports and dashboards.

Low-level authority sites

Websites with little trust or ranking power.

Low search volume keywords

Keywords that few people search for each month.

Mailchimp

An email marketing and automation platform.

Main menu

The primary navigation menu on a website.

Map Pack

Google's top local search results, shown with a map.

Meta / Meta platforms

The company behind Facebook, Instagram, and WhatsApp.

Meta description

A short text summary of a page shown in search results.

Mid-level authority sites

Websites with moderate trust and ranking power.

Mobile-friendly

A site that works well and looks good on mobile devices.

NAP

Name, Address, Phone number; key info for local SEO consistency.

Navigational links

Links that help users move around a website (menus, sidebars, footers).

Negative SEO

Harmful tactics used to hurt a site's rankings (e.g., spammy backlinks).

Next-gen image formats

Modern image types (like .webp or .avif) that load faster than .jpg / .png.

Nofollow

A link attribute that tells search engines not to pass SEO value.

Nofollow backlink

A backlink marked "Nofollow," providing traffic but little SEO benefit.

Off-page SEO

Actions outside your site (like backlinks) that affect rankings.

On-page SEO

Optimizing content and elements *on* your site for search engines.

Organic social

Unpaid social media posts that reach audiences naturally.

Orphan pages

Pages with no internal links pointing to them.

Over-optimization

Using too many SEO tactics (like keyword stuffing), hurting rankings.

Page authority (PA)

Moz metric predicting how well a specific page can rank.

Page indexing

When a search engine stores a web page in its database to show in results.

Paid search

Online ads that show in search engine results.

Paid social

Ads run on social media platforms.

Plugins

Add-ons that extend website or software functionality (common in WordPress).

Private Blog Networks (PBNs)

Networks of sites created to build backlinks; against Google's rules.

Product page

A page showcasing a specific product, usually with details and a buy option.

Quality

How useful, trustworthy, and relevant content is to users and search engines.

Quality assurance (QA)

Checking a site or content for errors before publishing.

Rank higher

Improving a web page's position in search results.

Readability

How easy content is to understand and scan.

Reciprocal linking

When two sites agree to link to each other.

Referring domains

Unique websites that link to your site.

Rich snippets

Enhanced search results with extra info (stars, FAQs, images).

Robots.txt

A file telling search engines which pages they can or can't crawl.

Schema markup

Code that helps search engines understand page content.

Scripts

Small pieces of code that add functionality (like tracking or forms).

Search engine optimization (SEO)

A marketing strategy to attract more visitors to your website.

Search volume

Average number of searches a keyword gets monthly.

Semrush

An SEO tool for research, audits, and tracking.

Semrush Local

Semrush's tools for managing local SEO and listings.

Server

The computer system that hosts and delivers your website online.

Service page

A web page describing a business service.

Shopify

An e-commerce platform for building online stores.

Short-tail keyword

A broad, often competitive keyword (e.g., “shoes”).

Site audit

A review of a website’s SEO health and technical issues.

Sitemaps

Files that list website pages to help search engines crawl them.

Squarespace

A website builder with drag-and-drop templates.

StumbleUpon

A now-defunct site that let users discover random web pages.

Table of contents

A list of sections in a page or article for easy navigation.

Technical SEO

Optimizing site structure, speed, and crawlability for search engines.

TikTok

A short-form video social media platform.

Title tag

The main title shown in search results and browser tabs.

Traffic

The number of visitors to a website.

Ubersuggest

An SEO tool for keyword research and audits.

URLs

The web addresses of pages (e.g., https://example.com/page).

Vimeo

A video hosting and streaming platform.

Word count

The number of words in a piece of content.

WordPress

A popular website and blog-building platform.

Yoast

A WordPress plugin for SEO optimization.

YouTube

A video-sharing platform owned by Google.

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About the Author



Matt Diamante is the founder of HeyTony, a digital marketing agency helping small businesses and entrepreneurs get found online through SEO and content strategy. Over the past decade, he's taught more than 30,000 students how to grow their businesses using simple, actionable marketing techniques. When he's not breaking down Google algorithms or sharing insights with his 500,000+ followers, Matt's helping clients rank #1 for the keywords that matter most—or hanging out at home in Ontario with his wife, Ali, and their two dogs. *Get Found* is his first book.

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